

365 LEVEL STEPS



MASONIC MEDITATIONS
FOR
EVERY DAY OF THE YEAR

JONTI MARKS

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Level Steps**

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Every Day of the Year**

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by

Jonti Marks

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**This book is dedicated to the glory of
The Great Architect of the Universe;
to the Head of All True Freemasons
and to my Brothers and Sisters
in ‘all corners of the world,’
Masons and non-Masons alike**

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Introduction.

This book brings together the four previous volumes of 'Masonic Meditations' and presents them, sometimes in a slightly edited form, all together for the first time.

The first book, 'Level Steps' was written specifically with Craft Lodges, or what are sometimes known as 'Blue Lodges' in mind.

The second book, 'Hidden Depths' was written for Companions of The Holy Royal Arch. In English Freemasonry, this Order is considered to be an extension of Blue Lodge Masonry and the general wisdom is that the ceremonies and knowledge imparted are, symbolically at least, a completion of the journey of a Master Mason.

If you are reading this book and you are not a member of a Royal Arch Chapter, some of the quotations and references may be strange and unfamiliar to you. The underlying messages will not, however, and I am sure that there is much to be gained from studying these meditations in the same way that I am certain that people who are not Freemasons will gain something from reading the book as a whole.

If the sections that relate to the Royal Arch pique your interest, however, then I encourage you to take this next step in your Masonic journey and I shall be glad to have helped you along your way.

The final two volumes, 'Still Waters 1 & 2' were written in a more general vein, with 'Masonry Universal' in mind. They were first published alongside the full (though sometimes abridged) text of the Psalms which inspired them although this is not the case in this current volume.

In this book I have mixed the four volumes up as far as was possible, mainly to give variety to each day's reading. The main exception to this is the series of 15 Psalms, starting with 120, which follow a progressive train of thought and which, I felt, were best kept together. I have also left all of the Psalms in their usual numerical order.

I'd like to mention some of my sources. I am aware that although the basic principles of Freemasonry are universal, there are many differences in the way we work our rituals and many differences within the rituals themselves. I have been criticised in the past for getting the ritual 'wrong' so I would like to clarify: all quotations relating to Craft rituals come from the workings of Lodge Scotia, 1008 S.C. which meets in Nairobi, Kenya and of which I am a life member.

Quotations from the Royal Arch come from the current ritual of the Supreme Grand Chapter of England. Quotations from the Antient Charges and other Masonic sources mostly come from the Book of Constitutions of U.G.L.E. Please forgive any glaring discrepancies between my ritual and yours. It is often in these differences that new insights and understandings can be found.

Biblical quotations in all e-book editions are from the King James Version.

The writings of other authors (including ‘Anon’) are taken from ‘A Treasury of Masonic Thought’ edited by Carl Glick and published by Robert Hale, London. Although none of the works are copyright as such, I gratefully acknowledge the work of Carl Glick in collecting together such a wealth of Masonic material and, of course, the work of the original writers themselves.

I wrestled with the question of whether or not to put dates in this book. In the end I did, but please don’t wait for January 1st to come around before beginning to use it! Make a note of today’s date and work your way around the year - it’s just as satisfying and it means you do not have to wait to begin the habit of sitting quietly for a few minutes every day, immersed in the teachings and mysteries of our beautiful Craft.

I wish you well as you begin this year of meditation and contemplation. May your daily advancement in Masonic knowledge be helpful, deep and meaningful.

May the Great Architect guide and protect you on your way.

JAM
July 2019

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January 1

‘Enter in God’s Name, Fearing No Evil.’

**Inscription on the Temple Door,
Freemason’s Hall, Nairobi, Kenya**

When we enter Freemasonry, we take a great deal on trust. Although we may have read something about the institution or spoken to friends - at least our proposer and seconder - there is a moment of great aloneness just before we enter the Temple to receive the benefit of Initiation. It is a moment when all of our privileges of rank and fortune in the ‘outside’ world avail us nothing. It is a moment of doubt, perhaps even of fear, when we wonder, deep down, what we are getting into. Will Freemasonry be all that we expect? Is it really the noble and honourable institution it professes to be or are we about to enter on a path that will actually take us away from our chosen course of self-betterment? Thinking back on that moment, we can discover that doubt, questioning, is a necessary step that drives us back on to the bedrock of our faith and trust.

And through faith, in God’s name, we move forward, secure and confident that it is He who guides our steps to this door, at this time.

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January 2

But his delight is in the law of the LORD; and in his law doth he meditate day and night.

Psalm 1

When we commit ourselves to the path of Freemasonry, we are, in fact, committing to a lifelong journey that will inevitably lead us towards goodness and Godliness.

Whatever the details of our particular belief-system, whatever religious or spiritual path we follow, Freemasonry enhances and decorates our faith. It is a rich and beautiful cloak that we wear over our daily practice to protect and keep it strong. Like a fine coat worn over our best clothes to protect against heavy weather, Freemasonry adds without ever taking away.

And, in putting on that protective cloak, we turn away from behaviours and thoughts that keep us tied to our earth-bound fellows and we turn our face to the long uphill path that leads to Truth and Light and Love.

January 3

‘May God grant further aid and light to keep us from standing in our own way.’

Goethe

We can never say that our knowledge of the Craft is complete because there is always so much more to learn and understand. But it is the case that the Master Mason’s degree completes the story around which the Craft is structured – the building of the Temple at Jerusalem. How sad, then, that the story ends so inconclusively, so badly. Our secrets are lost, our Master is slain and we are left to contemplate the fragility of our lives and the certainty of our own mortality. But there is more to come. The Craft teaches us much about ourselves, our world and our relationships with each other. The Royal Arch seeks to deepen this understanding and to encourage us to consider all of these things in the light of eternity; to see ourselves in relation to our primary relationship with our Creator. To be successful, we need ‘further aid and light’; we need to be open and to trust ourselves – with God’s help – to follow the right path.

January 4

*I will declare the decree: the LORD hath said unto me,
Thou art my Son; this day have I begotten thee.*

Psalm 2

When we first set our feet on the Masonic path we can find ourselves in a lonely place. In many cases we are creating a divide, not only between ourselves and the 'outside' world, but we are also drawing a line in our own lives between what has gone before and what will come after. We have reached a point where we are ready to take responsibility for our own development as human beings – moral and spiritual – and reject the materialistic consumerism that threatens to destroy us all.

When we chart a course against the prevailing winds of the world, we encounter rough seas and many storms. Anger, hatred, mistrust – these have plagued Freemasons throughout their history and on many levels, both visible and invisible and they may raise their ugly heads to plague us even now.

But let us not worry. We know that a world of open-hearted support lies before us. The promise of universal brotherhood becomes stronger and more real with every step we take and we know, deep down, that our strength is founded on something lasting and infinitely reliable.

January 5

'I would not give much for your Freemasonry unless it can be seen. Lamps do not talk but they shine...So let your actions shine out your Masonry. Let the main sermon of your life be illustrated by your conduct, and it shall not fail to be illustrious.'

Anon.

We have a duty to our much maligned Brotherhood to be exemplary in our conduct, for we are the visible face of Freemasonry. Freemasonry will be judged by what we, as Freemasons, do. We should be mindful of this every day, every moment and so order our actions as to be a credit to the institution of which we claim to be so proud.

But that is not all. Like any system designed for the betterment of humankind, Freemasonry is useless unless it is lived. The precepts that it teaches have no meaning until they find expression in our daily actions. The true secret of Masonry is to be found here: in a life well lived, in a heart devoid of all malice and in a conscience clear in the knowledge that, 'I have tried my best.'

January 6

LORD, how are they increased that trouble me! Many are they that rise up against me.

But thou, O LORD, art a shield for me; my glory, and the lifter up of mine head.

Psalm 3

The troubles of the world can seem so overpowering, so overwhelming, that we wonder how we can raise ourselves out of the pitfalls into which we so often stumble. Finances, health, relationships, work – all of these things can go wrong at any time and leave us feeling alone, abandoned and lost.

As Freemasons, we aim to practise equanimity in adversity, knowing that we are held and supported, not only by our Brotherhood, but also by our firm faith. The willingness to surrender our troubles to a Higher Power and thus to free ourselves from their hold over us is one of the greatest gifts of faith. This world is full of darkness but we know that it is also full of light. It is a wise person who can accept both joy and sorrow with a degree of acceptance and calm, knowing that, in time, all things pass, all things arise and fall away again, and only that which is true and real will last.

January 7

*'He that has light within his own clear breast
May sit i' the center, and enjoy clear day:
But he that hides a dark soul and foul thoughts
Benighted walks under the midday sun;
Himself is his own dungeon.'*

John Milton.

Within the Royal Arch degree there is so much symbolism associated with reaching down into the darkness to find light. It is worth remembering that sometimes the darkest places in our lives are those we create for ourselves, through negative thinking and by allowing ourselves to dwell on the struggles and sufferings that life throws in our way. Life can be hard, there is no doubt about that, but it is very clear that our attitude to the difficulties that beset us determines whether we walk in darkness or light. As Freemasons, we profess adherence to the three principle virtues of Faith, Hope and Love. These three are proof enough against the darkness. With them we can dare to delve into the depths of our souls to free ourselves from the dungeons of our own making.

January 8

Thou hast put gladness in my heart, more than in the time that their corn and their wine increased.

I will both lay me down in peace, and sleep: for thou, LORD, only makest me dwell in safety.

Psalm 4

As Freemasons, we have tried and trusted supports to turn to when things are hard. The practical and unquestioning support of our Brethren and the rock of our faith in God both provide us with solace, comfort, help and guidance when we need it. But it is important that we do not forget to look to our own hearts to find solutions to our problems, too. If we are completely honest with ourselves – as honest as we aim to be with others – we must acknowledge that some of the responsibility for our own suffering lies with ourselves. Whether it is something we have caused to happen through our own acts of commission or omission, or merely a negative attitude to what has befallen us beyond our control, there is no doubt that we have within ourselves most of the cures for our own ills.

So, while it is vital that we learn to trust our Brothers and have faith in our God, it is also important that we look within and learn to trust ourselves.

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January 9

*The three Great Lights will guide our steps
Through life's uncertain way,
And bring us safe at length to see
The bright eternal day.*

Anon.

The three 'Great Lights' are the Square, the Compasses and the Volume of the Sacred Law, the Bible. The Square represents, and is almost synonymous with, good conduct. It is within the Square that the whole Craft is said to be ordered. The Compasses express the bounds of our daily lives, the full circle of our actions. The Volume of the Sacred Law, being considered the word of God, is a clear source of inspiration and instruction as to how we should try to order our own existence. All this we know, but think for a moment on the significance of their positions when we first see them. The Compasses lie within the confines of the Square and are dominated by it. Both of these things rest resolutely on an open page of the Volume of the Sacred Law. These 'Great Lights' and the lessons they teach are surely enough to see us safely through to that 'bright eternal day.'

January 10

But let all those that put their trust in thee rejoice: let them ever shout for joy, because thou defendest them: let them also that love thy name be joyful in thee.

For thou, LORD, wilt bless the righteous; with favour wilt thou compass him as with a shield.

Psalm 5

To live every day - ideally every moment - in conscious awareness of our relationship to our Creator; to temper our every waking thought with the remembrance of our own frailty and our ultimate mortality, these are foundation stones upon which a life of meaning and worth may be built.

It is not until we fully accept the reality of our own death that we will fully begin to live: this is one of the greatest lessons of the 3rd Degree. And while the idea of our own mortality is frightening to fully contemplate, we have, as ever, our faith to hold us up. The 'promise of futurity' mentioned in our ritual allows us to rest secure in the knowledge that, although that future might be veiled from us, it is there and we trust that we will be kept from harm. Freemasonry offers us the opportunity to be good, to be 'righteous' and we believe unhesitatingly that righteousness will be rewarded.

That certainty, that unwavering faith, is our shield.

January 11

Oh thou, who hast called us out of darkness to be bearers of light; we beseech Thee to make us helpers in the world. Take away from us the love of ease, and fear of men. Show us the simple things that we can do to help our neighbours to be good.

Anon.

Having taken the first steps towards banishing the darkness in our own lives, as Freemasons we are called upon to do more. A deepening knowledge of what it is to be human – a growing understanding of ourselves as pilgrims on a path that leads, ultimately, to unity and peace in their most profound sense – carries with it a great responsibility. Those who carry the torches must hold them high to light the way for others. And so we must commit to live by the virtues we profess to admire. That doesn't mean we must become proselytisers for Freemasonry, trying to convert everyone to our way of thinking. On the contrary, it calls upon each one of us to live quietly and virtuously, a friend to all and an example of how simple goodness can spread from heart to heart.

January 12

O LORD, rebuke me not in thine anger, neither chasten me in thy hot displeasure.

Have mercy upon me, O LORD; for I am weak:

Psalm 6

None of us is perfect and we all have regrets in life: things we did, things we didn't do; things we said or didn't say; opportunities and connections missed and squandered. Worst of all are those moments when we know what the right thing to do is, but, often through fear, we fail to do it. In those moments we can feel such a separation from the centre of ourselves, such a distance from God, that we feel crushed, abandoned and lost.

As Freemasons we strive always to be the best we can be in every moment and we are sustained and supported in this by our faith. But we are also encouraged by a system that acknowledges that we are human and that sometimes we do not live up to the high standards to which we aspire. Life is short and the silent grave awaits us all. In this certain knowledge we must learn to trust that we will be held up and comforted and that, in the end, all will be well.

January 13

Therefore when we build, let us think that we build forever. Let it not be for the present delight, nor for the present use alone. Let it be such work as our descendants will thank us for.

John Ruskin

As Freemasons, we know that we are not concerned with the building of any physical structure, yet we must be aware that we are trying to build something. What? Something less solid than a building, obviously, but hopefully of more value and, possibly, longer lasting: a better self and, thereby, a better world; a world free from the material madness and greed that grip it at this time. We work for the promotion of values that are beyond price and that are truly timeless and eternal. So if you are troubled, as we all are, by the pressures and disappointments of daily life, think for a moment of the Spiritual values that the Craft aims to inculcate within us. Think of the lasting benefits to your children and your children's children of helping to make the world more sane, more peaceful, more full of brotherly love.

January 14

Judge me, O LORD, according to my righteousness, and according to mine integrity that is in me.

Psalm 7

While the idea that we should ‘let go and let God’ is one that is central to our sense of ourselves as Freemasons, we also understand ourselves to be co-creators of that perfect world of peace and harmony that is our goal and our dream. Our obligation and our duty in the world is to act at all times in the consciousness of our belief in the brotherhood and sisterhood of all of humanity; to bring harmony where there is strife; to relieve suffering; to comfort those who are in distress; to do all we can to actualize the philosophy to which we have subscribed.

And while we are committed to action, we also recognise that, without our belief in God, our actions have no meaning and no authority. We must act, of course we must, but we must also understand that, through us, God acts. Through us, God is known.

Freemasons are committed to a better world and a better life for all, regardless of race, sex, sexuality, belief or any other potentially dividing factors. Freemasons understand that we are all the beloved children of one God and so we work only for the common good. We do not presume to judge or punish, only to praise and encourage.

All the rest, we can leave to Providence.

January 15

Then wrought Bezaleel and Aholiab, and every wise hearted man, in whom the Lord put wisdom and understanding to know how to work all manner of work for the service of the sanctuary, according to all that the Lord had commanded.

Exodus 36:1-3

All of us have to work in one way or another. Even the richest or most relaxed among us have to make some effort everyday to clothe and feed ourselves; to put a roof over our heads; to care for our family, friends and wider connections. As Masons we understand the need to work in different spheres of life – spiritual as well as material – to be fully rounded ourselves. But the wise-hearted know that work done in a spirit of service is always more satisfying than work done for selfish reasons. Freemasons are givers, that much is certainly true, but it is worth remembering that giving is not just about money and charity. If all of our work in this world were done with the service of others – and, through others, God – in mind, how sweet our work would be.

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January 16

When I consider thy heavens, the work of thy fingers, the moon and the stars, which thou hast ordained;

What is man, that thou art mindful of him? and the son of man, that thou visitest him?

Psalm 8

There are times when we need to stop what we are doing, when we must step back from our constant striving, our busy-ness and look around us. The world is beautiful and full of wonder and it is vital for our continued well-being, inner peace and mental health that we take the time to appreciate it. Never underestimate the benefit of a walk in the park or a day in the country. If that's not possible, just look out of the window or up at the sky. Contemplate, just for a moment the expanse of the heavens and the complexity and variety of life here on earth. How can we not be filled with a sense of awe and wonder at this daily miracle that we call life?

And consider us – human beings – our ability to choose between right and wrong, our ability to be conscious of our thoughts, our gift of free will. How wondrous we are and what a responsibility we carry!

In these moments of realisation are to be found the keys to our true relationship to each other and to our Creator. Part of our duty as Freemasons is to look for opportunities to experience those moments and to share them, as far as is possible, with others.

January 17

'What are you doing?' a man asked three labourers beside a building under construction.

The first man replied, 'Stone cuttin'.'

The second smiled. 'Puttin' in time until a better job comes along.'

The third man waited a moment and then said simply, 'I'm building a cathedral.'

Anon

It is true that, with all the important things in life, we get out of them what we put in. Freemasonry is no exception. Our most mundane chores can be exalted to the level of Spirituality if we approach them in the right frame of mind. In the same way, our highest aspirations can be brought low if we bring a grudging spirit to the attaining of them. We must all become involved in drudgery to survive in this modern world of ours, but never forget that, with the right attitude, a well-ironed sock or shirt is as fulfilling an accomplishment as a difficult piece of ritual well delivered or a good deed unselfishly done.

January 18

And they that know thy name will put their trust in thee: for thou, LORD, hast not forsaken them that seek thee.

Psalm 9

One of our most important responsibilities as Freemasons has nothing – or very little – to do with what goes on within our Lodges. While our ceremonies and the times we spend together are important in so far as they inspire and strengthen us, they are of little value if we don't carry what we learn into our everyday lives. The truth of God's love for all, the truth that we are all God's children, the understanding that we are all part of one life, united and indivisible: that's what we are called upon to demonstrate.

It doesn't mean that we have to talk about it; it doesn't mean we have to impose our understanding of the world on others – we can trust God to do that when the time is right – it simply means that we must act in the light of what we know. Freemasons are always there to help and support; to offer a kind word and a helping hand because we know that it is through our response to the suffering and distress of others that the validity of our path is judged.

When we act from the highest that is within us, we cannot help but shine a light on our Creator's 'marvellous works.

January 19

Reveal to us the wavering ranks of those that are struggling upward that we may cheer and support our comrades unknown.

Anon.

We can never really know the innermost secrets of another person's heart; their hopes and fears, their joys and desires, their successes and failures, their dreams and aspirations. All we can know is ourselves and that is all we can hope to work on, certainly in terms of our own moral and spiritual evolution. But we can sometimes recognise a fellow pilgrim and we can cheer and support them on their journey. And more than that: by living lives that demonstrate our commitment to those higher values we profess to admire, we can offer support and encouragement to unknown comrades who may pass us by unseen and unheard but who may glance up and recognise in us something that gives them the strength and determination to continue along their path. This is something that we must take on trust but we must never underestimate its power.

January 20

Thou hast seen it; for thou beholdest mischief and spite, to requite it with thy hand: The LORD is King for ever and ever:

Psalm 10

It's hard to understand sometimes quite how the world works. When we are committed to a path of service, founded on a firm belief in the concept of Universal Brotherhood, it can be difficult to see good people struggling and suffering while others, who seem to live only for themselves, prosper. The question of how we confront such injustice in the world is an important one. We are enjoined to refrain from discussing both politics and religion in our meetings, and yet both of these things have a profound bearing on the problem.

We are not revolutionaries, that much is clear, but neither are we silent and indifferent bystanders to injustice, poverty and suffering. Our response – a beautifully Masonic one – must be to relieve suffering where we see it, irrespective of the sufferer's race or creed or whatever. We stand firm for the values we believe in – by exemplifying them in all our words and deeds – and thus we anticipate and subvert any revolutionary impulses by acting with love and kindness to all those who suffer. At the same time we encourage responsibility and selflessness in those who have power to make changes.

Perhaps we are revolutionaries after all!

January 21

'What do you mean by Masonry?'

'We mean that great and universal science which includes almost every other...but we have more particularly studied that part which teaches us our duty to God and to our neighbour, and a knowledge of ourselves.'

Ceremony of Exaltation

True self-knowledge has always been one of the highest aspirations of mankind. Through endless religions and philosophies we have tried to understand our universe and our part within it. Masonry is no different from other systems in this respect and points to the eternal truths that underlie all systems. In this extract there is a clear link between our duties to God and neighbour and with self-knowledge. This surely points to that most profound truth, the interconnection of all life. We cannot know ourselves if we neglect these duties because it is in their very performance that truth is revealed. Humility, reverence, love. These are our nature and, like a fragile plant, they will not grow in a desert of self-centred existence.

January 22

The LORD is in his holy temple, the LORD'S throne is in heaven: his eyes behold, his eyelids try, the children of men.

Psalm 11

All of life evolves and moves forward. This is especially true when it comes to the development of human consciousness and the maturity of our faith. But we can go further and, as Freemasons, we are committed to doing so. When we place God outside of ourselves, on a throne, in Heaven, we look to Him to right our wrongs, to fight our battles and to see that justice is done; we relate to Him as children: needy and dependent.

When we place God in our hearts, however, we begin to step into our true relationship with Him, as co-creators of a better world – a world where we see Him in the hearts of all our Brothers and Sisters. We begin to take responsibility for our own world. We begin to stand up against injustice and look to remedy it from the depths of our understanding of the true nature of brotherly love.

The Temple that we Freemasons are building is not a physical one. The Temple of heaven exists, we believe that and we understand it each in our own way; but the Temple we seek to build in our daily lives is the one in our hearts, and we must make it fit to contain the eternal presence of the Most High.

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January 23

I pray you with all earnestness to prove and to know within your hearts that things lovely and righteous are possible for those who believe in their possibility, and who determine that for their part they will make each day's work contribute to them.'

John Ruskin

Just as we often carry with us our own darkness and imprison ourselves in our own dungeons, so do we also have the power within ourselves to create delight and freedom. How profound that loveliness and righteousness are linked here. We all know that material success alone does not bring happiness, does not constitute 'rightness.' But what does bring happiness? What does feel right for us, in the depths of our souls? We know the answer to those questions, too. Let us make the commitment to work every day for the common good; to act in ways that contribute to the welfare of all. Let us believe wholeheartedly that lovely and righteous things are possible for us if we behave in ways that will allow them to grow.

January 24

Help, LORD; for the godly man ceaseth; for the faithful fail from among the children of men.

They speak vanity every one with his neighbour: with flattering lips and with a double heart do they speak.

Psalm 12

The values that Freemasonry promotes are sometimes so at odds with the values of the world that we can feel that we are surrounded by a kind of madness. How can it be that we, who are steeped in the understanding that all of life is one life, are able to function in societies that divide brother from brother; that allow war, hunger, disease, hatred and destruction to prevail? We go to our Lodges and we glorify the concepts of equality and the brotherhood of all humanity, but beyond those Lodge walls, we are thrown into a chaos of conflict. How do we hold on to our equilibrium?

Well, we have our faith, for one thing. Masonically speaking, we know that at the core of that circle of faith there is a point of stillness from which clarity and calmness emanate. That point within the circle represents the core of ourselves, the spiritual, God-attuned reality of who and what we are. Freemasonry gives us the tools to look within ourselves to find that still centre and, with practice, we can learn to act from it, to retreat to it and to draw from it all the resources we need to cope with the vagaries and difficulties of the outside world.

January 25

...in proportion to our capacities, we attain to a greater or lesser degree of perfection.

Second Lecture, Introductory Address

Among the many lessons that Freemasonry teaches are some that are very simple and universally applicable. The idea that we achieve results in proportion to the amount of effort we make is one such teaching. But Freemasonry is not about material gain, so while the same principle holds true of our jobs, our family life or our social standing, in Freemasonry it is elevated to the sphere of Spiritual endeavour.

‘As you sow, so shall you reap.’ It is a concept that has been with us for two thousand years. Use it to attain the highest degree of perfection possible.

January 26

How long wilt thou forget me, O LORD? for ever? how long wilt thou hide thy face from me?

Psalm 13

There's no such thing as an easy ride in life. Sometimes we can look at others who appear to be so much better off than us, whether in terms of money, work, health, happiness or anything and everything else – from the house they live in to the car they drive to the quality of their relationships – and wish we had what they have. Jealousy and resentment lie in wait for us, ready to distort our world-view and steal our peace of mind. If we look a little deeper, though, we find that it is all an illusion. Everybody has their troubles and disappointments; every life has worry and sadness; every life ends, ultimately, in death.

As Freemasons, we know this and try to hold ourselves steady through all the vagaries of life. We deal with ourselves and with others with compassion and understanding because, when all is said and done, we have that calm centre of faith and trust that helps us stay anchored in things that are real and true.

January 27

*And silent, before us,
Veiled the dark portal,
Goal of all mortal:
Silent stars rest over us,
Graves under us – silent.*

Goethe

As Master Masons, we do not shy away from the contemplation of the grave and we understand that, all too soon, that is where we shall lie. But we are also confident in the belief that, beyond the darkness of death, there is light; that death is but a portal, a doorway and that the ‘vital and immortal principle’ within us will rise again.

As Companions of the Royal Arch, we also know what it is to descend into an unknown darkness and we now discover where light can be found in that darkness: in the word of God.

Let us take a moment – in silence – to contemplate once more our own mortality and to reaffirm our faith that beyond the outer forms of this life, there waits another, greater existence.

January 28

The fool hath said in his heart, There is no God. They are corrupt, they have done abominable works, there is none that doeth good.

Psalm 14

Being a Freemason carries a great weight of responsibility. Once we are committed to the path and once we begin to understand where it leads, it is our duty to ourselves, our brethren and to the world at large to always act upon and live according to the precepts we profess to admire. It's no good extolling the virtues of brotherhood in Lodge if we don't go out into the world and demonstrate those virtues in our daily lives. It's pointless and hypocritical to align ourselves to the Masonic values of brotherly love, relief and truth if we don't go out into the world and hold up those values in all of our dealings with others.

To be ignorant is one thing – ignorance can be overcome through education; but to know something to be true and then not to act on it, that is worse than ignorance, that is a character fault and an act of shame from which we, as Masons, must work, in every moment of every day, to free ourselves.

January 29

You agree to be a good Man and true, and strictly to obey the moral law.

Antient Charges

Initiation into Freemasonry is an acceptance of a great responsibility. By agreeing to be 'a good Man and true' we enter into an obligation, to ourselves no less than to God, to renounce selfishness and all the little dishonesties that it brings with it. We bind ourselves to act for the general good, making our every contact with others an expression of the truth that we are all one. This is the surest obedience to 'the moral law': to love God and love each other as we love ourselves.

January 30

LORD, who shall abide in thy tabernacle? who shall dwell in thy holy hill?

He that walketh uprightly, and worketh righteousness, and speaketh the truth in his heart.

Psalm 15

In our ritual we talk about the ‘benefits’ of Freemasonry but we don’t always clearly define exactly what they are.

Of course, some of the benefits are obvious. We take pleasure in the sense of comradeship that is to be found in our Lodges. We enjoy being in an environment where our honesty and integrity are taken as a given. We have fun: we laugh together and enjoy the company of people whom we might not otherwise find a chance to get to know.

Some benefits are mentioned in the ritual, however, deeper and perhaps more personal. For example, there is a reference to the joy of living with a clear conscience and, in a way, the sense of inner calm and serenity that comes from knowing that we are always trying to be the best that we can be, may be seen as another way of expressing, at least figuratively, that we are living our lives ever closer to God, under His protection, in His house.

January 31st

Pure wisdom always directs itself toward God; the purest wisdom is knowledge of God.'

Lew Wallace

As Entered Apprentices, we are encouraged to study the hidden mysteries of nature and science. As Fellowcrafts, we are enjoined to look more specifically at the liberal arts and sciences. And as Master Masons, we are told that our study should be ourselves; in particular, ourselves as mortals in the light of eternity. In a way, all of this is preparation for the greatest subject of all: the study of our relationship with God. Freemasonry allows us the freedom to conceive of God in whatever way is most meaningful for us but it asks – certainly in the Royal Arch – that we consider most deeply what the implications of our professed faith mean to us. It asks that we apply that understanding in practical ways, in our daily lives and, as always, it offers us guidance on our path, always suggesting the ways that might, eventually, lead us to find the peace we crave.

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February 1

Preserve me, O God: for in thee do I put my trust.

Psalm 16

Trust and patience are two of the great lessons that Freemasonry can teach us; two of the gifts that it offers, From the moment that we approach a known Brother to ask about the Order; from that moment of aloneness as we wait outside the door of the Lodge before being initiated; from that moment when we kneel in darkness – we trust. We trust ourselves and the intuitions that led us to enquire about Freemasonry and then to seek admission. We trust the people we met who put us on the path; we trust those who prepare us and who conduct us into the Lodge to receive the blessing of light.

And then we learn patience because patience is trust that things will work out in their due time. We progress slowly, passing to the second degree, being raised to the third. We begin to work in the Lodge and then to take offices, perhaps eventually being honoured with the opportunity to sit in the Master's chair.

All this can take years and then there is more beyond this, as we know. But we learn to accept, to understand that the system we are a part of is well designed and that, as each step is presented to us, we are readied to meet it.

And as it is in Freemasonry, so it is with life.

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February 2

Masonry, therefore, is not a competitor with religion though in the sphere of human conduct it may be hoped that its teaching will be complementary to that of religion.

Points of Procedure

There is no doubt that Masonry is a Spiritual pursuit. The fact that it has as its principal aim the betterment of humanity is proof enough of that assertion. Because it is a Spiritual pursuit, it is intensely religious and yet one of its beauties is that it adorns and enhances religion without usurping it. A good Mason will always be a good person and therefore, by extension, a good Christian, Jew, Hindu, Muslim, Sikh or whatever. We should allow our Masonic principles to adorn and enhance our religious beliefs so that all our actions are acceptable to ourselves, to others and to God.

February 3

Keep me as the apple of the eye, hide me under the shadow of thy wings,

Psalm 17

We assume that when someone seeks admission into our order, they are motivated by the best of intentions. In our ritual we are asked if we come to solicit the privileges of Initiation as a result of "...a favourable opinion preconceived of the Institution, a general desire of knowledge, and a sincere wish to render yourself more extensively serviceable to your fellow-creatures..."

The claim that Freemasonry 'makes good men better' is not an idle one. We come already predisposed to want to learn and to serve and it is these things that open the door to us and allow us to progress on our journey.

We know the path we are on and we are aware that it is a path that leads us away from and above the common condition of humanity towards the Godhead. This is why a genuine and constant humility is necessary. The moment we begin to feel ourselves to be better than others, we abandon our principles of universal brotherhood and we lose every advantage that Freemasonry gives us.

If we are to walk a righteous path, it must be in the sure knowledge that we are able to do so only because we walk in the shadow and under the guidance and protection of God.

February 4

Almighty God, unto whom all hearts be open, all desires known, and from whom no secrets are hid...

Opening prayer

Whatever we conceive God to be, we generally acknowledge that the Being to whom we assign that name is omniscient: all-knowing. This means that we are known, in our totality, by God. The innermost secrets of our hearts are open; our hopes and desires are known and even our darkest secrets are not hidden. This is, on the one hand, a terrifying thought. We all have hidden depths that we find hard to bring into the light, even in our own minds. But it is also a very liberating thought. If these things are known and open to the One who is the highest power and state of being, why should we fear to acknowledge them ourselves? The very essence of Royal Arch Masonry is the idea that we must plumb the depths and bring light to the darkest recesses of our lives. How joyful to know that God is with us; that we will have support and guidance and love on every step of that difficult journey.

February 5

I will love thee, O LORD, my strength.

The LORD is my rock, and my fortress, and my deliverer; my God, my strength, in whom I will trust;

Psalm 18

In some ways, it's easy to love an abstracted image of perfection and there is no doubt that when we try to imagine the Divine, we tend to create it as an idealisation of what we are. Therefore God becomes, to us, a projection of what we see as the very best in ourselves.

What's more difficult to understand and accept is that God doesn't just exist 'out there' but also, and more importantly, in every aspect of Earthly existence. And, while we know that the earth is full of beauty and that we humans are capable of the most altruistic and noble acts, some of it is pretty ugly.

For us to learn to see God equally in every human being, in every animal and plant – in every living entity – is, spiritually, a herculean task. To see Spirit move in beauty and goodness is easy enough, but to see it in squalor and degradation, in war, murder, hatred and indifference is another thing entirely.

If we are to build a house fit for the Lord with our lives, it must be large enough to include everyone, not just those who appear to be 'deserving.'

When we can do this, then we can truly claim to love the Lord.

February 6

'How should Freemasons meet?'

'On the Level.'

Closing Ceremony

When we say that we meet 'on the level' we most usually think of our differing stations in life and it is true that Masonry allows us all to meet as equals, whatever our backgrounds. However, the concept of Masonic parity should also apply to our hearts and minds. As Masons we should always have our sights set on the highest levels of thought and behaviour and in this, too, we should be 'on the level.' All lives contain drudgery and it is often difficult to remain optimistic in the face of it but there is no doubt that to do so is the mark of a good Mason.

February 7

The heavens declare the glory of God; and the firmament sheweth his handywork.

More to be desired are they than gold,

Psalm 19

As Freemasons, it must be part of our daily practice to learn to love and appreciate this beautiful world in which we live. We know – and our ritual reminds us – that the Earth is made with symmetry and order and that Wisdom, Strength and Beauty are inextricably woven into its fabric. We must also remember, though, that this life is not all that there is. To be wholly seduced by its attractions is not our purpose and we must keep in mind that greater existence which is our birthright and our source.

The teachings of Freemasonry are enough to keep us on track at all times and the support and companionship of our Brethren are enough to give us the strength to continue, even when life challenges us to the limits of our capacity to cope.

This practice, this path, this hope of futurity – these are the things of true value in the world. It is no coincidence that we are given a password whose import is ‘worldly possessions’ moments before we are led to a figurative death and it is only in the light of true brotherhood under God that we are raised again.

More desirable than gold? Definitely.

February 8

Then he answered and spake unto me, saying, This is the word of the Lord unto Zerubbabel, saying, Not by might, nor by power, but by my spirit, saith the Lord of hosts.

Zechariah 4:6

Perhaps the greatest lesson that the Royal Arch has to teach us is that to accept the word of God in our lives is the beginning of wisdom and inner peace. Coming, as we do, from so many walks of life, so many countries and cultures and religions, our interpretation and understanding of what is meant by the word of God may differ, but we can agree that it represents that innermost impulse that tells us what is right and what is wrong: what benefits and what harms ourselves and those around us. And, acting from that place of light, we acknowledge the power of truth to actuate us and to keep us on the path that leads, eventually, to our deepest selves and to God.

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February 9

Some trust in chariots, and some in horses: but we will remember the name of the LORD our God.

Psalm 20

We take so much on trust in our lives, but if we didn't we would never be able to lift ourselves out of a bottomless pit of anxiety and worry.

There are endless things to fret about and many of them are real and worthy of a certain amount of attention. The trick, though, is to only give them the amount of attention they deserve, proportional to the importance they have in our lives.

So check your on-line marketplaces and your Facebook settings. Meet your children's teachers; vote wisely in elections. Do what you can.

And then let go.

Our ritual says: "...relying on such sure support you may safely rise and follow your leader with a firm but humble confidence, for where the name of GOD is invoked, we trust no danger can ensue." Of course, this alludes to a particular moment at our Initiation, but the principle remains true in the whole circle of our lives.

Trust is a valid and effective antidote to worry as long as it is well-founded. Ours, being founded on God, is strong enough to overcome all that troubles us.

February 10

*Live on old monuments of the past,
Our beacons through ages dark!
In primal majesty still you'll last,
Endeared by each Mason mark.*

Anon

In becoming Freemasons, we unknowingly attached ourselves to a huge weight of history. We became a part of that stream of ancient hope and endeavour which has crystallised into our modern Craft. No Mason can be unaware of the traditions of his Lodge, his Grand Lodge and of the institution as a whole and each Mason should try to feel a part of this heritage. Despite the many so-called scandals that have plagued it through the years, Freemasonry remains a system that advocates the highest to which human endeavour can attain. Only individual Freemasons can undermine this and so we should take care to nurture our Masonry with pride in its past and the determination to be the best of ambassadors for its future.

February 11

The king shall joy in thy strength, O LORD; and in thy salvation how greatly shall he rejoice!

Psalm 21

Wisdom, strength and beauty are the three pillars which support a Freemason's Lodge. They are described as three attributes with which God is imbued and which are manifest in creation. As such, we can also understand them to be three excellences of character to which we should aspire.

The strength that we - frail creatures that we are - must learn is not necessarily about physical strength although it is certain that what physical strength we have must be put to use in service and doing good works. More importantly, though, the strength we must cultivate must be internal: strength of character, firmness of faith, an unwavering commitment to do and be our best at all times.

To live in accord with what we know to be true, this is the first step to wisdom; and if we live in wisdom and strength, surely our lives will be beautiful.

February 12

We three do meet and agree in Peace, Love, and Unity...

Chapter Opening Ceremony

In the Royal Arch, nothing is accomplished alone. In Craft Freemasonry, we are, in some respects, alone at every step of the journey. We enter the Lodge in darkness and, in the third degree, it is only after our raising that we are reunited with our ‘former companions.’ But in the Royal Arch we are never without the help and support of our Companions. The Chapter is ruled by three; three journey to Jerusalem; three assist in the discovery and exploration of the vault. And three, together, bring their discovery before the Court of the Sanhedrin.

The journey from darkness to light is a difficult one. Sometimes we create our own difficulties; sometimes life throws difficulties before us. How good it is to know that we do not have to travel this road alone. How good it is to know that there are those who tread the path with us and that there are those who have gone before us and who are able to guide and counsel us.

How foolish it would be to refuse that help.

February 13

All the ends of the world shall remember and turn unto the LORD: and all the kindreds of the nations shall worship before thee.

Psalms 22

Freemasons live in two worlds that sometimes seem totally incompatible. On the one hand, we live and work in the world of external form. We do our duty - to ourselves, our families and our connections; we conform to social expectations and uphold the laws of our respective lands. Our lives, sometimes, are hard. We put in long hours at our work-place, we struggle to find a balance between what we must do and what we want to do. If we are lucky, the two occasionally merge but, in the daily struggle, God can seem very far away.

And yet, we also carry within us another world. A world of knowledge and deep understanding that, beyond this life there is another existence. The world is not what it appears to be and those of us lucky enough to have been given a glimpse beyond its veils, know that there is more.

When life is busy, difficult, chaotic; when we struggle and feel abandoned and alone, we need to remember what is on the other side of that veil. Stop for a moment. Breathe. Think.

God is there.

February 14

‘There is a perennial nobleness, and even sacredness, in work...in idleness alone is there perpetual despair...’

Thomas Carlyle

We should understand the word ‘work’ to mean more than just physical or even intellectual effort, and certainly more than the daily round of our employment, however worthwhile it may be. As human beings we are, with God, co-creators of the world and to strive always for its betterment is the true work of us all. In performing this work, we take our place alongside our Creator, fulfilling our role as tenders of His glorious garden. It is this which fills such work with sacredness. When we neglect our duties we fall away from God’s plan for us and this will undoubtedly lead us into despair.

Let us determine to try to make the world a better place, to try to act in accordance with the Masonic precepts we espouse. As Masons we aim to construct a Temple fit for the Lord to dwell in; the building blocks of that temple are found in every human heart.

February 15

The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want.

He maketh me to lie down in green pastures: he leadeth me beside the still waters. He restoreth my soul:

Psalm 23

In the relentless busy-ness of our lives, the idea of just stopping for a moment can be terrifying. We are so used to believing that our striving is all that keeps us from ruin that we forget who we truly are and why we are really here.

Of course, we must take care of our material needs as far as we are able. We must clothe and feed ourselves and our families. There are bills to pay, mortgages to service, contingencies to plan for. But unless we take the time to focus, to find our centre, to remind ourselves of who and what we are, we run the risk of losing ourselves and succumbing to a weight of care that can overwhelm us.

It is at these times that we most need to remember that, beyond this life, another existence is possible. If we can't do it literally, then we must find time to do it metaphorically: to lie down in those green pastures; to drink of those still waters; to restore our soul.

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February 16

Do you present yourself with a view to improving in Freemasonry and directing that improvement to the Glory of God, and the good of man?

Ceremony of Exaltation

Before the ceremony is properly begun in the Chapter, we are reminded about the importance of the work we do. That we have attained a certain level of understanding of Freemasonry is taken as read – we are Master Masons after all – but it is also acknowledged that we can learn more, that we can improve. This doesn't mean, necessarily, that we must become better ritualists but, more importantly, that we can always deepen our understanding of the lessons that lie within our rituals. We can always become better people by putting those lessons into practice in our lives and, right from our entry into the Chapter, it is stated, without equivocation, that by choosing to make ourselves better people, we can glorify God and lift all our brothers and sisters towards the light.

February 17

Who shall ascend into the hill of the LORD? or who shall stand in his holy place?

He that hath clean hands, and a pure heart;

Psalm 24

The idea of ascent is a strong one in Freemasonry. In the first degree, we are told of Jacob's ladder and of how we might attain its summit. In the second degree we hear a great deal about the winding staircase and how all duly qualified brethren were able to climb it and thus reach the Middle Chamber of the Temple where they received their wages and discovered the sacred symbol. In the third degree, we are 'raised' from a figurative death to glimpse the possibility of a new life.

In the Royal Arch, our ascent is preceded by a descent into darkness where we find the light that will allow us to be lifted up again.

The symbolism of these ascents is clear: we rise slowly from the physical to the spiritual; from the earthly plane to the heavenly; from darkness upwards to the Light.

And how do we make this great ascent?

Slowly, but surely: with clean hands and pure hearts. Our actions will bring their own rewards.

February 18

That thing which I understand by real art is the expression by man of his pleasure in labour...A most kind gift is this of nature, since all men, nay, it seems all things, too, must labour.

William Morris

As human beings, we have within us an urge to create, an impulse to make sense of the world around us by the application of our labour in some sphere or another. The labour itself, as well as its fruit may be called art and it may take many forms. Anything good, well made by human effort, from a happy home to a successful business to a well-run Lodge can be seen as a work of art and it gives to its creator an inexpressible pleasure that is truly divine in origin. When we work mindfully and our work is such that it adds something to the common good, we become co-creators with God of the perfect world that must always remain our highest aim.

February 19

Remember not the sins of my youth, nor my transgressions: according to thy mercy remember thou me for thy goodness' sake, O LORD.

Psalm 25

One of the great things about Freemasonry is that, while it calls on us to be the best that we can be, it never asks us to be more than we can be.

None of us is perfect and all of us have made mistakes and errors of judgement which, with the gift of hindsight, we might come to regret. Guilt is a debilitating emotion that prevents us from living fully in the moment. It infects our present with the poisons of our past and means that we can never attain that ease and clarity and singleness of character to which we aspire.

The only way to be fully free is to learn forgiveness and it is here that Freemasonry's benevolence can be seen. By assuming the best of us in the here and now, it allows us to forgive ourselves. More importantly, it also calls on us to forgive others and, in doing so it allows us to cultivate those truly Masonic virtues of truth, of mercy and of kindness.

February 20

I have taught thee in the way of wisdom; I have led thee in right paths.

Proverbs 4:11

The legacy that Freemasons hope to leave is a world made just a little better, a little happier and a little wiser for their having passed through it. We do this in many ways: through our family lives, our friends, our work, our charitable activities and, of course, by making ourselves a little better, a little happier and a little wiser. But all of us have a responsibility, not only to gain and use knowledge and understanding, but to pass them on to the next generation. Whether it is to our own children by making sure they have a 'virtuous and liberal education,' or younger Brethren through precept and example, or, indeed, to younger people at large, one of the greatest gifts we can leave the world is a clear, well-trodden path that leads to personal fulfilment and peace.

February 21

*Examine me, O LORD, and prove me; try my reins and my heart.
For thy lovingkindness is before mine eyes: and I have walked in thy
truth.*

Psalm 26

One of the earliest charges laid upon us as Freemasons is that each one of us should aim to be a ‘...good man and true...’

The idea of truth in this sense is about more than just a narrow idea of being honest in what we say - although, of course, that is a meaning that must be included. But to be a ‘true’ man is something more. It’s about carrying with us at all times a sense of unity of purpose and of being. The words we say, the thoughts we think and the actions we perform all arise from a centre of integration wherein our personality and our deeper spiritual selves are fully aligned.

More than this, it’s also about having a conscience and working to keep that conscience clear. In other words, we work constantly and in every moment to see the right in every circumstance and then to act upon that knowing. By doing this we remain, in all senses, true to ourselves, true to the moral principles of our order and true to God.

February 22

'What is the first duty of Entered Apprentice Freemasons in Lodge assembled?'

'To see that the Lodge is properly tyled.'

Opening Ceremony

Tyling is about turning inwards, about shutting out the world with its everyday cares. It is a focussing of attention on our inner lives, a drawing in of breath; a moment's contemplation before action. See how the act of tiling and the calling of each officer in turn that immediately follows it is symbolic of how our attention dwells on the outside world. Then, by our own endeavour, it is drawn inward and upward until it comes to rest on, and act from, our highest Spiritual self.

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February 23

The LORD is my light and my salvation... the LORD is the strength of my life; of whom shall I be afraid?

Psalm 27

Fear is a great force in all of our lives and, conscious or not, many of our decisions are taken in its shadow.

Eventually fear becomes so integrated into who we are that we stop recognising it as such and we find ourselves conforming to rules and mores that, quite often, don't actually exist except in the confines of our own heads. Fear can destabilise us. It can take us away from who we are and prevent us becoming all that we might be. It can inhibit our joy, block our creativity, stunt our growth and stifle our ability to give and receive love.

"Fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom" and it may be that, really, the only thing we need to fear is the consequence of not living up to our full potential as co-creators of what Charles Eisenstein calls '... the beautiful world we know is possible.'

If our only fear is that we might fall short of becoming all that our Creator meant for us to be - 'a little lower than the angels' - then we must find a way to overcome it through our actions in the world.

As Freemasons, we understand that our true centre is bounded by knowledge, wisdom, faith, hope and love and that, acting from that centre, we cannot err.

Knowing this, how can we be afraid?

February 24

Yet now be strong, O Zerubbabel, saith the Lord; and be strong, O Joshua, son of Josedech, the high priest; and be strong, all ye people of the land, saith the Lord, and work: for I am with you, saith the Lord of hosts:

Haggai 2:4

Having developed the discipline to listen to our inner voice, to act from our deepest sense of knowing, we have to learn to let go and trust that things will proceed as they ought. We often can't know what effect our actions will have, how they will be interpreted or acted upon by others and to try to anticipate all of those things will lead us to such uncertainty that we may stop acting altogether. We are only in control of ourselves, so if we ensure that our actions are correctly motivated, we can relax and be strong, secure in the knowledge that we have done our best.

February 25

*Draw me not away with the wicked, and with the workers of iniquity,
which speak peace to their neighbours, but mischief is in their hearts.*

Psalms 28

We should not underestimate the importance of our Masonic community. We declare ourselves to be the brethren of all Freemasons across the globe. We also aim to cultivate and live by our understanding that all people are our brothers and sisters.

We acknowledge that we have a particular affinity and closeness with the members of our own Lodge. These are the brethren whom we know and come to love and care about. They are the ones with whom we work in the Lodge, with whom we sit at our festive boards, with whom we become friends. And it is in those bonds of particular friendship that our brethren truly become a practical and real support to us in our aspiration to become the best that we can be. Their approbation means something to us; their praise makes us glad; but the possibility of letting them down or of acting in such a way that casts a shadow on the harmony of the Lodge - these are important and powerful tools and incentives to remain true to all of our obligations.

February 26

*You alone are your master
Who else?
Subdue yourself
To discover your master.*

Adapted from the Dhammpada

After tying, after shutting out the distractions of the outside world, the lodge turns in on itself and, through ritual, the attention is guided up through the officers of the Lodge, representing their various functions, to the Master. He represents here our highest Spiritual self but even he has to turn for guidance to an authority that has gone beyond human knowledge, in the form of the Immediate Past Master. But there is a higher authority still, and the consciousness of the Lodge is raised again as the Chaplain invokes a blessing from the Almighty before the business of the meeting can proceed.

Our prayer must be that we continue to strive to raise our own consciousness and overcome the baser elements of our nature so that we may strip away the layers of illusion and discover our truest, deepest selves.

February 27

The LORD will give strength unto his people; the LORD will bless his people with peace.

Psalm 29

There is no doubt that to set our feet on a path such as Freemasonry - a path that leads, ultimately, to self knowledge and deeper spiritual understanding - is to set off on a path beset with challenge and difficulty. Given that the path is often so hard, it is natural to wonder why we would bother, but the truth is that, once we have understood that the path exists, we can never forget it. If we try to ignore it and go back to our state of not-knowing, we will not again find a sense of ease and inner peace because we will be trying to fool ourselves. We will be denying what we know to be true: that there is more to this life than material success and sensual pleasure.

When we act on what we know and take that first step, we do so knowing - because our ritual makes it clear - that there will be no material gain in this. If we tread this path, it is for other, higher reasons.

But the path brings its own rewards: we learn the value of brotherhood. We learn to trust in God and to find joy in our daily advancements; we come to understand, in fact, that lasting joy and true beauty are to be found in the holiness we seek.

February 28

...may he not enter our Order lightly, nor recede from it hastily, but pursue it steadfastly...

Ceremony of Exaltation

Entering Freemasonry is a big step and one we take largely in the dark, on trust. Once we are committed to the Craft, we tend to go through the different degree ceremonies without much thought beyond the fact that this is what comes next. When we are invited to join the Royal Arch, we can fall into the trap of doing so unconsciously, flattered to be wanted, taking the whole process a little for granted. But each step we take on the road to our own perfection is as important as the last. The Royal Arch is often referred to as the completion of the Craft Degrees but it is much more than that. It sets our feet on a whole new path. In the Craft we were led inward to discover ourselves and down into the darkness of our own mortality to learn to understand ourselves in the light of eternity. In the Royal Arch we are taken down into the darkness of this mortal life one more time in order that we might discover where light is to be found. Clearly, this is a something to be undertaken consciously and pursued steadfastly.

February 29 (Leap Year)

*Like as the waves make towards the pebbled shore,
So do our minutes hasten to their end;
Each changing place with that which goes before,
In sequent toil all forwards do contend.*

William Shakespeare.

On this, the strangest and perhaps the most contrived day in our calendar, perhaps we would do well to consider time itself. Today's date reminds us that all our concepts of time are constructs that we use to help give shape, meaning and direction to our lives.

Our calendar is a reflection of reality: the Earth does travel round the sun in a little over 365 days so every 4 years we need an extra day. The Earth does rotate on its axis and we have divided the time that takes into 24 segments.

But we mustn't let the constructs that help us experience and feel in control of 'our' time prevent us from actually living. Time can be a trap: we spend so much of it looking back to what has been or looking forward to what soon will be that we miss out on the only truly real segment of time that ever exists: now.

To be fully present in this moment of time and carry this understanding of the eternal now through all of our days helps us see the world for what really is, a timeless wonder, a beautiful garden, the temple of our living God.

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March 1

To the end that my glory may sing praise to thee, and not be silent. O LORD my God, I will give thanks unto thee for ever.

Psalm 30

Our aim, as Freemasons, is to make of our lives a place fit and worthy to be the dwelling place of the Most High; a temple and a monument to all that is good. It's not a solid building of bricks and mortar, of course, but a figurative structure, made of all that we say and do in every moment of our lives. It's made of our relationships with our family and friends; of our interactions with strangers; of how we treat those less fortunate than ourselves. It's made of the words we speak and the acts of kindness we perform. It's in our hopes and dreams; in our aspirations for a better life for ourselves and our connections and a better world for all. It's in our prayers and in our silences; in our thoughts and in our hearts.

We have all taken obligations to uphold the highest standards of behaviour and to see in every person a brother or sister. It is in the upholding of these obligations and in the commitment to do it a little better every day, that our daily lives become our acts of prayer, our expressions of gratitude and our songs of praise.

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March 2

Masons unite with the virtuous of every persuasion in the firm and pleasing bond of fraternal love;

Antient Charges

One of the greatest lessons Masonry teaches us lies in the admonishment to avoid discussion of things that could cause division amongst us. Instead of identifying each other and ourselves within the confines of title, job, political persuasion, religion, race or tribe, we are defined, not only as Masons and in ways peculiar to the Craft, but by a belief that things can be better, that humankind still has a long road to travel to fulfil its destiny and, most importantly, by the belief that we, as individuals, can make a difference. This longing to improve both ourselves and the world at large is the beginning of virtue and, while we preserve it as a Masonic virtue, we understand that it is not exclusively so.

March 3

Be of good courage, and he shall strengthen your heart, all ye that hope in the LORD.

Psalm 31

Freemasons do not shy away from the thought of death and neither are we strangers to the trials and tribulations of life. On the one hand we have the absolute joy that can come from being truly 'in the moment;' of appreciating the beauty of the world; of feeling a profound sense of gratitude for our family, friends and connections. To love and be loved is a daily miracle and, if we cultivate the practice of remembrance, we enter into its 'secret pavilion.'

On the other hand, our lives are tinged with the sadness of loss and decay. We grow old and infirm; our loved ones pass away. We experience grief, frustration and anger at our sense of powerlessness before the relentless march of time. We are leaves, tossed on the wind, swept away on currents over which we have no control.

And yet we have before us the possibility of equilibrium; of finding a due medium between these extremes. From that calm centre, that point within the circle of our lives, we can appreciate the joy and acknowledge the sorrow but, at the same time, we hold firm to our rock and our refuge, knowing always that courage and strength of heart are available to us when we live out the tenets of our professed faith.

March 4

Truth is One, the wise know it by many names.

Rig Veda

In this quotation from one of the world's oldest scriptures, the word 'Truth' is often inter-changed with the word 'God.' This deeply profound statement is of the greatest interest for every Freemason who understands that Freemasonry is loved, revered and practised by members of every religion across the globe. In many ways, Freemasonry is one of the few remaining non-denominational institutions that holds this truth as a central tenet of its identity. As Freemasons, each one of us acknowledges God but understands that every individual will conceive of God in his or her own way. To maintain this deep and broad understanding of the oneness of God, without being dragged down into sectarianism is, indeed, the mark of 'the wise.'

March 5

Blessed is he whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered.

Psalm 32

It's a recurring idea in Freemasonry and in many of the world's religions and spiritual disciplines: to be our best, we need to be free from the burden of guilt that can weigh us down and render us, as it were, unserviceable.

There are a few ways to live guilt-free. The first is to be completely amoral: to live without any consciousness of the concept of right and wrong. This isn't an option open to Freemasons because - happily - we are, by definition, people who do have a sense of morality.

The second way to live guilt-free is to never do anything wrong. This isn't an option for Freemasons either by virtue of the simple fact that we are human and therefore imperfect.

The third way is to acknowledge our mistakes and to seek forgiveness and make restitution. This is the only practical way to wipe our slate clean and allow us to approach each day with the lightness and clarity that are the marks of a fully functioning, well-balanced personality.

To learn to trust in the power of forgiveness and to embrace the gift of self-reflection that makes us human: these are the first steps on the path that will lead us to that sense of ineffable joy that is our birthright.

March 6

The level demonstrates that we are all sprung from the same stock, are partakers of the same nature, and sharers of the same hope;

Second Degree Ceremony

Freemasonry has always recognised that the widest principles of belonging unite us. Masons have firmly held to their belief that nothing less than a vision of all humankind as children of God is inclusive enough to reflect our true relationship with our Creator. The Working Tools of the Fellow-craft teach us important lessons of morality, equality and justness and uprightness of action, but here, as so often in our ritual, stress is put on the particular aspect that reminds us that the whole purpose of Freemasonry is to strive for a better world outside of the Lodge. The Level is a clear indication that, while we are united in our Lodges as Freemasons, beyond its confines we are, by our own assertion, members of an even wider family.

March 7

Praise the LORD with harp: sing unto him with the psaltery and an instrument of ten strings. Sing unto him a new song; play skilfully with a loud noise.

Psalm 33

Music plays an important part in the ceremonies of religions and spiritual practices in almost every culture in the world. The power of harmonious sound, the unifying force of voices raised together in songs of praise: these are vital foundations in the superstructure that we hope to build in and of our lives.

As Freemasons, we have our own musical traditions: our opening and closing odes; the incidental music that permeates our ceremonies; the songs at the festive board: the Master's Song, the Entered Apprentice's song. In their singing, we find the simplest and most direct route to creating unity amongst ourselves as we, literally, create harmony easily and instantly.

As Freemasonry seeks to modernise itself and to become more relevant to our 21st century lives, it is important that we do not fall into the error of thinking that the music in our rituals and at our tables is an incidental 'extra' that can be dispensed with when time is short.

We Freemasons understand the power of the spoken word. We would do well to consider and reaffirm the equal - perhaps greater - power of music and song to unite us.

March 8

...may he ever remember that the object of our institution is the welfare of our fellow-creatures, but above all, the honour and glory of Thy most Holy Name...

Ceremony of Exaltation

Again, we are reminded that what we are about to do is a serious business. There is no doubt that Freemasonry can be one of the most joyous and fulfilling things we do because it satisfies us on a very deep, soulful level and this is equally and, in some senses, more true of the Royal Arch; but to glorify God – in a sense to be emissaries for all that that stands for – is a great responsibility and certainly not one to be taken lightly. We are not often given such unambiguous guidance on our purpose as Freemasons, but the message here is very clear. Let us try to remember this purpose at all times, in the Lodge and Chapter and beyond: at our festive boards, our social gatherings and in our daily lives away from the comforting and supporting presence of our Brothers and Companions.

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March 9

I will bless the LORD at all times: his praise shall continually be in my mouth.

The LORD is nigh unto them that are of a broken heart; and saveth such as be of a contrite spirit.

Psalm 34

While we try our best to live good lives, to be upright and true, we acknowledge that we sometimes fall short. We know in our hearts what is right and, in our moments of strength and certainty, we act upon that knowledge without hesitation.

But we all have moments of weakness and doubt as well and it is at these times that the companionship and support of our brethren is so important. It can offer us what we need to move forward, to power through those dark moments of uncertainty when we lose our way and our faith falters or is submerged under the sea of troubles that threatens to overwhelm us.

This is what our Brotherhood is for: to help each other - as well as the stranger at the gate - to find our way again. It's why we come together to unite in forming a column of mutual aid and support, recognising that we are stronger together than apart.

It's why we should never be reticent to ask for help, for how can we be afraid to ask for that which has already been freely promised?

March 10

It should be understood by every Brother - and made clear at an early stage to every Candidate for Initiation - that membership of the Craft is not to be used as a means of promoting his personal or business advantage.

Points of Procedure

It is no coincidence that the thing the outside world most suspects us of is the very thing against which we must be most on our guard. It would be so easy to fall into the trap of treating our Masonic Brethren differently, of saving the best in ourselves for them. It is natural for us to feel a particular affinity with those who share our rites and there is no shame in rejoicing in the Brotherhood that Freemasonry brings us; but we must not lose sight of that most profound teaching of our Order: that all humankind is one family under God. Our treatment of every individual within the greater family should be such that it could not be bettered even when directed to the interests of a fellow Mason. We should not seek to raise our Brethren above humankind but should seek to treat all of humankind as our Brethren.

March 11

All my bones shall say, LORD, who is like unto thee, which deliverest the poor from him that is too strong for him, yea, the poor and the needy from him that spoileth him?

Psalm 35

A Freemason is always a friend to the poor, distressed and lonely. Much of what we do in the 'outside' world involves charitable giving to worthy causes and there is no doubt that all Freemasons, rich and poor, can feel proud of what our institutions do to help those less fortunate than ourselves.

Ideally, we should do more than give money if we can. While we might thank God for our good fortune, we should also cultivate the practice of seeing ourselves as the vehicles by which God manifests blessings to others. So, when we involve ourselves directly in people's lives, doing good work through actual human contact, we are not only representing Freemasonry but also everything that Freemasonry stands for in terms of its understanding of and belief in the brotherhood of humankind.

Charitable giving of money is a worthwhile and laudable pursuit; charitable giving of our time and energy is even better. Giving of ourselves in the spirit of brotherhood is best of all.

Let us each determine to give what we can, whenever we can.

March 12

You have now arrived at the crown of a vaulted chamber into which it is necessary that you should descend.

Ceremony of Exaltation

So much of the symbolism of the Royal Arch is concerned with this idea of a descent into an unknown darkness and on an esoteric level the symbolism can convey so much meaning, so many mysteries. In one sense it can stand for the Soul's descent into this mortal realm in order to learn and grow towards God. In another, it stands for the darkness of ignorance that must be plumbed to find knowledge and it can also represent that inevitable descent into the grave that awaits us all. Whatever it means to us at any given moment – and it can mean different things to each of us at different stages in our lives – there is no doubt that we must descend. No knowledge comes without experience and each of us, at some time or another, is called upon to explore our own depths, our own 'vaulted chamber.' Let us do so secure in the knowledge that help is at hand and that, at any given moment, we can be hauled to safety.

March 13

The transgression of the wicked saith within my heart, that there is no fear of God before his eyes.

The words of his mouth are iniquity and deceit: he hath left off to be wise, and to do good.

Psalm 36

We have to cope every day with people who do not share our views and, worse, those who consider Freemasonry to be a negative force in the world. Obviously, we will do our best to correct misconceptions and prejudices and we will always judge a person by their actions, not on their professed belief or lack thereof.

However, we are not here to proselytize and we know that arguing with people determined to hold on to their prejudices is a waste of time. We must learn to let go of such potential disturbances to our peace, such upsetters of our equilibrium, and be prepared to let our actions speak the truth that we act in the best interests of all - including, unashamedly, ourselves and our connections - and we do it from a firm and unshakeable centre of hope, of love and of faith.

March 14

FAITH...HOPE...CHARITY...These forces are within reach of all men; and an association of men, actuated by them, ought to exercise an immense power in the world. If Masonry does not, it is because she has ceased to possess them.

Albert Pike

At first this may seem like too harsh an indictment; but is it? The statement, 'Ye shall know them by their fruits,' is no less true now than it was two thousand years ago. We should dwell on these three virtues and ask ourselves how many of our daily actions are really founded on the rock they represent. It is in relation to this question that we may judge ourselves to be 'good' Masons and hence good people. The more we strive to live by the excellences which we claim motivate us, the more power for good Freemasonry will have in the world.

March 15

Mark the perfect man, and behold the upright: for the end of that man is peace.

Psalm 37

Luckily for us, it's not our responsibility to put the world to rights. Our duty is to live good lives of honesty and integrity and to deal kindly and sympathetically with all those who come within our compass. Some of us have more influence in the world than others, it is true, but we are only called upon to do what we can - no more but, equally, no less.

The world will continue to unfold as it should or at least as it will and we will only find peace by allowing that to happen. Again, we will always try to be influences and examples for the good, but we trust in God for the outcome, knowing that, ultimately, power does not lie with us.

Thus we are left with a strong sense that we must work always for the good but, at the same time, we must not allow ourselves to be overwhelmed by concern about the results of our actions. We work with a benevolent disinterest and in that way we remain conscious of that power, greater than ours, by whose hand all things come to pass.

There is no doubt that this is the path to find peace in this troubled world; this is the perfect way.

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March 16

Let that want remind you that man by nature is a child of ignorance and error...

Ceremony of Exaltation

It sounds rather harsh to suggest that we are children of ‘ignorance and error’ but the point being made here is that this is only the case when we are missing a vital ingredient in our make-up. Without consciousness of God, whatever we conceive that God to be, we are incomplete; we are creatures of clay lacking the vital spark that makes us fully functioning beings, able to fulfil the role assigned to us in this life which is to work for the glory of God and the benefit of all. The darkness of the vault – the want of light – reminds us that without the light of God we are, indeed, in ignorance and error. Let us remember to walk always in the light, understanding that when we do so, we are operating from the fullness of our potential as human beings.

March 17

O LORD, rebuke me not in thy wrath: neither chasten me in thy hot displeasure.

For thine arrows stick fast in me, and thy hand presseth me sore.

Psalm 38

Rooted in our faith, Freemasons are in a position to walk through this world untroubled by the extremes of emotion and suffering to which so many people fall prey.

It's not that we are unmoved by what we see - indeed Freemasons are often the first to respond to suffering and crisis and we are exemplary in our efforts to help those in need - it's more a case of us understanding that this life is not all that there is and that suffering and pain, as much as joy and well-being, are transitory and, therefore, unreal.

Our ritual tells us clearly that this life is a shadow - darkness visible - and that true life and true light are only to be found on the other side of that mysterious veil that divides this life and the next.

With this in mind, we are able to face this life; to feel joy and sorrow, pleasure and pain, hope and disappointment with a degree of equanimity because our hope and our belief is in a life beyond this mortal realm, beyond the grave into which we will all be lowered and from which we will all be raised.

March 18

May Freemasonry in every quarter of the globe become influential by diffusing the light of knowledge; aiding the strength of reason; dispensing the practice of virtue by lessening the aggregate of human misery and vice, by extending the bounties of charity and the blessings of peace to every deserving object under heaven.

Ceremony of Installation

Few of us are so placed that our actions can have any significant influence over public life, but all of us have it within our power to influence those with whom we come into daily contact. Be sure to put into daily practice those tenets you profess to admire within the Lodge. Let your life, by a simple and humble clinging to Masonic ideals, be a force for good. The light of knowledge, the strength of reason, the practice of virtue: these are the weapons that Freemasonry gives us, the armour with which it clothes us. Use them to live a life that does indeed extend the bounties of charity and the blessing of peace to the world.

If each Freemason lived such a life, spread across every quarter of the globe as we are, what an influence that would be.

March 19

I said, I will take heed to my ways, that I sin not with my tongue: I will keep my mouth with a bridle, while the wicked is before me.

Psalm 39

There is a clear suggestion at our initiation that one of the conditions of our acceptance into the order is that the 'tongue of good report' is heard in our favour. In other words, our reputation - what others say about us - must be positive.

The point here is that words are powerful and the words we speak affect others around us, often in ways that we cannot anticipate. Knowing this, we can choose to harness this power as a force for good to build people up; to reassure, to calm and to bring joy; or we can use them destructively to bring down, to shatter peace and harmony, to cause sorrow and distress.

Hopefully, Freemasons, being committed to act for the general good, will only use this power positively, but a careless word, spoken in haste or anger or without thought, can lead us to cause untold harm unwittingly.

We are told that we must learn to guard our tongues in order to preserve our secrets. More importantly, we must do so to avoid causing distress. If we can find nothing pleasant to say, it is better to say nothing, always remembering that silence is a virtue highly prized amongst us.

March 20

In the beginning God created the Heaven and the Earth. And the Earth was without form, and void; and the darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light, and there was light.

Genesis 1:1-3

These words play an important part in the Ceremony of Exaltation. They remind us that the light we seek comes from God and that, in a sense, light is the very essence of God. The words themselves remind us of this very clearly – this is the moment in the Bible story when light was created. But the scroll reminds us of more than this, too. It reassures us that we can always find answers to the questions and problems that beset us and it represents the idea that God's will is revealed and available to us in many ways. In this sense the scroll represents the scriptures of all our religions because, as we know, Freemasonry's truths transcend the boundaries of dogma and look to the Truth that underlies all Religion.

March 21

Blessed is that man that maketh the LORD his trust, and respecteth not the proud, nor such as turn aside to lies.

Psalm 40

Freemasonry can help us to see where true value lies. We pride ourselves on the fact that any good-hearted person can become a Freemason, that our members come from all walks of life and that no outer distinction of rank or station makes one brother better or more valued than another.

At the same time, we take an equal pride in the fact that our 'rulers' often come from what might be considered to be the highest ranks of society. Even our ritual states that, "... in every age monarchs themselves have been promoters of the art..." as if this somehow gives 'the art' extra validity. In fact, we might also consider it the other way round: royal or noble patronage does not increase Freemasonry's worth, instead it reflects well on those who patronise it and adds to their status, suggesting, as it does, that even they "...prize honour and virtue above the external advantages of rank and fortune."

So Freemasonry teaches us to be content with our place in the order of things but, most importantly, it reminds us that our value is not determined by our social status but by our words, our actions and our hearts.

March 22

You agree to avoid private piques and quarrels and to guard against intemperance and excess.

Antient Charges and Regulations

The intrusion of personal disagreements between its members is one of the greatest dangers to threaten Freemasonry and, indeed, all institutions where people come together for a common cause. This is the reason we are enjoined to avoid discussions which pertain to our personal religious or political beliefs. By focussing on the things that unite us, we willingly learn humility and to subdue our egos for the greater good. Remember that Freemasonry is essentially a guide on the path that leads from physicality to spirituality and, like others, teaches us to walk a Middle Way, eschewing all extremes, emotional as well as physical.

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March 23

Blessed is he that considereth the poor: the LORD will deliver him in time of trouble.

Psalm 41

When things are going well, when we are comfortably housed and our children are educated and fed, when our health is good and our wallet is full, it is easy to be grateful, easy to thank God, easy to say, in the strength of our youth, “We do not fear sickness or death. To a Freemason, only dishonour is intolerable.”

But fortune’s wheel will turn and, at any time, illness can strike, work can become impossible and money can become tight.

At times like this, will we still hold firm to that rock we claim is our fortress and our strength?

The true answer is that we don’t know, but there is no doubt that we will cope better if we prepare ourselves for everything. And, as we know from our initiation, preparation is twofold: inner and outer.

Our inner preparation here is about a daily practice of introspection through which we learn to rely on our faith by force of habit so that our spiritual ‘muscle memory’ is tuned automatically to God.

Our outer preparation consists of living according to the precepts that Freemasonry teaches so that, when the time comes, we can face whatever life brings secure in the knowledge that we have lived well and done our best.

March 24

Let us therefore...walk worthily in the light which shines around.

Ceremony of Exaltation

As Freemasons, we work with the loftiest of ideals but because we often work with them in ways that can, understandably, become overly ritualistic, we sometimes forget just how high-minded they are. It is worth remembering that many people have not yet reached the stage where they can talk easily about matters of the Spirit or where they can begin to live their lives in the light of an understanding that we are all brothers and sisters, united into one family in God. For this reason, we should try to understand ourselves, not as particularly clever or evolved or gifted, but as lucky, as blessed to be able to understand this great, all-encompassing truth.

Let us remember what a privilege it is to see the light and to walk in it. And let us always aspire to be worthy of that privilege.

March 25

As the hart panteth after the water brooks, so panteth my soul after thee, O God.

Psalm 42

We often hear people say, 'Be careful what you wish for' and it's become one of those expressions that we use without really thinking about what it might mean and without considering its deeper implications.

There is a thought that runs through several spiritual disciplines and even some religions that says that this world is built on desire; that we get what it is that we most long for. It's not an easy concept to understand because it's impossible to imagine that anybody would desire a life of degradation and suffering, yet we can see that many people have one. There are two ways to consider the idea. The first is to simply say that it isn't true; it makes no sense. The second is to consider whether it's possible that, while nobody would choose to suffer, it is conceivable that a soul might choose to take on a life of apparent suffering in order to learn something and, even, in order to teach something.

These are deep esoteric concepts that require deep contemplation but the simple fact remains that, if we eventually get what we desire - if there's even a tiny chance that that might be true - wouldn't it be a good idea to make sure that our desires are fixed on the spiritual and not on the carnal?

March 26

Everyone who enters Freemasonry is, at the outset, strictly forbidden to countenance any act which may have a tendency to subvert the peace and good order of society;

Aims and Relationships of the Craft

Freemasonry is often accused of being reactionary because it tends to support the established order, but remember that we are exhorted thus very much on the assumption that a peaceful and well-ordered society exists around us. Nowhere are we enjoined to support, or keep silent about, tyranny of any kind. As Freemasons we are concerned with personal freedom and self-determination and so any society that allows its people to pursue these basic rights is worthy of our support. Freemasonry by its nature upholds the values of such a society and this is why it has always been the enemy of, and feared by, oppressors in every age.

March 27

Why art thou cast down, O my soul? and why art thou disquieted within me? hope in God: for I shall yet praise him, who is the health of my countenance,

Psalm 43

Nearly all of the stories told in our rituals have a positive outcome but they also have a moment of negativity too; a moment of tension that gives the positive added weight and value.

At our initiation we are put into darkness before we can be brought to the light. As Fellowcrafts we hear of how Jephtha was expelled from his father's house before being promoted to being the Gileadites' chief Governor. To become Master Masons, we must be laid in the grave before we can be raised again. In the Royal Arch we descend into darkness to discover the source of light; in the Mark degree, the keystone is thrown over amongst the rubble before it is found and recognised.

So it is with life. There are always moments of darkness, doubt and negativity but they are invariably matched and offset by moments of certainty and joy. Knowing this and understanding the truth about how quickly the wheel of fortune may turn, we must try to maintain equanimity and not be unduly swayed by any extreme of emotion. Most certainly, we can avoid the depths of despair because we have chosen to have in our lives an inexhaustible source of hope.

March 28

For wisdom is better than rubies; and all the things that may be desired are not to be compared to it.

Proverbs 8:11

In some ways, it may be said that one of the biggest steps we take as we move on from the Craft to the Royal Arch is the step from knowledge to wisdom. In the three degrees of the Craft we are encouraged to consider worldly knowledge: the hidden mysteries, the liberal arts and sciences, ourselves and our mortality. This last leads us to an understanding of our place in the light of eternity and then the Royal Arch presents us with a clear sense of our dependence on God and on the dispensation of divine Grace. This combination of knowing and understanding has the potential, when thoughtfully applied, to lead us to the wisdom that will inform our actions and sweeten all of our relationships and this, in turn, will fill all the spheres of our lives with true richness.

March 29

*Awake, why sleepest thou, O Lord? arise, cast us not off for ever.
Wherefore hidest thou thy face, and forgettest our affliction and our
oppression?*

Psalm 44

Sometimes we have to tread our path alone. Sometimes it feels as though all support has been withdrawn and we have to be willing to embrace uncertainty, to take our first few steps not knowing for sure whether we are even heading in the right direction.

Relying on others, we must be sure that we don't lose confidence in ourselves. Relying on God, we must be sure that we are willing to take responsibility for our actions. When we are uncertain, we must trust in our own sense of what is right and follow our intuition.

If it is the right path, we will know; if it is wrong, at least we will learn something from it before we find the right way again.

We must remember that if we have to tread it alone for a time, there is a reason for this. We are not abandoned - ever - but perhaps we are being given an important lesson about independence, free will and trust.

March 30

'Name the three grand principles on which the Order is founded.'

'Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth.'

Second Degree Ceremony

Not only does Brotherly Love 'cement us' together as a group, its very concept reminds us of our true relationship to God as our Creator and to humankind as brothers and sisters. The relief we offer is not just that found in our charitable donations, but also when we try to lighten the burden of human suffering by our own correct living. Our Truth is not the truth of any particular dogma or creed but that which underlies all dogmas and all creeds: God is our Creator and we are all God's children. Let us try to live so that this truth, at least, is self-evident.

March 31

...grace is poured into thy lips: therefore God hath blessed thee for ever.

Psalm 45

Some days, the sun seems to shine a little brighter, the breezes blow a little warmer and life is sweet and precious. Goodness and happiness sometimes come into our lives as quickly and mysteriously as worry and hardship and if we are not to be trapped on an emotional see-saw all of our days, we must consider how to find equanimity in the good times as well as the bad.

It would be easy to allow ourselves to be swept away on the euphoria that the good days bring but if we allow that, then we cannot help but be equally affected by the doldrums that come with the bad days. If we choose to be ruled by our transient emotions, we must understand that we are not always in control of which emotion will hold sway at any given moment.

In fact, our daily practice should eventually lead us to be able to feel the emotions that sweep through us without being swept away by them. It will lead us in time to find that still centre from which we cannot err: that point within the circle that is bounded by wisdom and truth. From this still centre we will find a different kind of happiness, one not dependent on the vagaries of transient emotion; one more solidly founded on the truth of who we are.

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April 1

Because of thy temple at Jerusalem shall kings bring presents unto thee.

Psalm 68:29

When we begin to live our lives in such a way that it is informed by the beliefs we profess, people are naturally attracted to us. If God is at our centre, it necessarily follows that the world will look to us for guidance, leadership and counsel. As Freemasons, we build a metaphorical Temple out of our lives and we must understand that a Temple is open to all of God's children. This is why we aim to be strong and kind and open-hearted: because we know that we are opening a door through which the world might approach God.

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April 2

God is our refuge and strength... Therefore will not we fear, though the earth be removed, and though the mountains be carried into the midst of the sea;

Psalm 46

There are no real certainties in this life. We can plan and prepare for our future, of course but we do so in the consciousness that anything can happen at any moment to render our plans and preparation as nought. Sudden illness, accident, financial instability, earthquake, hurricane - these are things over which we have no control and, although we are statistically unlikely to be affected, we know from experience that statistical probability does not necessarily shield us from calamity or misfortune.

It is in our response to these crises in our own lives that our faith is tested and it is in our response to such crises in the lives of others that our true values are seen.

Freemasons, generally, are optimists. We believe in a benevolent God and we trust that life proceeds as it should.

Ultimately, though, we acknowledge that we are powerless in the face of forces we can neither control nor fully understand and it is in this state of powerlessness that we willingly and happily say, 'Thy will be done.'

April 3

Brethren, this morally teaches us to set a guard at the entrance of our thoughts; place a watch at the door of our lips; and post a sentinel at the avenue of all our actions, thereby preserving a conscience void of offence before God and man.'

Investiture of the Tyler

This injunction is often assumed to relate to the keeping of our so-called 'secrets' and perhaps on one level it does. On another, however, it is a repetition and a reminder of a much older instruction on how to live a pure life:

'Do ye not yet understand, that whatsoever entereth in at the mouth goeth into the belly, and is cast out into the draught?

'But those things which proceed out of the mouth come forth from the heart; and they defile the man.

'For out of the heart proceed evil thoughts, murders, adulteries, fornications, thefts, false witness, blasphemies:

'These are the things which defile a man: but to eat with unwashen hands defileth not a man.'

April 4

For God is the King of all the earth: sing ye praises with understanding.

Psalm 47

Freemasons, certainly those under the jurisdiction of the Grand Lodge of England, are called upon to express a belief in a Supreme Being as a prerequisite to membership. We use the word 'faith' regularly and it appears in our ritual. But what exactly do we mean by it?

Generally, the word is used to mean a belief in God, usually in the absence of concrete 'proof.' In the past, churches were full and the intercession of priests between the people and God was the accepted norm. God was external, a distant being to be placated or worshipped or petitioned. In those days, perhaps, faith was a belief held in the absence of proof.

In these times, though, the sense that God is with us and available to us directly through prayer and meditation, through appreciation and the cultivation of gratitude means that more and more people are able to experience the presence of God for themselves, with no need of an intermediary.

In the light of this, faith becomes not so much a belief without proof, and more of a remembrance; a mindfulness of knowing.

April 5

The Royal Arch...is therefore concerned with truth in the light of eternity, and so leads to a higher understanding of the purpose of our mortal existence.

Ceremony of Exaltation

To walk through this brief life with light hearts and joyful step, knowing that all the things and people we love will come to dust, is the first step on the road to true knowledge. We know that we are mortal and yet we also hold fast to a faith in that immortal principle that guides and animates us. Knowing this and thinking logically about it make it abundantly clear that the purpose of our existence must be to concern ourselves with that which shines light on our eternal existence, not with those things that bring us merely to the brink of the grave. All material things will pass away but all those gifts and joys of the spirit will endure. It is love that lives on when all else has gone, so let us make love our currency, to spend and to share in abundance. Let us fill our days with acts that deny and defy death through generosity of heart and mind and spirit. And, by these things, let us approach that Supreme Being who is light and love and eternity.

April 6

*Great is the LORD, and greatly to be praised in the city
We have thought of thy lovingkindness, O God, in the midst of thy
temple.*

Psalm 48

We love to imagine the temple at Jerusalem and the beauty of the holy mount. As Masons we hold on to three distinct images of it that are overlaid, one on the other, separated by time. We see Abraham building the altar on which he believes he will soon sacrifice his son, Isaac; we see David offering up his prayers for the well-being of his people and, finally, we see Solomon's temple in all its glory, a wonder to all who saw it.

We, too, have our part to play in this still-unfolding story. The temple at Jerusalem may be but a memory and a symbol, but the building of another temple continues to be the work of every Freemason. Not a temple of stone, of course, but an edifice made of a life well lived; of relationships well tended, of love and kindness; of charity, brotherhood and faith. We are only human but we aim for perfection and even if we don't come close, our heartfelt efforts in themselves become a wonder and an inspiration for all.

April 7

Thought will not work, except in silence; neither will virtue work, except in secrecy.'

Thomas Carlyle

Like its sister Mercy, Charity is something that affects both the giver and the receiver. Whether we give money to causes that touch our hearts, or whether we bring relief with a word or a smile, the act of doing good, of practising virtue, benefits the giver in ways that are hard to define. What we can understand, however, is a simple equation: we reap what we sow. A planting of virtuous action will result in a harvest of the spirit that will bring us ever nearer to our true selves and to God. But the seed must germinate in the darkness of secrecy. When we parade our virtue before the world, we expose the fragile shoots and eventually nothing grows. Let us determine to do our good deeds quietly, silently, so that the good we seek to do will come to fruition.

April 8

My mouth shall speak of wisdom; and the meditation of my heart shall be of understanding.

Psalm 49

The faith that relies on belief without proof will always be susceptible to doubt. The faith that needs us simply to remember and act upon what we know - because we have experienced its truth for ourselves - is much firmer, much harder to shake, much more rooted in our experience of ourselves and the world.

It is not always easy to find the source of that knowledge, however. We have to cultivate it through our commitment to live our lives in a certain way: through contemplation, meditation and prayer; through the practice of charity and the understanding of brotherhood we develop the sensitivity to discover God within our hearts. And having found it, we must develop a conscious practice to remember it and to live by what we know.

It may not be easy but the reward is profoundly worth it: a life of certainty, lived without fear.

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April 9

In the second year of Darius the king, in the sixth month, in the first day of the month, came the word of the Lord by Haggai the prophet unto Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, governor of Judah, and to Joshua the son of Josedech, the high priest...

Haggai 1:1

It is easy to act sometimes from impulse, without first considering the implications and possible outcomes of what we do, but it is always worth remembering that all of our actions will cause a chain of reactions that we often can't anticipate and won't see. For that reason, the more we can train ourselves to act from a deeper place of knowing and feeling, trusting our intuition and leaning on the sense of right and wrong that Freemasonry supports within us, our actions will increasingly have beneficial effects as they ripple out from us. Just as Zerubbabel and Joshua waited for the word of God through Haggai, so should we train ourselves to listen and wait for that inner voice to inspire our actions in the world.

April 10

Our God shall come, and shall not keep silence:

Psalm 50

It is said that for evil to prosper all that is required is for good people to do nothing. As Freemasons we are enjoined to refrain from political involvement and the reason is clear: politics is potentially divisive and we strive always for unity. But we are also committed to help the poor, to support the underdog, to ease the burden and suffering of our fellows.

The truth is that Masonic philosophy in its purest sense is ideologically far above the purely political. Freemasonry sees to the heart of the matter and is moved by suffering and injustice wherever they are found. Of course we vote (those of us who live in democracies) for different political parties and that is absolutely our right and our duty as private citizens. As Freemasons, though, we see beyond the divisions of party politics and we look for practical ways to help those in need. The hungry need feeding, the homeless need shelter, the sick need treatment, the despairing need something to hope for.

This is where Freemasonry fits: not in the combative field of party politics, but in the unifying application of practical charity.

We know that all are our brothers and sisters and when we see them suffering we are moved to help.

Charity - love in action. It's what we do.

April 11

Learn something every day, and think often on what you have learned; by this you will gradually form your mind to embrace truth, from whatever quarter it may come.

William Frend

As the significance of the working tools of an Entered Apprentice are explained to a newly initiated Brother, it is stated that, while we take much of our symbolism and myth from the medieval craftsmen whose name we carry, we are not, of course, directly concerned with using the tools in their literal sense. At this point in the ritual we refer to ourselves as speculative Masons and this passing comment is of great significance. We are enjoined, elsewhere, to ‘make a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge’ and so it is clear that study and contemplation are vital parts of a Mason’s ‘work.’ If we are to speculate, on what should we speculate? The ritual helps us there, too. All of human life; the mysteries of Nature and Science; the liberal Arts and Sciences; even death itself is worthy of our contemplation. Our duty is to try to make sense of the world and our place in it. By constant study and mental effort we will, indeed, finally come to understand and embrace Truth.

April 12

Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit within me.

Psalm 51

To live in the fullness of what it means to be human is to shine forth as a clear vessel for the light of God. In our purest state we are embodiments of the divine, embodiments of the love that is the bedrock of creation and the highest virtue to which we can aspire.

The clear mirror of our heart that reflects this love throughout our lives slowly becomes dimmed by the accretion of dust and grime that all our little human weaknesses lay on it over time. Our 'sins' - the actions we perform that are not born out of love and unity and understanding - eventually cause the mirror to become dull and dark and we can no longer fulfil our function to manifest God on earth.

This is why it is so important to keep that mirror clean. Freemasons have a clear set of guidelines that, if followed, will not only keep our mirrors clear, but will also help to clean off what has accrued in the past. Kindness, brotherhood, charity, love; gratitude, forgiveness, empathy. These are the cloths and the polish that will keep those mirrors clear; the tools that we can use to make sure that God's gifts of love and unity come to fruition.

April 13

...three Master Masons from Babylon, having heard that you are about to rebuild the Temple to the honour and glory of God, are anxious to sojourn among you, and to offer their assistance in that great and glorious undertaking.

Ceremony of Exaltation

Sometimes our choices are very clear: whether it is about the right thing to do, the right path to take, or the right way to use our strength and our gifts. Which one of us would not travel through danger and difficulty to work for God, to rebuild the temple and re-establish humanity's true relationship with its Creator? But sometimes in life our choices are not so clearly stated. Sometimes we have to ask ourselves whether this path is the right one; whether, in following it, we will be doing work that is great and glorious, however humble in the eyes of the world, or is it a path of self-serving that puts distance between us and our inner sense of what we know is right?

In all our choices and in all our decisions, let us remember to act 'in the light of eternity.'

April 14

But I am like a green olive tree in the house of God: I trust in the mercy of God for ever and ever.

Psalm 52

It may sometimes appear that we don't gain much by being Freemasons. We don't gain social standing, we don't gain wealth - in fact quite the opposite! The outside world can be quite scornful in its attitudes to Masonry and there is no doubt that our membership costs us money, if not in dues, then in what we give voluntarily for charity.

Invisibly, however, it gives us everything that we need to be happy in this world: a moral code to live by, brothers to walk beside us, companionship and laughter and, most of all, the knowledge that, when our time comes to face that grand leveller of all human experience, we will do so with a clear conscience and a glad heart.

By filling our lives with generosity and kindness and by always speaking thoughtfully and truthfully, we qualify ourselves to enter God's house when our earthly work is done.

April 15

...as a Craftsman, you are expected to make the liberal Arts and Sciences your future study, that you may be the better enabled to discharge your duty as a Mason, and estimate the wonderful works of the Almighty Creator.

Second Degree Ceremony

By understanding the world, we are better able to understand ourselves and our place in it. As Masons we are called upon, not only to contemplate the beauty of the world, but also to make a real mental effort to comprehend the physical laws on which it is built. The physical is a manifestation of the Spiritual and insight into one leads to a clearer apprehension of the other. The liberal Arts and Sciences make sense of the world through language, thought and speech; through number and form; through sound and then beyond: to the movements of the Heavenly spheres themselves. Let us aspire to cultivate a true appreciation of the wonders of the universe and let us base that appreciation on genuine understanding.

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April 16

The fool hath said in his heart, There is no God.

Psalm 53

We see all around us every day the consequences of living in a Godless world. Murder, hatred, violence: these are commonplace. Everywhere we look there are signs of degradation and despair.

Without the belief in a common ancestry, we cannot see each other as kin and so it becomes possible to hate our fellows; to see them as 'other', as different from ourselves; a danger and a challenge.

But once we acknowledge a supreme being, whether that is God as our father or the Earth as our mother, we have to acknowledge each other as brothers and sisters. And once we have done that, where is the room for hatred? How can we murder our brother? Or rape our sister? How can we hate those with whom we share bonds of heart and soul and mind?

We must remove the scales from our eyes and the falsehood from our heart that let us see any other human being as anything other than as an extension of ourselves.

April 17

And I have filled him with the spirit of God, in wisdom, and in understanding, and in knowledge, and in all manner of workmanship...

Exodus 31:2-4

There are many instances of wisdom and closeness to God being linked with knowledge and the craftsmanship of the maker. Through study – which may not only mean an intellectual, academic rigour but also a knowing of the heart and soul – and through creativity, we come closer to our inner selves and that means that we approach closer to God. Our role and function on earth, not just as Masons but also as human beings, is to lift the material up towards the Spiritual and bring the Spiritual down to manifest of earth. When we align ourselves with deep and honest knowing and with constructive, creative making, we begin to be channels for the spirit of God and are ready to be filled with all those gifts that will so benefit the world.

April 18

Save me, O God, by thy name, and judge me by thy strength.

Psalm 54

If we believe that God is absolute - truly omniscient, omnipresent and omnipotent - then it is not so difficult to understand the power that has always surrounded the mystery of the Holy Name.

In Freemasonry, we come to speak of God by way of a series of descriptive epithets: The Great Architect; The Grand Geometrician; The Most High. In the Royal Arch a great and holy name is revealed to us, so powerful that we are enjoined not to speak it aloud and alone but, rather, it may only be spoken when three are gathered.

And yet we know that, across the world, God is known by different names - just as holy, just as powerful - and so we are led to the possibility that either all these names are sacred and powerful or none of them are. Either the idea that God's power resides in the name is a true one or it is not. For us as Masons to entertain the idea that only one name contains these attributes goes against our Masonic understanding that God is One.

And so, we come to understand that, wherever the name of God is invoked and whatever name is used, God will be there for us, to deliver us from our troubles.

April 19

Do not pray for easy lives; pray to be stronger men. Do not pray for tasks equal to your powers; pray for power equal to your tasks.

Phillips Brooks

When we set our feet upon a path such as Freemasonry, we commit ourselves to a process of growth. It is not an easy path as it constantly requires a stretching, a breaking-out of old molds to reshape ourselves in the light of the understanding we acquire. To want 'easy lives' or 'tasks equal to our powers' is to misunderstand the process of our Spiritual evolution and to turn our backs on the course we have chosen. Pain is often part of the process as we leave old selves, old belief systems and old crutches behind. As Freemasons we must accept responsibility for our own march towards the Godhead and so should welcome all difficulties and all challenges.

April 20

We took sweet counsel together, and walked unto the house of God in company.

Psalm 55

How lucky we are to be part of a society of sworn brothers! How joyful it is to know that friendship, advice, help and support are always there for us when we need it! How good it is to know that that friendship is based on something deep and meaningful and lasting.

But what a responsibility it is too. We are not just lucky recipients of those blessings, we are also the source of it for others. As we might call upon them in our times of need, so must we be prepared for them to call upon us in theirs. Then we must be the outstretched hand, the listening ear, the open heart, the strong support.

Our commitment to our Brothers means that we must be willing to be steadfast and true, knowing full well how devastating it can be when someone on whom you rely lets you down. Always in Freemasonry, our own needs should act as reminders of the needs of others and incline our hearts to help them. Even better if we remember that the world is full of our brothers who are not Freemasons.

April 21

Humility and docility are sure indications of merit...

Ceremony of Exaltation

It would be hard to imagine anyone putting the qualities of humility and docility on their CV when applying for a job in the modern world. They are not qualities that are valued and, more than that, they are likely to be thought of as weaknesses and worrying signs of uncertainty and vacillation. Yet, here we see them described as sure indications of merit and, by implication, we are encouraged to cultivate them in ourselves. How can this be?

The reality is, of course, that true humility is a sign of absolute certainty in our sense of who we are and what we understand life to be. It is an indicator of total faith in the ‘wise dispensation of divine providence’ and proof that, as Masons, we see things from a wider perspective than that of mere material considerations. Docility, too, speaks of a submission to the Divine will that – to those who understand such truths – is an excellence of character to which we can all aspire.

April 22

In God have I put my trust: I will not be afraid what man can do unto me.

Psalm 56

As Masons we are comfortable with our faith and happy to join with others under the widest of umbrellas: that we believe in a supreme being. Freemasonry, although its tales and legends are rooted in the Bible, appeals to people of all faiths for the simple reason that it allows each individual to conceive of God in their own way, free from imposed dogma.

This liberality allows us an ease with faith and an ease with each other because we can all rest secure in the knowledge that, deep down, beyond the superficialities that divide us, we hold fast to the same unshakeable ideal of brotherhood.

In good times we wear our faith lightly; so lightly, in fact, that we can forget it's there. Life flows so smoothly that we forget whose hand it is that directs it and we forget the debt of gratitude that is due.

When things go wrong, though - when we are faced with trouble and distress - that is when the value of faith shines through. When illness and the shadow of death come close - when fear threatens to unbalance us - that is when we most have need of trust. That is the time when we know that our trust in God is well founded.

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April 23

All these charges you are to observe...cultivating brotherly love, the foundation and keystone, the cement and glory, of this ancient fraternity...

Antient Charges

Any who doubt that Freemasonry is a Spiritual discipline would do well to think upon this beautiful summary of a Mason's duties. We learn and perform our rituals, we execute the more mundane business of the Lodge, we socialise, we practise Charity; we try to live good and ever better lives. All of these things are undoubtedly valuable and virtuous, worthy and worthwhile; but without the cultivation of love, they have nothing to set them apart from any other human pastime. Charity, the thing that Freemasonry sets such store by and the aspect of the organisation that is most often quoted to the public as our *raison d'être*, is love in action. Without it, giving is no more than an exercise in self-gratification or public relations. Masonic charities are important, as is Charity in the wider sense of the word, but we must understand that it is important to us because of our firm belief in the Brotherhood of all people in God. It is not Charity but the love that actuates it, that is our glory.

April 24

Be merciful unto me, O God, be merciful unto me: for my soul trusteth in thee: yea, in the shadow of thy wings will I make my refuge

Psalm 57

We often say that charity is love in action - that we are moved to charity by the spontaneous outpouring of love that results from our appreciation of the true implication of the fact that we are all Brothers under God.

The same can be said of mercy: that it is a spontaneous outpouring of forgiveness arising from a realisation that we are all weak, that none of us is perfect, that we have all done things of which we are not proud.

Charity inclines our hearts to generosity; mercy teaches us forbearance and compassion to others. It teaches us patience, gentleness and encourages an empathetic understanding of the troubles of others.

As we know, generosity begets generosity; kindness begets kindness; mercy begets mercy.

If we wish to rest in the shelter of God's love and mercy, then we must be prepared to offer those same comforts to all those who ask for ours.

April 25

My companions and I were equally anxious to descend.

Ceremony of Exaltation

One of the great delights that Freemasonry has to offer us is the prospect of an area of personal growth and achievement that is totally free from competition and envy. As Brothers and Companions we delight in each other's successes and we encourage each other's efforts. If there are risks to be taken, we are all equally willing to take them on each other's behalf and to support each other, sharing the responsibility for subsequent failure and success.

Faced with a dark and possibly airless descent into the unknown, all three of our ancient brethren were willing to risk themselves for the benefit of all; all three of them worked together to bring their task to a successful conclusion; all three of them shared the benefit, praise and preferment that resulted. Let us take those three ancient sojourners as an example in our own lives, understanding that, by helping each other we help ourselves and, when our efforts are directed towards the light, we help the world at large.

April 26

*So that a man shall say, Verily there is a reward for the righteous:
verily he is a God that judgeth in the earth.*

Psalm 58

We all have dark thoughts; we all have a dark side: a side that wants to call down destruction on those who wrong us; a side that wants to lash out when we are hurt or threatened. Our primitive instincts are strong within us and, when we give them free reign, they thirst for vengeance and retribution.

Yet also within us is a divine spark; an essential part of the divinity that resides in all of life and this tiny drop of water in the ocean of life, this shard or splinter of light that shines in our depths, is what has the power to lift us beyond our base instincts into higher realms of mercy and compassion.

Freemasons are not beasts. We work to subdue our baser passions and, while we acknowledge that they exist, we use the tools that Freemasonry gives us to transform their energy into finer stuff.

Thus vengeance becomes mercy, judgement becomes forbearance, intolerance becomes understanding, antipathy becomes empathy.

This is the true work of a Freemason: to turn the lead of our basest selves into the gold of purest Spirit. This is the true aim and miracle of alchemy.

April 27

...a time will most assuredly come when all distinctions save those of Piety and Virtue shall cease and Death, the grand leveller of all human greatness shall reduce us all to the same state.

Second Degree Ceremony

Whatever comes to us after death, Freemasons, being believers in God, tend to cling to the hope that we will continue to exist in a sphere of being that is more Spiritual than this earthly round and closer to God. We hold on to a faith that teaches us that goodness will be rewarded when our time comes. That may indeed be true, but, as Masons, we develop the firm conviction that goodness is its own reward in this life and, when Death comes for us, we think, not of our own reward, but of the world we leave behind. Is it a better place for our having sojourned here for a short while? Outward distinctions of rank, riches and influence will come to naught when Death strikes us, but will we leave behind us that greatest of legacies: a good name?

April 28

But I will sing of thy power; yea, I will sing aloud of thy mercy in the morning: for thou hast been my defence and refuge in the day of my trouble.

Psalms 59

While it is true that forgiveness is one the greatest gifts that we can bestow on our fellow creatures, and while it is the blessing of God we most desire and need to live a full, open life, we cannot deny that sometimes our thoughts are taken by baser wishes.

Ultimately, we understand that we have no control over what others do or what befalls them as a consequence. We exercise a certain amount of power in our own lives by the choices we make, but even then, nothing is certain.

Which is why, in the end, to pray for particular outcomes is not only vain but leaves us open to the disappointments of false expectation and the weakening of faith that can accompany it.

Our greatest prayer, in every circumstance, is joyful, total surrender: ‘Thy will be done.’

April 29

That, Most Excellent, we must humbly beg to decline...

Ceremony of Exaltation

It takes a great deal of courage to stand up for what we believe and to stay true to our own understanding of what is right and wrong. As Freemasons we are enjoined and committed to pay due regard to the laws of the lands in which we reside, but we are also obliged to obey 'the moral law.' So what happens when these two things clash? Luckily it is rare that this happens but if it does it can produce a conflict that is very difficult to resolve. Ultimately, there is no easy answer other than to search inside ourselves and to listen to the voice of our conscience. We are all responsible for our own actions and all subject, in the end, to higher laws that are often beyond our comprehension. To follow our own moral compass sometimes seems to be the only solution.

And how can Freemasonry help us? At least it might help us to be sure that our moral compass is properly calibrated.

April 30

O God, thou hast cast us off, thou hast scattered us, thou hast been displeased; O turn thyself to us again.

Psalm 60

In the second degree we hear the story of Jephtha and his brothers; of how Jephtha was cast out and then reinstated to high honour. We hear how God habitually subjected the people ‘...to the inroads and oppressions of neighbouring gentile nations...’ as a punishment for abandoning the laws of their forefathers. When the people repented, however, God ‘...never failed to raise them up a champion and deliverer.’

We are told that the people ‘repeatedly’ forsook the laws of their forefathers and that God ‘never failed’ to redeem them

What we learn from this is that it wasn’t a one-off; a momentary lapse in judgement by the people - it was habitual. In other words the story tells us that, as humans - even though we Freemasons like to think of ourselves as ‘good’ ones - we will fall down; we will fall short; we will keep going wrong. It’s in our nature: we are not perfect.

But, happily, it is God’s nature to forgive. However often we err, however far we stray from the right path, God is there to wash away the past and let us try again. We are creatures of dust, animated by God’s breath and that divine spark within us is love, a love that is merciful, kind and patient.

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May 1

He, of all men, should best understand that God seeth not as man seeth; for man looketh at the outward appearance, but God looketh to the heart. A mason is, therefore, particularly bound never to act against the dictates of his conscience.

Antient Charges

When we step on to a Spiritual path such as that offered to us by Freemasonry, we step beyond the value system of the outside world where rank, power and possessions hold so much sway. We embark upon a journey that we hope will raise us above the shallow and illusory delights of the mundane world and seek something deeper and more constant. While we live in the world, we understand our true purpose to be to rise above it and come at last to a point where everything of value that we wish for is to be found in things of the Spirit: to be able to offer brotherly love to all, relief of the suffering of our fellows and a firm grasp of truth. Let us try to learn to see beyond outward appearances and look, as God does, to the heart. With our attitudes and aspirations thus founded on true values, we will be better placed to exercise that freedom of conscience that Freemasonry allows us in all spheres of our lives, understanding always that freedom carries with it a great burden of responsibility.

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May 2

For thou, O God, hast heard my vows: thou hast given me the heritage of those that fear thy name.

Psalm 61

Although they are one of the main things that the outside world often finds most threatening about Freemasonry, our obligations are, in some ways, the most reassuring as they commit us to a life of selflessness, kindness and support for others, Masons and non-Masons alike.

Our only exclusive obligation is the one that binds us not to reveal the ‘secrets’ of Freemasonry but in these days of the internet when everything is freely available, we must reconsider exactly what we mean by our secrets.

A non-Mason could be in possession of the signs, words and tokens of a Mason and still not pass muster. And even if they did, every step along the road of untruth and duplicity would take them further away from what are our most precious - if open - secrets.

The peaceful mind and the calm heart that come from an untroubled conscience, free from the taint of falsehood, lightened by the sharing of troubles with brothers, attuned to the divine and to the highest aspirations - these are Freemasonry’s true secrets and they are available to all who are prepared to work for the common good.

May 3

...it was not lawful for any man to pronounce that Sacred and Mystrious name of the True and Living God Most High, but the High Priest, nor he but once a year, and then only when he entered the Holy of Holies, and stood before the Ark of the Covenant to make propitiation for the sins of the people.

Third Degree Tracing Board

In the Craft we are led to an understanding of the sacred nature of the Name of God, a word once believed to be so powerful that to pronounce it in the wrong circumstances could reduce the speaker to ashes.

In the Royal Arch, we begin to learn what that name might be and, although further knowledge will be added later, we are taught to appreciate that this is a new step in our relationship with our Creator and that everything we learn in the Royal Arch is designed to cement that relationship further. Ultimately, for us, the name becomes a symbol of our growing closeness to God and our increasing appreciation of the way in which our lives unfold towards the bearer of that name in the same way that a flower unfolds towards the sun.

May 4

Surely men of low degree are vanity, and men of high degree are a lie:

Psalm 62

Freemasonry, through the symbolism of the level, teaches equality and recognises that all people are both creatures of the dust and sparks of the divine.

There are dangers in the Masonic system though. We are an initiatory order and we ascend clearly laid out steps on the path that leads us from base materiality to the realms of the divine. On the way we collect honours and titles and, if we are not careful, the outer signs of our advancement will halt our inner progress altogether, leaving us outwardly elevated but inwardly stunted, seduced by finery and far from the path we first set out to follow.

Our ritual tells us that we are all equal and that means that the newest Entered Apprentice is of no less value within our system than the Grand Master himself. What differentiates them is time, experience and the knowledge and wisdom to be gained on the path. But if the search for knowledge and wisdom is forgotten in the seeking after rank and station, then rank and station mean nothing.

Our ritual speaks of advancement through merit and merit is gained through study, contemplation and the everyday application of our Masonic values. If we are to move forward, we must be sure of our intention.

May 5

As an Individual, let me recommend the practice of every domestic as well as public virtue.

First Degree Ceremony

Masonic Ritual often reminds us of the inherent differences between our public and private lives. So much of our daily existence is public - our jobs, our hobbies, our social circles - that it is an easy mistake to think that it is our actions in these spheres that are the most important. It is not that difficult to win acclaim in the eyes of those who are not closest to us. Charitable activities, outward charm and beneficence are enough to gain the world's approval. However, if we do not live to the same high standards in private - with our partners, our children, our close friends and relatives - who are we fooling? While the practice of public virtue may win for us a good name, it is only the practice of domestic virtue that will win for us the precious gifts of a clear conscience and an untroubled mind.

May 6

O God, thou art my God; early will I seek thee: my soul thirsteth for thee, my flesh longeth for thee in a dry and thirsty land, where no water is;

Psalm 63

We become Freemasons - hopefully - because we have arrived at a point in our lives when we realise that there is more to this earthly existence than the endless cycle of work-eat-sleep; more than working hard to earn a living to pay bills and mortgages and taxes. We come from all walks of life and there is no doubt that amongst us there are some who struggle to make ends meet while others are lucky enough to be able to enjoy all the sensual delights that material existence has to offer.

Eventually, though, even the most delightful of delights lose their savour and our soul awakens to the idea that satisfaction needs to be found in something deeper, more long-lasting, more real. For a while we may be able to ignore this growing yearning but, once awake, it's hard to go back to sleep - it's hard to 'unknow' what we understand more and more clearly to be the truth.

And so it is, with souls thirsting for God, we arrive at the door of the Lodge, ready to knock, ready to take that first step into the unknown, from darkness to light.

May 7

...emblems of that purity of heart and rectitude of conduct which should always actuate all those who are exalted into this Supreme Order.

Ceremony of Exaltation

On entering Freemasonry, we are likened to a rough ashlar, lacking education and knowledge. As we progress through the Craft we become refined, our understanding grows and we aim to become perfect ashlar, ready to be used in the building of a great temple to the glory of God. A perfect building stone has perfect dimensions and conforms perfectly to the architect's plans. A perfect human being is one who perfectly reflects the Great Architect's plans for the world and that, as we know, is one who most ably brings into being the virtues of faith, hope and love. By the time we have descended into the vaulted chamber and found the light of God by which we are to live, we hope to be in the position of being able to commit ourselves to those high ideals.

May 8

Hear my voice, O God, in my prayer: preserve my life from fear of the enemy. Hide me from the secret counsel of the wicked; from the insurrection of the workers of iniquity:

Psalm 64

The three guiding principles of our order are Brotherly Love, Relief and Truth. Like all of the teachings of Freemasonry, the idea of truth is multi-faceted and many-layered,

First of all, we understand the basic truth of the existence of a Supreme Being; then we accept the truth of our brotherhood under that divinity. Truth is also an aspect of our obligations: we are enjoined and expected to be truthful in our dealings with others and to be true to ourselves.

What we cannot control are the words and deeds of others and when they are untruthful, whether from ignorance or malice, it can be hurtful and damaging.

Freemasonry has many detractors and there are those who would have us believe that the path we walk is an unholy one. We experience it differently and rest secure in our trust in God and in our own intuitions and understanding. We know that our truth is strong and robust; that it can withstand scrutiny and the attacks of its detractors. We know that it will not let us down in the final reckoning because, in the end, we know that it is real. We know that it is true.

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May 9

Masonry recognizes the right of every man to worship God freely and according to the dictates of his own conscience and in his own way and according to the forms and ceremonies of his choice.

Arthur S. Tomkins

We are so often divided by the superficialities of our lives. Even the most profound aspects of our thoughts and our beliefs can so easily cause dissension. The endless wars that have been fought because of religion or ideology are proof enough of that. By bringing us together, united in our faith but at the same time recognising that each of us may understand and approach God in our own way, Freemasonry avoids the differences that divide one narrow creed or dogma from another and concentrates on the glorious truth that, whatever our race, our caste, our creed, we are all God's children.

May 10

The pastures are clothed with flocks; the valleys also are covered over with corn; they shout for joy, they also sing.

Psalms 65

The seeking of truth and knowledge is one of the prime aims of a Freemason. Of course, we love the sense of fraternity and comfort that our meetings give us. Our social events and our festive boards are times of joy and laughter - and rightly so. It is '...good and pleasant ...when brethren dwell together in unity.' But we also know that there is more to Freemasonry than that. What goes on inside the Lodge is the key to what we are - and what goes on in the lodge is the unlocking of the secrets of who we are and what our purpose is here on earth.

Knowledge and understanding are good in themselves but we also hope that from them will spring the wisdom to appreciate that knowledge and to use it for the common good.

As Freemasons, our primary attitude is one of gratitude: for the beauty of the world, for our place in it and for the opportunities that we have to make it a little better and therefore a little more beautiful.

The knowledge and understanding that Freemasonry offers us means little if it does not lead us here.

May 11

...there are three epochs in the history of Freemasonry which particularly merit your attention. They are, the openings of the First or Holy Lodge, the Second or Sacred Lodge, and the Third or Grand and Royal Lodge.

Historical Lecture

In Masonic terms, these three historical events mark significant moments in our understanding of the Divine and of our relationship with God. The first Lodge relates to the time of Moses and the giving of Law. This is often cited as the moment when organised society came into being, with a set of codified laws and an agreed, shared morality. The second Lodge relates to the building of the first Temple in Jerusalem – the subject of Craft Freemasonry – and may be seen, not only as the beginning of formal worship of God in a set place but also as a time of a falling away, when our secrets were lost and we were left to contemplate a universe in which God was distant and we were no longer able to receive the light that came from above. And the third Lodge represents rediscovery and renewal; a reaffirmation of faith; a rebuilding of God's Temple and a rediscovery of God's word.

May 12

*Make a joyful noise unto God, all ye lands:
Sing forth the honour of his name: make his praise glorious.*

Psalm 66

We are told at the end of the lecture on the first degree tracing board that the distinguishing characteristics of a good Freemason are, ‘...virtue, honour and mercy.’ These are fine attributes and there is no question that we should aspire to develop them in all aspects of our lives.

However, we might also like to consider a fourth ‘distinguishing characteristic’ which could be considered to be a natural by-product of the other three: happiness.

When we live our lives according to ‘Masonic line and rule’ we align ourselves with the true and lasting values that they represent; we follow the path we were meant to tread; we fulfill our proper role as co-creators of God’s world. Knowing that all these things are true and also secure in our faith and the hope that it gives us, how can we be anything other than full of gratitude and joy?

May 13

...a poor candidate in a state of darkness.

First Degree Ceremony

Although there are practical reasons why a candidate must first enter the Lodge blindfolded, the greater reason, as ever in Freemasonry, is symbolic. Darkness here stands for many things: the fact that we enter Freemasonry not knowing the full extent of its teachings; that we enter this world ignorant of what has come before and what will come after. But, before long, in the course of the ceremony, the blindfold is removed and light is restored. With light comes the knowledge and understanding of direct experience and we are led to appreciate that darkness, or ignorance, is not our proper state. We are born to seek the light, to strive for understanding, and Freemasonry teaches us the beautiful lesson that, in time and with effort, we may all come to understand the truth.

May 14

*Before God's footstool to confess
A poor soul knelt and bowed his head;
'I failed,' he cried. The master said,
'Thou didst thy best - that is success!'*

Anon

Masons, being human, are generally less than perfect. Anybody who expects otherwise has a poor understanding of human nature and if perfection were a requirement for membership, there would be very few Masons indeed. Freemasonry itself, though, may be deemed to be perfect, in that it provides a vehicle for us to embark on a path that may eventually, through our own efforts, lead us to that perfection which we have come to understand is the ultimate goal of human endeavour. So, perfection is not required of us, but what is expected is a deep and heartfelt commitment to try to do our best in all spheres at all times. No one can ask us for more.

May 15

God be merciful unto us, and bless us; and cause his face to shine upon us;

Psalm 67

There is no doubt that gratitude is the fertile soil in which contentment grows. To wake up every morning with a grateful heart is to take active, conscious measures to ensure our own well-being and happiness.

We have so much to be grateful for: we are alive on this beautiful world; we have the friendship and support of our brethren; we have our faith in God. Even in times of difficulty, when finances are difficult or when relationships go awry, to have these three things is to be in possession of great treasures because when worldly wealth is gone and the time of truth is at hand, it is love and gratitude that will see us through to that brighter world where the blessed Architect ‘...lives and reigns forever.’

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May 16

...and from this, the strongest of all architectural forms, we learn the necessity of guarding our Mysteries from profanation...

Symbolical Lecture

The catenarian arch is one that is associated with all sorts of esoteric speculation and symbolism. It is considered to be the strongest because all the forces at work within it are perfectly balanced. In the Royal Arch, we also consider it to be a fitting symbol of what we are and what we do. The form of the Chapter itself is meant to reflect its perfect symmetry and, symbolically, we are called upon to demonstrate its inviolate strength in keeping our mysteries unsullied. It is interesting to note here that secrecy itself is not the issue; it is the idea of ensuring that our rites and ceremonies are restricted to those who will respect and preserve them. There is a verse in the New Testament which enjoins the same thing: “Do not give what is holy to the dogs; nor cast your pearls before swine, lest they trample them under their feet, and turn and tear you in pieces.” (Matthew 7:6)

May 17

So far as I am acquainted with the principles and doctrines of Freemasonry, I conceive it to be founded in benevolence and be exercised only for the good of mankind...

George Washington

What a lovely thought! That Freemasonry is ‘founded in benevolence’ is indisputable. The endless theories put forward to explain the origins of our institution disagree on almost every point, but on one they are unanimous: Freemasonry was founded to bring benefit to the world. However, to believe that it is ‘exercised only for the good of mankind’ remains, at best, an idealistic dream. To make the dream come true should be the desire of every Mason who truly loves the Craft. To do this requires from each one of us a commitment to make our membership of it an influence in our lives that works for the benefit of all with whom we come into contact. We should reflect, each day, on the principles of our Order and put them into joyful practice, exercising them for the general good.

May 18

Princes shall come out of Egypt; Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands unto God. Sing unto God, ye kingdoms of the earth; O sing praises unto the Lord;

Psalm 68

When our ritual talks about Freemasonry being universally spread over the surface of the globe, we should pause for a moment and consider the fact that this is not just a ritualistic formulation but also a statement of fact. We are able to number among our brethren people of every race and every religion: from every continent and every country. Our ritual is performed in many different languages with countless variations and local idiosyncrasies.

It is one of the reasons why we should always encourage visiting between lodges, districts and even constitutions. It can be so easy to fall into the trap of thinking that the way our lodge does things is the only way and for the ritual that we are so familiar with to become stale and lose its power to stir us.

But in travelling and visiting, we come to understand that while the Freemasonry that we know and love can appear to be so different in its outer form, at its core it is the same;. In the same way we understand that God, whose names are slowly revealed to us as we progress, is known by many more names across the globe, but remains - always - the one true God.

May 19

Understand that as the mighty wind, blowing everywhere, rests always in the sky, all created beings rest in Me.

Bhagavad Gita 9:6

Freemasonry provides us with a framework in which we can pursue our public and private lives with success and satisfaction. We can walk the paths of this world secure in our faith, happy that we are aiming to make our lives meaningful to ourselves and to all those with whom we come in contact. When things go wrong or when we feel adrift, when we've gone astray and the darkness threatens to engulf us, we should remember that we walk always in God; that the Divine essence of our Creator also resides within us and that, even though we may feel lost, that Divine spark is still there, shining its light through the gloom and guiding us home, back onto the path that leads to fulfilment and peace.

May 20

I am become a stranger unto my brethren, and an alien unto my mother's children.

Psalm 69

There is a tendency, when times are bad and things are difficult, for us to withdraw into ourselves. It seems to be a natural - if strange - instinct within us to not want to share bad news, even to feel ashamed of our difficulties and illnesses, - mental, physical and spiritual - as if they somehow are the result of some moral failing or insufficiency to which others are not prone.

Luckily, our brotherhood is so ordered that none of us should ever feel isolated for long. Within our lodges mechanisms exist to make sure that no Brother falls out of sight for long before someone - usually the Almoner or some close brother - will do what is necessary to check whether all is well. These mechanisms are real and practical supports for many brethren and those of us who take on those caring roles are to be praised and thanked and, of course, supported in their turn.

We live with the hope that our faith and our brotherhood will be enough to prevent us slipping into despondency, but life can be hard and we all have moments of despair. In those moments, it's good to know that we have help at hand, physical as well as spiritual.

May 21

...Masonry, according to the general acceptation of the term is an Art founded on the principles of Geometry, and directed to the service and convenience of mankind.

First Lecture

That Freemasonry is directed to the ‘service and convenience of mankind’ is a truth that we should ever bear in mind as we move from the close confines of our Lodge meetings to our wider lives in the outside world. But that it is founded purely on the principles of Geometry is harder to grasp. We know that Freemasonry is a ‘peculiar system of morality, veiled in allegory, and illustrated by symbols,’ but to state that the Order is founded on principles of Geometry is a big leap of understanding. We need to spend time contemplating the truth of this statement. Geometrical structures obey strict laws and describe a perfection of shape, angle and form that cannot be altered. So it is with our lives and with the universe as a whole. It, too, is founded on unalterable laws and it, too, we have to assume, is perfect. Let us make it our constant duty to try to comprehend these laws and so tailor our daily lives as to live in accordance with them.

May 22

When a man finds his path, heaven is kind.

Anon.

One of the great things that Freemasonry can do for us is to provide pointers on the road of life that help to keep us on the right path. Although it is up to each of us to find our own way and to discover our own truths and our own sense of what is right for us and our connections, there is no doubt that Freemasonry can provide a framework that helps keep us within due bounds: with ourselves, our connections and with God. Life can often be difficult and the way sometimes is not that clear, but if we use the tools that the Craft and Royal Arch put at our disposal, we will find that it becomes more easily visible, more easy to tread and more joyful to follow to the end.

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May 23

Let them be ashamed and confounded that seek after my soul: let them be turned backward, and put to confusion, that desire my hurt.

Psalms 70

It's very strange that even when we go out of our way to show the world how positive a force for good Freemasonry can be, there are still those who denigrate us and who treat us with suspicion and anger.

It is tempting to respond with a touch of self-righteous indignation when this happens but we have to accept that some people are not open to new ideas and will only disbelieve everything we tell them and twist our meaning to suit theirs. If we respond with the same negative emotions we only serve to reinforce their prejudices and build up even more resentment and lies.

In the end, we know that truth is stronger than untruth. It may be that lies are sometimes easier to believe and easier to spread but, ultimately, the truth is true because it is real. It is strong; it will be what lasts.

May 24

...and honourable it must be acknowledged to be, as by a natural tendency it conduces to make those so who are obedient to its precepts.

First Degree Ceremony

Because it assumes a starting point of Faith, Masonry relies less on this concept than its counterpart, Religion. It is not so much concerned with imposing and supporting a belief system as with promoting the principles of sound actions. As such, it is less emotional than Religion and is often more a simple formula for good living. The precepts it expounds are endorsed by all religions and they are so embedded in Masonic ritual and symbolism that it is impossible to follow them and not become a better person. As we renew our determination to live by the Masonic 'line and rule' we should do so in the awareness that, as we are deemed honourable by our association with Freemasonry, so the Craft itself is deemed honourable only through our actions.

May 25

The three greater lights represent the Sacred Name itself, and the triune essence of the Deity; and are emblematical of His creative, preservative, and annihilative powers.

Symbolical Lecture

It is quite rare that we see this articulation of God's nature into three distinct powers. The idea of God as three-in-one is not uncommon and the strength and sense of the rightness of the idea of the Trinity is reflected a great deal in the Royal Arch. Here, three travel, seek and find and three rule. Interestingly, the three attributes of the Godhead outlined here are widely recognised in Hinduism where the divine essence of Brahman is expressed and known through the three deities of Brahma – the Creator, Vishnu – the Preserver and Shiva – the Destroyer.

How wonderful to be given this glimpse of the Universality of the truths to which we subscribe. Let us consider for a moment that great truth that Freemasonry is, indeed, spread around the globe and that everywhere where its light shines, minds are illumined and lives are touched by its benevolence.

May 26

O God, thou hast taught me from my youth: and hitherto have I declared thy wondrous works.

Psalm 71

Truth wears many guises and there is never any suggestion that Freemasonry is anything other than one of the innumerable paths that lead to the refinement and spiritualisation of humanity and eventually to the feet of God. But that doesn't make the truths of Freemasonry any less true. All 'truths' are really just different framings of the one truth: that God is one and that we are all God's children. Everything beyond that exists to illustrate and cement this truth in our hearts and minds.

But because Freemasonry is true, it lasts; it stands the test of time. What was true in 1717 when the United Grand Lodge of England was formed, is still true now and will still be true in another three hundred years, even in another three thousand.

We must remain confident in the teachings that Freemasonry offers. The moral code, the particular framing of truth that it carries - these are good and strong and timeless. We can live by them and teach them to our children without fear. They will not let us down.

May 27

Grandeur of character lies wholly in the force of soul, in the force of thought, moral principles, and love, and this may be found in the humblest conditions of life.

William Ellery Channing

As Freemasons we value the concept of grandeur. It is symbolised most forcefully in our rituals through our vision of that grand Temple, God's house, the home of our highest aspirations. We see grandeur not as an outward, ostentatious display of wealth, rank or privilege, but as an inner strength, an inner virtue that shines out from the depths of a person's soul. To achieve this grandeur of character we must cultivate the highest standards of conduct, be true to the dictates of our conscience and, as ever, try to put into constant practice our belief in the principle of brotherly love. This is the way of virtue and, thus, of inner grandeur.

May 28

A man to personify intelligence and understanding; a lion to represent strength and power; an ox to denote the ministration of patience and assiduity; and an eagle to indicate the promptness and celerity with which the will and pleasure of the Great I AM are always executed.

Symbolical Lecture

There is no doubt that human beings have different attributes, talents and character traits. Some are artists or musicians, writers and physicists. Some are builders and home-makers, some are listeners, talkers; the list is as endless as it is fascinating, telling as it does the story of human development, endeavour and interest. How good it would be if we could learn to use our talents and strengths, whatever they may be, to their fullest potential. How good it would be to be able to encourage the gifts that are waiting to be realised by others. How good it would be to understand that all of our gifts, all of our strengths and talents are best used in the service of God and for the benefit of all of living creatures.

May 29

Give the king thy judgments, O God, and thy righteousness unto the king's son.

Psalm 72

Solomon himself is the subject of this Psalm and, in a way, it contains a blueprint for the ideal ruler. When we finally come to sit in the Master's chair - the throne of Solomon - we would do well to consider the ruling of our Lodge in line with the attributes outlined here. Of course, justice, honour and mercy are familiar ideals to Freemasons but peace, too, is paramount. To bring peace and harmony to our Lodge is vital for its effective functioning and the Master's role is to embody and promote this peace as an example to all the brethren.

It is also worth considering how we will act as we move yet higher towards Provincial and Grand Lodge honours and how our positions of increasing influence might be used for the good of Freemasonry and the world at large.

It is also good to consider the rulers of Freemasonry themselves. They carry a weight of responsibility on their shoulders to guide the Craft safely into a strange new world. We pray that they, too, will be guided always by those truly Masonic virtues of truth, justice, honour and mercy. May they - with our help - bring peace and light to every dark corner their influence reaches.

May 30

...as in the previous degree you made yourself acquainted with the principles of moral truth, you are now permitted to extend your researches into the hidden mysteries of nature and science.

Second Degree Lecture

If the liberal Arts and Sciences are the foundations of knowledge in the second degree, then it is the twin mysteries of Divine Creation and human understanding that form the bedrock on which they stand. Knowledge is power and it is not for nothing that we are led to its portals along the path of morality and virtue. Masonry calls itself a progressive science and recognises that we must develop our character before we can be entrusted with that which has the power to awaken our souls. We must be perfect vessels for the sacred balm our system offers, perfect ashlar in the building of the universal Temple.

May 31

Thus saith Cyrus king of Persia, All the kingdoms of the earth hath the Lord God of heaven given me; and he hath charged me to build him an house in Jerusalem, which is in Judah. Who is there among you of all his people? The Lord his God be with him, and let him go up.

2 Chronicles 36:23

Sometimes the right thing to do is very clear and when that happens life seems very easy. Sometimes we envy those characters in the Bible stories because we feel that if we had God telling us what to do as clearly as they did, we wouldn't be wracked by doubts and insecurities. But life isn't like that very often so we spend much of our time scrabbling around trying to figure out the correct way to behave at any given moment, weighing up who will be affected by our actions and how. Sometimes it can all get too much.

So, every now and then, it is good to reflect on how lucky we are to have something that gives us a firm anchor in these stormy seas. Freemasonry does not provide all the answers to life's problems but it does, at least, point us in the right direction.

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June 1

So foolish was I, and ignorant: I was as a beast before thee.

Psalm 73

Every positive emotion has a dark shadow. Even love of God - surely the most positive emotion it is possible for a human being to attain - contains the seeds of danger for the unwary. When we first find love of God in our hearts, it is our particular conception of God that moves us and rightly so because the first part of our search is to find a way to understand and conceive of the Divine in terms that we can comprehend. It is only later, as our love grows more certain, that we come to understand the infinitely multi-faceted nature of the Deity and so come to realise that all facets show and reflect the Light equally.

In the early days of our faith, it is easy to look down on others who seem to have no conception of God at all; even worse, sometimes, is the tendency to take issue with those who conceive of God in a way different from ourselves. It is here that war and conflict arise and it is here that the great shadow stands, to cast darkness over all our spiritual progress.

We must hold fast to the Masonic virtues of tolerance and love if we are to pass through the darkness that this shadow threatens and come, at last, to the sunlight of the greater truth. There is no God but God and God is One.

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June 2

To steer the bark of this life over the rough seas of passion, without quitting the helm of rectitude is the highest degree of perfection to which human nature is capable of attaining.

Second Degree Ceremony

There is no doubt that one of the highest tasks we can aim for as human beings is the overcoming of our baser passions, our lower selves. All of our religions and all our history teach us that we are engaged on a slow upward path from physicality to Spirituality. We often go wrong, thinking that we should try to subdue our passions completely, but this would be to deny that we have a lower self at all. We must learn to control our passions, not suppress them, and to do that we need something to hold on to, to give us strength: our philosophies and our religions. For those of us who have chosen Freemasonry as our boat over these 'rough seas,' the moral framework which we build around the symbolism of the Craft must be strong enough to survive all the raging storms of this life. For that, we must build it with care.

June 3

...the Royal Arch signs mark in a peculiar manner the relation we bear to the Almighty, as creatures offending against His mighty will and power, yet still the adopted children of His mercy.

Mystical Lecture

All of the signs in the Royal Arch speak to us of the humility and reverence due from a creature to its Creator. We approach our Maker on bended knee, with eyes downcast, demonstrating our weakness and fragility before the great light that burns brightly around us. But we are also mindful of the great love that supports us and lifts us; the deepest sympathy for our weaknesses and failings; the endless patience of a parent for a beloved child. Let us consider how we might always be worthy of that great love and also how we might share it and manifest it in our own lives, through our dealings with others.

June 4

O let not the oppressed return ashamed: let the poor and needy praise thy name.

Psalm 74

Intolerance is the enemy of Freemasonry. Every form of prejudice and discrimination stands in direct opposition to the ideals and truths that we espouse. No religious dogma, no racial or cultural bias; no '-ism' of any kind has any place in any Lodge under any jurisdiction of Freemasons anywhere in the world.

More than this, Freemasonry must make itself the outspoken critic of discrimination in all its forms and the greatest, most powerful tools that it has at its disposal are the words and actions of individual Masons.

It is up to us to be the visible face of Freemasonry and to be ambassadors for its philosophy of inclusion and tolerance. This doesn't mean that we have to get embroiled in discussions about the pros and cons of identity politics - anything overtly political is beyond our remit - but it does mean that we treat every individual on his or her own merit and that we relate to everybody without prejudice, with open hearts and open minds, seeing in them nothing more or less than a brother - or a sister - of the dust.

June 5

*There is so much good in the worst of us,
And so much bad in the best of us,
That it ill behoves any of us
To find fault with the rest of us.*

Anon

One of the finest and, paradoxically, one of the most practical aspects of Freemasonry is that it teaches us only to be the very best we can, not try to be what we cannot. Like Jacob's ladder, Freemasonry is planted firmly on the ground in our humanity but reaches to the heavens in our higher selves. While having the highest of ideals, it recognises all human weakness, thereby giving us realistic expectations and aspirations. Being a good Freemason therefore means that we must acknowledge our own weaknesses and strengths and, through them, learn to deal more kindly, more compassionately, with the faults of others.

June 6

How strained and wretched would be our life, if our hope were not so spacious and extensive!

Mohamed Abu Alahmar (attrib.)

Life can be very difficult sometimes and it feels as if we are forever struggling in the darkness. All of our efforts as Entered Apprentice, Fellow Craft and Master Mason led us to the brink of the grave and it seems, that in life, too, none of our efforts will be enough to lift us from the round of our earthly existence into the realms of Light. Luckily, we have our faith and this faith naturally creates in us a hope that is directed at nothing less than the throne of God.

When things appear dark, let us remember that help is at hand: our Companions will lift us out of the airless vault and together our hopes will help us to ascend to the very summit of Jacob's Ladder, '...that ethereal mansion, not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.'

June 7

Unto thee, O God, do we give thanks, unto thee do we give thanks:

Psalm 75

By approaching all that we do in a spirit of service to the greater good and gratitude for our many blessings, we avoid the dangers that potentially threaten our spiritual growth.

Freemasons are committed to acting in this world in such a way that the idea of service should be second nature. We acknowledge the interconnectedness of all life and we know that the suffering of one is the suffering of all. In the light of this understanding, we do not become overly proud of our accomplishments and achievements; our fortune, our gifts and talents; our strength and our intelligence. Instead, we give thanks that we possess at least some of those attributes when we see that so many do not. We give thanks for our families and friends, our loved ones and our brethren, appreciating that we have what so many lack.

And then we put all those gifts to work in the service of that wider brotherhood we call life on Earth.

June 8

...while some must rule and teach others, of necessity, must learn to submit and obey; humility in each is an essential virtue.

Installation Ceremony

Although the world at large is increasingly shying away from hierarchical structures for fear that they might somehow undermine our essential equality, we as Freemasons understand that, while inequalities exist between people in many ways, our basic worth as children of God is unalterable. From the basis of that understanding, we also recognise that all Initiatory paths are hierarchical in structure and Freemasonry is no different.

The first important thing to acknowledge is that our system advocates advancement through merit and that merit is gained through effort. The second is that Freemasonry understands that there is always more to learn. Whether you are a new initiate or a Past Master, further study will bring its rewards. A constant attitude of receptiveness is what opens us - heart and mind - to new and deeper truths and it is this grateful receptivity that we call humility.

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June 9

...we are taught...to bend with humility and resignation beneath the chastening hand of the Most High, and at the same time engraft his law on our heart.

Mystical Lecture

A young man once sat at the feet of a Master and listened to the teachings that flowed from the wise one's lips. At the end of the talk all the other students bowed down in reverence but the young man could not. He did not know this teacher and was not sure that it was right to surrender himself in this way to someone he was unsure was worthy of it. When the others were gone, the teacher smiled at the young man and said, "You were right to hesitate; it is true that I, myself, am not worthy of your reverence. But when we bow before a teacher, it is the teachings we salute, not the person. We salute the Truth."

The young man prostrated himself with a clear heart and went on his way, happy...

Let us always find it in our hearts to surrender ourselves completely to the Truth, wherever we find it, knowing that God resides within it.

June 10

*Thou didst cause judgment to be heard from heaven; the earth feared,
and was still,*

Psalm 76

There is a key Buddhist teaching that tells us that, in this world, things are not what they appear to be. It is an idea that is reflected in other traditions of course and Freemasonry is no exception.

We know that the outer values of the world are often different to the inner values that Freemasonry seeks to inculcate in those who choose to make it their path. We know the difference, for example, between worldly wealth and the true treasures of the spirit. We know that physical strength will fail in time while strength of character will grow stronger the more it is exercised, even into our old age; we know that power and influence can be snatched away on a whim; that the measures of worldly success are fickle and untrustworthy. And did we not learn unequivocally at our Raising that worldly possessions lead us directly to the cold grave from which only love can lift us?

Through the teachings contained in our rituals and, perhaps more importantly, through the company and support of our brethren, we are able to remember that truth lies behind and beyond all the outer shows of the world. We are able to hold fast to what is real and what will last.

June 11

They remind us that even the qualities of uprightness of conduct, humanity of disposition, and energy of purpose may deaden and kill the spiritual principle within us if applied to no greater use than merely selfish or ambitious ends.

Third Degree Ceremony

It seems to be part of the human lot that we so easily cloak ourselves in self-righteousness, where our own perceived virtue leads us to believe we are in a position to judge others. We step out onto the path of self-improvement motivated by high ideals: the betterment not only of ourselves, but of all humanity. However, if we do not take care, the elevated nature of our purpose inflates our self-importance and leads us into justifying actions that undermine the very advancement we are trying to demonstrate.

We must constantly measure our actions and our thoughts against the principles we profess and be sure that humility does not become arrogance and all our efforts come to naught.

June 12

The triangle has long been considered a sacred symbol. In times of antiquity names of God and symbols of Divinity were often enclosed in triangular figures.

Mystical Lecture

The triangle is an incredibly powerful symbol and is reflected in so much of Royal Arch ritual: the strength of three is a recurring motif. But the form of the equilateral triangle also represents the striving of humankind for God; the struggle to shift our lives from the material physicality of the wide, flat base to the spiritual unity represented by the sharp, upward-pointing apex. In some Lodges, the triangular flap of an Entered Apprentice's apron is worn folded upwards to demonstrate that the spiritual and the physical are not fully integrated in one so new on the path. For many, the six-pointed star represents the idea that God descends to humanity as humanity strives to uplift itself towards God.

June 13

I cried unto God with my voice, even unto God with my voice; and he gave ear unto me.

Psalms 77

To those who have never experienced it, it's difficult to explain how dark the night can be when we are overcome with despair. Hopelessness; the sense that our lives are worthless and pointless; the feeling that we have accomplished nothing and done nothing right; the seeming impossibility of finding our way back to the right path and of climbing back up to the light - at times like this it seems that we are alone and friendless, cut off by our own sense of desperation from those who love us (how unworthy of love we feel at these times!) Not even our faith can help us when we feel so far from God's mercy.

And yet... and yet... even here, in this isolation and darkness, help is there. God is unchanging; God's love is unwavering; God's mercy and forgiveness are boundless.

Be patient. Be silent.

Listen for that still, small voice.

June 14

...you will also notice that a Brother's hands reach beyond his immediate neighbour and this is to show you that Freemasonry should go beyond helping a Brother and should reach out into the world to help all of mankind.

Entered Apprentice Chain

We must never lose sight of the fact that Freemasonry has practical applications in our daily lives. It is so easy to leave our Masonic ideals untouched from one month to the next, locked in a briefcase with our regalia, but when we do this we render the whole system worthless. There is no benefit to anyone if we only think about the Craft when we attend our Lodges. The dictates and principles of our Order must inform our actions every day if they are to have any meaning at all. It is this that we must strive to achieve, as it is only through this that Freemasonry will find its proper place as a force for good in the world.

June 15

Prepare our hearts in sympathy to be partners in suffering with the weak; partners in eager service with the strong.

Anon.

To be human and to be adult means making choices. As Freemasons, we have already made some very important choices about the kind of lives we wish to lead and about the kinds of people we wish to be. But making the decision to do this or that or to be this or that is only the beginning. Now we have to do it and to be it. And that requires a daily effort to renew and reaffirm those choices. Every day we must remake the commitment to live according to our values. We have already identified ourselves as helpers and protectors of the weak; we have already committed our strength – heart, body and mind – to serve those who need it and to serve all that helps lift humanity from darkness to light. Let us prepare ourselves afresh each day for this work and let this spirit of service suffuse all our days, whatever else we do.

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June 16

We will not hide them from their children, shewing to the generation to come the praises of the LORD... That they might set their hope in God, and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments:

Psalm 78

The idea that younger generations can learn from the mistakes of their elders has long been the hope of many of us. It's so painful to watch our children make the mistakes we made to learn the lessons that we so painfully had to learn ourselves but it seems that there's no way of avoiding it. Instead, we can do two things.

First of all, we should not hide those dark and difficult lessons from our children: they will grow and be strengthened by their understanding. Our desire to protect and cushion them from life's problems can stunt them and weaken them - if we carry them everywhere, they will never develop the muscles required to walk themselves.

Secondly, we can show them, through the example of our lives, what it is to face the darkness without fear, what it is to be afraid but to move forward regardless. We can show them what vulnerability looks like and show them how it becomes strength. We can show them our faith and how it supports us.

June 17

*In this world
Hate has never dispelled hate.
Only love can dispel hate.
This is the law,
Ancient, yet always new.*

Adapted from The Dhammapada

This teaching from the East has its own resonance in Western traditions: ‘...resist not evil: but whosoever shall smite thee on thy right cheek, turn to him the other also.’

What we need to understand here is the immutability of this statement, this ‘law.’ Hate does nothing but feed on itself and grow ever bigger and more destructive. Love is the humbling force that starves hatred and withers it on the spot. This is one of the greatest teachings of all religions and one of the reasons that Freemasonry aims to cultivate in our hearts a love of all humanity. By filling our lives with love - a detached, unselfish love - we touch other lives, multiplying and spreading that love behind and around us like the wake of a ship or the ripples of a fish, disturbing the silent surface of a tranquil lake.

June 18

The circle is an emblem of eternity, for as it is without beginning or end, it may justly be deemed emblematic of God, who is without beginning of days or end of years, and it continually reminds us of that great hereafter or futurity, where we hope to obtain eternal life.

Mystical Lecture

The first thing we are told on becoming Master Masons is that, at last, we are able to work with both points of the compass to render the circle of our lives complete. We learn early on in our Masonic journeys that the circle is an important symbol, containing as it does a sense of absolute completeness and a centre from which we cannot err. The circles of our lives connect with the circles of all the other people with whom we come into contact, overlapping and merging as our lives touch and are touched by friends, family and the wider world. But let us remember that all of our smaller circles, with all of their endless interconnections are contained within the greater circle that is God: eternal, ineffable, the beginning and end of all.

June 19

We are become a reproach to our neighbours, a scorn and derision to them that are round about us.

Psalm 79

Everything we do, in the final reckoning, is a choice. We can look to our childhoods and say, “This is why I am like this,” or “This is why I behave in this way,” but, once we become adults, we have to take responsibility for own actions and not look to attribute them to outside influences - however real and powerful those influences might have once been.

It is the same with our feelings. We can either go through life at the mercy of the effect that others’ words and actions have on us, or we can choose to take responsibility for how we react to others and for how we feel. It’s so easy nowadays to be offended by someone else’s words or actions, so easy to be upset or hurt or disappointed by what they say and do, but we must learn to understand that any power another person has to upset us or make us feel bad is a power that we choose - consciously or unconsciously - to give them and the decision to be offended or hurt rests solely with us, not with them.

We do not have power over others but we do have power over our own actions, thoughts and feelings and, of course, we have a great help and support in our Masonry.

June 20

*The heights by great men reached and kept
Were not attained by sudden flight,
But they, while their companions slept
Were toiling upward in the night.*

Henry Wadsworth Longfellow

It is not easy, this consciously stepping on to a path of self-knowledge. As soon as we rise above the valley that is the common human condition, we see with a new perspective and, attaining the heights, we can never again immerse ourselves in much of the pettiness of life without feeling ill at ease. Having once set a loftier course for ourselves, we are doomed to see the futilities of our lives for what they are. We can never be satisfied with whatever is in us that does not strive for perfection and so, although we live in the world, we are slightly apart from it and our appreciation of its beauty is forever tinged with the poignancy of its - and our own - transience.

June 21

*On that plate of gold was the word J.H.V.H, that great, awful,
tremendous and incomprehensible name of the Most High...*

Mystical Lecture

To be given a thing's true name was once thought to be given power over that thing. Between ourselves, the idea of being on 'first name terms' with someone is a sign of closeness and informality, a sign of friendship and even of intimacy. As we approach God by way of our journey through life in general and Freemasonry in particular we are led from the formality of titles like 'Great Architect,' 'Grand Geometrician' or 'Most High,' to specific names that cement our growing relationship with our Creator. But just as a man might be known by different names by different people: Mr. Smith to business associates, Robert to acquaintances and Bob to his friends, so are different names of God revealed to us as we approach closer to the divine presence. There are no contradictions here, only a growing closeness, a flowering of love.

June 22

Turn us again, O God, and cause thy face to shine; and we shall be saved.

Psalm 80

When it feels as if all the sweetness and joy have gone out of life and the world loses its beauty and charm, we must know that the world has not changed - it is we who have lost sight of the things that are important to us.

It's easy to wallow in a sense of abandonment and separation but one of the key lessons of Freemasonry is that we are the determiners of our own destiny. We choose how we relate to the world and we choose Freemasonry as one of the filters through which we look at it. When that filter fails us - or rather when our strength to use that filter fails - it is not always easy to bring ourselves back to our usual poise of equilibrium and wellness and once more see the world as it is.

In these hard times we must look inward to find the bedrock of our faith and that still, small voice within us that never falters, that never loses its way and that will never let us down.

If we can find the time and the space and the inclination to be still and listen, that voice will be there to save us.

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June 23

*Exchanging fragmentary news or prophecies of crop
Until they reach the Tyler's room and current topics drop.
To turn their thoughts to nobler themes they cherish and adore,
And which were heard in meeting night up over Simkin's store.*

Lawrence N. Greenleaf

One of the great joys of our Lodge meetings, be they weekly, monthly or quarter-yearly, is that they offer a few hours respite from the cares of the world. When we pass from the Tyler's room into the Temple itself, we should leave all our daily concerns outside and indeed turn our 'thoughts to nobler themes.' This turning inward and upward of consciousness is the same escape found by religious people in their fervent prayer and by mystics in their meditation. It is not something to feel uncomfortable or embarrassed about but is something we should embrace thankfully, using the time to refresh our Spirits so that when we re-enter the world we are stronger, better people.

June 24

Then rose up Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, and Jeshua the son of Jozadak, and began to build the house of God which is at Jerusalem: and with them were the prophets of God helping them.

Ezra 5:1-3

One of the wonderful things about Freemasonry is its practicality, the power it has to inform our daily lives and make a difference to the ways in which we act and the ways in which we relate to others. But life isn't just about doing. When we act we must do so from a core of thinking and feeling so that our actions arise from our thoughts, our dreams, our aspirations. The fact that those practical men who rebuilt the Temple were supported and helped by the prophets of God can stand as a reminder that all of our doing, all of our making, all of our manifesting on the outer planes of life should arise from an inner impulse that has God as its centre.

June 25

Thou calledst in trouble, and I delivered thee; I answered thee in the secret place of thunder:

Psalm 81

However much we want to rely on an idea of God ‘out there’ somewhere in the vastness of the heavens, until we understand the truth that God resides always and most closely in the recesses of our hearts, we will never fully understand the true nature of our Creator.

In Freemasonry we hear of that ‘immortal principle’ which animates us and, although it is pretty obvious that we cannot all carry the entirety of what God is within ourselves, we do all carry a divine spark that is, qualitatively at least, one with God. Just as a drop of the ocean has the same qualities as the ocean but is not the whole ocean; just as the spark of a fire has all the attributes of the fire but is not the whole fire; so we carry within ourselves a divine and immortal principle that is of God but is not wholly God.

If we look inwards; if we listen to our hearts and learn to hear that voice within, we will come to recognise and understand that divine essence within us and, through that daily practice, through that daily advancement, we will come, in the end, to know God.

June 26

By such exemplary conduct you will convince the world that merit has been your title to our privileges, and that on you our favours have not been undeservedly bestowed.

Third Degree Charge

After the drama and emotion of a degree ceremony, a serious charge is once more laid upon us. Amongst other things, we are reminded that each of us, as an individual, carries the weight of Freemasonry on our shoulders. The world will judge the whole by its parts and it is up to us, who are the parts that make up the whole that is Freemasonry, to ensure that the reputation of the Order is preserved.

There is no doubt that the world at large has had a generally negative image of Freemasonry and if we are to continue to change that, it will be by proving its falsehood by our behaviour. We should always act in such a manner that our actions are a positive reinforcement of Freemasonry's tenets. After all, have we not all made the decision that it is those tenets which will regulate our words and deeds?

June 27

It shows the Royal Arch to be the climax of Freemasonry...It has virtue for its aim, the glory of God for its object, and the eternal welfare of man is considered in every part...

Mystical Lecture

The idea that the Royal Arch completes the journey of Freemasonry may be taken to mean many things. One clear sense is the idea that Craft Freemasonry leads us to explore ourselves: our physical limitations, our relationships in this world; even encouraging us to consider how this world works and how far human knowledge may take us in comprehending it. But all of this knowledge leads us to the grave and the third degree points clearly to the fact that, if we want to understand what happens beyond that grave, we need to look higher, beyond the reflected light of our world, described merely as darkness visible, into the true light of divinity.

When we begin to understand ourselves in relation to God, we begin to understand the true depths of what we are.

Let us remember the truth of our divine origins and let the eternal welfare of all become our natural concern.

June 28

*Defend the poor and fatherless: do justice to the afflicted and needy.
Deliver the poor and needy: rid them out of the hand of the wicked.*

Psalm 82

Mankind has always looked to God to bring justice to ‘the righteous’ and to visit retribution on ‘the wicked’ and this invocation to God to “...defend the poor and fatherless, do justice to the afflicted and needy. Deliver the poor...” is both timeless and, to our shame, as necessary in today’s society as it clearly was at the time of King David.

As Freemasons, our duty is clear. We act in the world and our aim is to do God’s work, which we interpret as working for the common good, attempting to relieve the suffering of the poor and needy. In other words, when reading an invocation such as this, a cry for help, we treat it as if it is directed at us because we choose to see ourselves as hearing with God’s ears, seeing with God’s eyes and acting with God’s love.

We do not concern ourselves with visiting justice on ‘the wicked’ because that is beyond our remit and our understanding. That, we will leave to God.

But to offer succour - yes. Definitely. That’s why we’re here.

June 29

...a spirit of emulation prevails, and each vies as to who shall excel in promulgating the valuable principles of the institution.

Second Degree Lecture

Those of us who work the Emulation Rite would do well to ponder the meaning of the word thought important enough to give its name to the whole system. Those who do not can only admire the wisdom of the men who lit the beacon blaze shining out in that name.

Is this not one of the great joys of our workings? The joy of excellence; the joy of exalted rivalry as we first emulate and then aim to be worthy of emulation ourselves; to give of our best to the lofty ideals of the institution and to be perfect vehicles for the plan laid out in its rituals.

June 30

Sing unto God, sing praises to his name: extol him that rideth upon the heavens by his name Jah, and rejoice before him.

Psalm 68:4

Ultimately, all the paths of this life lead us to one place, a place where every Freemason has – emblematically, at least – already been: the grave. Our time on Earth is so short, this life is so sweet for those of us lucky enough to have known love and to have had the time to appreciate the natural beauty that surrounds us. What else can we do but let our hearts sing the praises of our Creator? How else can we prevent them bursting with the joy that fills us when we contemplate all that makes us human?

For all its troubles and disappointments, all its suffering and injustices, this life still holds the possibility of happiness and peace. Sometimes we would do well to remember this and simply go out into the world to share our joy and our appreciation for what we have and what we know to be true.

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July 1

Keep not thou silence, O God: That men may know that thou, whose name alone is JEHOVAH, art the most high over all the earth.

Psalm 83

We live in tumultuous times. The winds of change buffet us night and day and we are battered constantly by conflicting world views, by dystopian, end-of-the world horror stories; tales of war and violence; imagined and real threats to our security and well-being; shootings, murder; natural disasters; nuclear meltdowns: everywhere we look, we can - if we choose - find a narrative of negativity that makes the world seem such an ugly, bleak and hopeless place.

Yet, if we lift our eyes, we can still find beauty; we can still find peace; we can still find love and brotherhood and unity. All the ingredients for a successful, peaceful and happy world are at our fingertips and it is only a lack of purpose, intention and clarity of thought that prevents us from grasping it and making it a reality.

Our job as Freemasons is to help build God's temple here on earth and we cannot do that if we choose to place our energies with those who preach doom and gloom. In spite of everything that is wrong with the world, we must remain positive and, step by step, brick by brick, build that edifice of love, peace and unity that will be fit to house the presence of the true and living God Most High.

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July 2

...thereby enabling you to exercise those talents wherewith God has blessed you as well to His Glory as to the welfare of your fellow creatures.

First Degree Ceremony

Masonry is something that should touch and influence our deepest selves. Being established in God, it is the foundation of a house 'built upon a rock.' Whatever is done to the house above, the foundations are unchanged. We should learn to think of the Craft as the substructure of a temple which is our life. By adopting the symbols of Masonry as our base and our design, we can walk the chequered path of this existence secure in the knowledge that what we build will not fall because it is founded in Truth. With this thought in mind, try always to be guided by the ideals that, in your last Lodge meeting, you professed to admire.

July 3

I must, however, impress upon your mind that the higher the rank to which you are elevated, the more important and responsible do the duties required of you become.

Installation of 'Z'

This is true in any walk of life: rank brings responsibility and the higher our position, the greater the burden placed upon us. It is true that in the world we are often rewarded for our responsibility as well, which helps us to bear the burden, but in Freemasonry a different value system applies. In the Royal Arch we all make the commitment to come to terms with our relationship with God. As rulers in the Chapter, there is an added responsibility to personify and emulate exalted characters who formally took on the responsibility to lead our ancestors on this path of knowing. We are first Priest, then Prophet, then Prince and all of these roles carry heavy responsibility without any reward save that truly Masonic one of knowing that when the job is done, it is well done.

July 4

My soul longeth, yea, even fainteth for the courts of the LORD: my heart and my flesh crieth out for the living God.

Psalm 84

To become a Mason is to acknowledge that material life ultimately lacks that which will satisfy our deepest selves. With all its joys and pains, even with great success and real accomplishment, in the end, a time will come when all earthly happiness will count for nothing and our souls will long for something more fulfilling, more lasting and more real.

Freemasons are not afraid to think about death and because of that they are able to live life to the full. Life is a wonderful gift: the Earth is beautiful; the joys of friends and family, loved ones, children, labour, brotherhood - all these are beautiful and valuable. And yet, while we appreciate them, our delight in them is tinged with sorrow at the knowledge of their impermanence.

In our quiet moments of contemplation, meditation and prayer, we feel the longing of our soul - our deepest self - reaching out to that which we know is there: the eternal light of Spirit; the presence of that God in whom we put our trust.

July 5

My real faith then is in a dream that, in spite of daily headlines prophesying man's destruction, we can build a better world, a world of peace and human brotherhood. Yes, even in our lifetime...In my small way I want to have a share in making it come about.

Julien Bryan

As Freemasons, this is a faith and a dream to which we should all subscribe. Why else would we be Masons? Why else would we spend so much of our time working to improve ourselves and each other? The ideals of brotherhood and, by a natural extension, peace, are close to our hearts and at the core of our rituals. An important point here is that we do all have a part to play in making this dream a reality, even if it is a small part. Very few of us move in circles where our actions and decisions will have a global impact, but all of us are the centre of a circle, however seemingly insignificant, from which our actions will influence those around us. As Masons we must be sure that all we do takes our immediate circle closer to the fulfillment of our dream.

July 6

...whilst we are labouring to erect and preserve our earthly tabernacle to Thy Name and Glory, we may at the same time prepare our path to Thy eternal Temple, where peace and glory reign for ever...

Installation of 'Z'

There does not need to be any separation of our lives into spiritual and material; into worship and our daily labour. We are taught as Entered Apprentices that we should divide our time appropriately, but by the time we have advanced to the Royal Arch, the various strands that make us human are much more closely integrated and so we can begin to see our lives and actions in a more unified way. We labour on Earth for the benefit of our fellow travellers and for the glory of God. If our work is well-directed and our actions well-motivated, we should understand that this is spiritual work too. We recognise that the way to the 'eternal Temple' lies not in separation from the mundane and physical, but in the elevation of the mundane and physical to acts of service and prayer. Let us not lose sight of the fact that all of life is a spiritual journey and that, as Master Masons, we are qualified to work with the full circle of our lives.

July 7

Mercy and truth are met together; righteousness and peace have kissed each other.

Truth shall spring out of the earth; and righteousness shall look down from heaven.

Psalm 85

We must always recognise and embrace the weaknesses and flaws that are a natural part of being human. No one is perfect and we must learn to be kind and patient with our own shortcomings as well as those of others. Of course, to seek forgiveness implies an acceptance of having done wrong in the first place (consciously or not) and implies, also, a commitment to refrain from repeating that particular mistake in the future.

Freemasonry is gentle on us in that it demands of us only the best that we can do and be at any given moment. It accepts our frailties within a context of assumed goodness and goodwill. There are no hard and fast rules; no 'sins' or punishments attached to them. There is just an assumption that, as far as we are able, we will abide by the moral law of harm to none, confident in our relationship with each other and our Creator.

How lovely it would be if we could make and maintain this great Brotherhood of ours as one of the places where mercy and truth meet; where righteousness and peace embrace and where truth springs out of the earth.

July 8

Truth never yet fell dead in the streets; it has such affinity with the soul of man, the seed however broadcast will catch somewhere and produce its hundredfold.

Theodore Parker

Truth is like a butterfly: vibrant and beautiful until it is captured and pinned down. Truth is not an exclusive commodity and cannot be contained in any one creed. Freemasonry recognises this and has as one of its aims the enrichment of our religious lives, whatever our faith. Truth informs our ritual and guides our principles but nowhere do we find a suggestion that we are sole possessors of 'The Truth.' As the sound of a church bell may be heard by all and stir the hearts of many, worshippers or not, so Truth will make itself known to all who seek it, conforming to the outer form of their faith. And how do we recognise this Truth that cannot be encompassed? By its atmosphere, its spirit, its resonance within our deepest selves.

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July 9

The crown...being an emblem of sovereignty, should remind you that to reign in the hearts and affections of the Companions is far more gratifying to a generous mind than to rule over their lives and fortunes.

Address to 'Z'

Although the original Zerubbabel was a Prince who wielded earthly power, we, as his symbolic descendents and imitators do not do so. Power, as held by the rulers in Freemasonry is nothing to do with temporal power, but our rulers are important to us. In the Royal Arch they not only represent the characters whose names they bear, but also our highest aspirations and hopes. As such, we readily open our hearts to them, looking always for the best that a human being can be and for worthy examples to follow on the path we all tread. The rulers, being gifted these open hearts, take on a huge responsibility to hold them lightly and to treat them reverently, understanding that an open heart is a rare and most precious trust.

July 10

I will praise thee, O Lord my God, with all my heart: and I will glorify thy name for evermore.

Psalm 86

As we cope with the daily stresses of modern life, it's easy to forget who and what we are. As Freemasons, we recognise that within our breast there dwells an immortal, divine spark but to keep that divine flame burning as we worry about deadlines and bills and all the other distractions of this earthly life is sometimes hard. Sometimes it feels impossible.

We know that habits are formed, like anything else in our lives that we wish to master, by practice. If we want to dwell more often and more securely in the light of the divinity within us, then we must make it a daily habit to connect, even if just for a few moments, with that still centre from which we cannot err. If we, as Masons, wish to develop a full sense of our holiness; if we wish to live more fully in the awareness of our true selves and our true nature, then we must develop for ourselves a regular practice of contemplation and meditation where we can, for a short time, be freed from the duties and cares of our daily lives.

July 11

... in giving him a virtuous and liberal education, his mind becomes cultivated and he is thereby rendered a fit member of civilised society.

First Degree Ceremony

Many of us who have arrived at the portals of Freemasonry have been attracted to the vision of a humanity ennobled by its profound teachings of morality, truth and love. We have learned to love its ritual and its history and have gained much from our association with it. But we have not arrived here as a result of our own innate wisdom and virtue. No, the very fact that we find this vision attractive is a direct result of the education we received which taught us to prize these ideals above material rank and fortune. We should be forever grateful to our parents or guardians, our teachers and to society at large for that education and we should use our influence and strive always to ensure that such an education - both virtuous and liberal - is available to all the world's children.

July 12

...we learn that the Almighty does not look upon the outward appearance of a man, but upon the heart.

Installation of 'Z'

When we set our feet on the path of Freemasonry, although we may not realise it at first, we take a direction that diverges in many subtle ways from the path of modern society. Freemasons are not part of a religious sect that hides itself away from the world or shuns it in any way. We live in the world and there are even those among us who do so prominently and in the public eye but, at the same time, we are proud to align ourselves more and more with those aspects of society that look beyond surface values to those that are found in the deeper vaults and recesses of the human heart. As ever, we do our best to look upon ourselves, each other and the wider world with the eyes of eternity and see each other as God sees us.

July 13

His foundation is in the holy mountains.

And of Zion it shall be said, This and that man was born in her: and the highest himself shall establish her.

Psalm 87

When we say that our Lodges stand on Holy ground, we draw a deep symbolic connection direct to the source of the most important stories on which the edifice of Freemasonry is founded. And by linking ourselves to this source of holiness, we take on a huge mantle of responsibility to live up to the ideals and philosophy we espouse.

The Psalmist suggests that there is no higher accolade than to say, "...that man was born in her..." - that to be born in Zion is to be holy and good. If we wish the link that we make between our Lodges and that Holy place to be a true one, we must aim to make it the case that the words, "That person is a Freemason," carries as much weight as those words, "...this man was born there."

July 14

Let us discard all this quibbling about this man and the other man, this race and that race and the other race, being inferior...Let us discard all these things, and unite as one people throughout this land, until we shall once more stand up declaring that all men are created equal.

Abraham Lincoln

Although we eschew the discussion of politics at our meetings, we cannot fail to be aware of the many wrongs in the world. Neither are we expected to avoid difficult issues because they may seem 'political'. As Masons we are determined to right wrongs in any lawful way available to us but we should do so by rising higher and finding remedies that are founded on the Spiritual principles that actuate us. Our basic premise that all of us are God's children is one that can allow for no wrong to go unchallenged and so, on social issues we enter, of necessity, the political arena. Try to be sure that even in this sphere, your actions are guided by Masonic principles and avoid everything that causes division and strife in the world.

July 15

...and to preserve that bond of union and fraternal love which has ever been the foundation of the Masonic structure.

Installation of 'Z'

Like all of the relationships in our lives, those with our Brethren and Companions in our Lodges and Chapters need to be constantly worked on to maintain their lustre. It is easy to slip into bad habits; to become critical or negative; to repeat gossip; to speak unkindly of someone. It is good to remember that, not only have we taken solemn obligations to see and encourage the best in each other, but that to do so is also to cement our relationships further with that Masonic mortar which is brotherly love. And now, as our Companion is prepared to take the highest office in the Chapter, he – and we with him – is reminded that this brotherly love is the bedrock upon which the whole structure of Freemasonry rests. How important, then, do all our relationships become when seen from this perspective! Let us commit ourselves to do all we can to support each other to be the very best we can be at all times – in and out of the Temple.

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July 16

For my soul is full of troubles: and my life draweth nigh unto the grave.

I am counted with them that go down into the pit: I am as a man that hath no strength:

Psalm 88

Freemasons are not immune from life's trials and tragedies. All of us suffer in varying ways and to varying degrees at some point in our lives and even the healthiest, wealthiest and luckiest amongst us will come to know sickness, bereavement, infirmity and, eventually, death.

If anything sets Freemasons apart, it is not that they do not know suffering, but that they are equipped to cope with it and to see it for what it is. Any person of faith will have a set of mental, emotional and spiritual tools to help them face the vicissitudes of earthly life and Freemasons are no different. We are not afraid of going down into the pit; we are not afraid of the darkness and we are not afraid of death. We have, in our rituals, confronted and contemplated these awful subjects and we know, at least intellectually, how to overcome them. It is up to us as individuals to put our Masonic tools to such a use that this intellectual understanding becomes so deeply ingrained in us as to become an integral part of our lives and character.

July17

...admonishing us to be careful to perform every operation in its proper season, that we lose not the fruits of our labour.

Ceremony of Exaltation.

All of life may be viewed as a series of causes and effects. From the primordial impulse that created the physical universe to the smallest doings of our daily lives, there springs an endless chain of action and reaction. When we set out on the path of Freemasonry, we are, often unknowingly, taking the first step towards controlling that chain. We begin to make conscious use of the forces that govern our lives and we behave in such a way, understanding what the effect will be. We begin to harness that universal urge towards perfection that is instilled in all of us. But once started, we must continue. To not continue is to give up what progress we have made and so to lose the fruits of our labours. Remembering that we labour for the good of humankind, we must commit to bear the responsibility bravely and strive always to move forward.

July 18

...an example of that moral rectitude of conduct which alone can entitle him to the goodwill and affection of the Companions, and the respect and homage due to the office.

Installation of 'Z'

Promotion and responsibility go hand in hand and as we climb the ladder of office through Lodge and Chapter we cannot help but realise the increasing weight of history that we bear on our shoulders as we become the focus of the aspirations of our Brethren. It is only fair that there should be some separation in the minds of all between the Office and the holder of that Office, but it cannot be denied that our personal conduct and our standing with our Brethren and Companions affects the way they relate to the Offices we hold. It can be seen, therefore, that our responsibilities begin much earlier than our first step on that ladder. From our entry into Freemasonry, we are building a foundation upon which our later effectiveness as rulers is being constantly built and, from the earliest moments of our Masonic lives, we are responsible for preserving the dignity and respect due to the rulers of our Order.

July 19

I will sing of the mercies of the LORD for ever: with my mouth will I make known thy faithfulness to all generations.

Psalm 89

Faith is a conscious choice. Having it does not make us morally superior; not having it does not make a person inferior in any way. It is for each one of us to make sense and meaning in this life and all we can do, as Masons, is to help every individual as much as is in our power in their quest for understanding and worth, remembering that they are all, every one, a Brother and Sister under God.

Becoming a Freemason is also a choice and many people choose it for very many reasons. But it is worthwhile remembering occasionally exactly what it is we have chosen: a life of strong faith, underpinned by a love of God and humanity, founded on clear principles of charity and fraternity. We have chosen a strong foundation for the superstructure we build with our lives; a reliable rock. We have chosen confidence, optimism and joy for, even in times of trouble, we know that we can rely on a source of truth and inner strength that will never fail us.

How happy we should be in our choice.

July 20

Pendant to the four corners of the Lodge are four tassels, which represent the four cardinal virtues-namely, Temperance, Prudence, Fortitude and Justice.

First Degree Ceremony

During the second degree ceremony, the candidate is taught that a Fellow-craft Freemason should ‘...observe a due medium between avarice and profusion [and] hold the scales of Justice with an equal poise...’ This reminds us that in all things, a good Mason is encouraged to tread a ‘middle way’, avoiding extreme in all things. As Masons we are very much part of society; even though we try to lift ourselves above its pettiness and materialism, the joys and successes of the world are ours and so too are its failings and its sorrows. We need to learn to be moderate in all we do; to do what is needful or appropriate, but not to lose ourselves in any vice or addiction - good or bad - that tends to lead us away from our chosen path. This moderation in thought, word and deed, is Temperance in its widest sense.

July 21

But Zerubbabel, and Jeshua, and the rest of the chief of the fathers of Israel, said unto them, Ye have nothing to do with us to build an house unto our God; but we ourselves together will build unto the Lord God of Israel, as king Cyrus the king of Persia hath commanded us.

Ezra 4:3

The whole question of inclusion and exclusion is one that we need to consider. We are, in many ways, an open group insofar as we welcome new members and enquiries from those interested our rites and customs. We are also closed in the sense that those rites and customs are really only available to those who have joined us. It's something of a contradiction and one we should be aware of. Exclusion without sensitivity can lead to bad feeling and alienation; inclusion without discernment can lead to a dilution of what we are. As ever, we must aim to walk a middle way, dealing with each situation as it arises and judging it on its own merits.

July 22

*For a thousand years in thy sight are but as yesterday when it is past,
and as a watch in the night.*

*Thou carriest them away as with a flood; they are as a sleep: in the
morning they are like grass which groweth up.*

Psalms 90

A sense of perspective is vital if we are to negotiate the twists and turns of life successfully. Our earthly existence, obviously so important to us, is so brief and so inconsequential on a cosmic scale that it is a wonder and a mystery that we can hold within us a divine spark that makes us so much more than a flash in the great pan of universal life. Our physical lives are so unutterably short and set about with difficulty that we must look for deeper meaning in things of the spirit, for it is only there that anything can begin to make sense.

Time is short, however, and we must avoid the trap of thinking that there will always be an opportunity and a space for us to set aside our material concerns and consider deeper, more lasting matters. There is no time. We must do it now and integrate our learning and our insights and our understanding into our everyday lives. If we do not, we are no more than mayflies, here for a fleeting moment and then gone, forever, without a trace.

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July 23

Truth's tough. It will not break, like a bubble, at a touch; you may kick it about all day, like a football, and it will be round and full at evening.

Oliver Wendell Holmes

There is no doubt that truth endures. Falsehood, too, has strength and existence but, in time, it is exposed for what it is and it falls away. It is not robust and cannot stand the probing and testing of daily life. Truth, on the other hand, in all its various guises, can stand such testing. By its very nature it is strong because it reflects reality, the way things actually are.

Much of Freemasonry might be seen as quaintly old-fashioned by the outside world but to many of us that is part of its charm. Meanwhile the important lessons it teaches continue to have real force and import for us and this, if any were needed, is proof enough that it contains much that is real and true.

Don't be afraid to put Freemasonry to the test. Use the lessons it teaches, practise the principles it expounds; be proud of this vehicle that can do so much to improve the lot of humankind. It can stand it. It is tough because its basic message is a true one. You can rely on it.

July 24

Grant that our labours may produce the fruits of wisdom and love;

Installation of 'Z'

It is an obvious truth that if you want to grow a particular plant, you must plant the right seeds. You can prepare the earth and weed and water as carefully as you like, but if you wanted carrots but sowed pumpkin seeds, you are bound to be disappointed. In the same way, the excellences of character that we aim to cultivate do not come about by accident. We direct our labour – our actions, both physical and mental – in certain ways and we understand that wisdom and love will be the fruits that we will reap at the end. Indeed, the whole purpose of Freemasonry is to direct us towards those seeds which need to be planted in our lives in order to attain this rich and benevolent harvest. Our words and actions are seeds. Let us aim to produce the best and most worthwhile of fruits.

July 25

He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty.

Psalm 91

Of all the so-called secrets that Masons hold and prize, this is perhaps the sweetest - the secret of the in-dwelling Deity. Not secret in the sense that it is hidden, but secret in the sense that each person can only know of it within themselves and, knowing it, we are held; wrapped in a mantle, protected, guided and fearless.

If Freemasonry has a single aim or a single goal, perhaps it is this: to provide a path for any seeker to find the truth that lies within their own heart. From this knowing, faith is strengthened but so, too, are tolerance, compassion and empathy. Knowing the divine in ourselves helps us to see it in others and so we come to that great Masonic truth that everybody is kin to us; everybody is a vehicle and a temple of the divine.

July 26

...to seek the solace of your own distress by extending relief and consolation to your fellow creatures in the hour of their affliction.

Third Degree Ceremony

The practice of Charity, and the development of empathy that characterises it, is an exercise that leads to a fuller understanding of our relationship to each other. When we learn that the measure of our own happiness lies in our response to the suffering of our fellows, we will have learned the great truth that we are all a part of the same Life. Like the silky threads of a spider's web, the strands of life connect us in a vast, unimaginable unity, where the lightest touch on any part sets up vibrations of consequence in all the others. When we help others, we are also helping ourselves, and many more beyond the immediate circle of our aid. Understand the truth of this thought and be sure that all of your giving, all of your 'extending relief and consolation' comes from your heart before anything comes from your pocket.

July 27

The passages of Scripture just read afford ample proof of His readiness and power to assist those who love, fear, and obey Him.

Installation of 'H'

Although the details of each Mason's faith are private and personal, all of us have openly professed our belief in the existence of a Supreme Being. As we have progressed through Freemasonry's initiatory pathways, we have come to accept that the nature of that being is Love. As Companions we have also all seen and acknowledged the darkness and the depths and we have descended into the vault to bring forth the light of God's word. We should remember that moment as being one of profound symbolical importance because it was the moment that we realised our potential as instruments of God's plan, for we enacted the fact of our ability to contribute by bringing light into the world. And when we come into line with God's plan, we can be sure that help and assistance will be there for us.

July 28

The righteous shall flourish like the palm tree: he shall grow like a cedar in Lebanon.

Those that be planted in the house of the LORD shall flourish in the courts of our God.

They shall still bring forth fruit in old age; they shall be fat and flourishing;

Psalm 92

So much of our lives involves the idea of planting seeds now that will come to fruition later. Among the greatest lessons that Freemasonry teaches us are those of patience and trust. We learn patience through the process of being made a Mason - from petition to Initiation, to Passing, Raising and beyond. There is always a process, a due order, and we must wait.

As we progress, we also learn trust. Trust in our Brethren, trust in our chosen path, trust in God on whom we increasingly learn to rely. It is in the safety of this trust that we come to understand that we are planting the seeds of a future harvest. Our aim, as Masons, is not to achieve worldly glory, riches or fame; what we look forward to is the 'promise of futurity' and we understand that it is our present actions that determine what fruit we will come to bear and what harvest we will eventually reap.

July 29

*Although our past achievements we with conscious pride review,
As long as there's Rough Ashlars there is work for us to do.
We still must shape the Living Stone with instrument of love,
For that eternal Mansion in the Paradise above.
Toil as we've toiled in ages past, to carry out the plan-
'Tis this: The Fatherhood of God, the Brotherhood of Man.*

Lawrence N. Greenleaf

Those who love to denigrate Freemasonry for being what they consider to be no more than an exclusive social club, have clearly not studied the teachings of the Order. The ideals of Freemasonry are the highest to which humankind can aspire: the betterment of all life and the Spiritualisation of humanity. It does not suit all people and nor does it need to. However, it does need to be recognised as a real force for good in this increasingly materialistic and confused modern world. For this to happen though, each individual Freemason must hold to these aspirations and so live a life that will reflect the high ideals of the Craft. Let us determine to do so.

July 30

It is the best proof that your conduct as a Master and your zeal as a mason are approved and acknowledged by the Companions.

Installation of 'J'

Eventually, most Companions will have the opportunity to fill the role of Principals in their Chapter and, eventually, even the youngest Chapters will have a great many Past Principals in their ranks. This should in no way lessen the sense of honour or importance of the role. Freemasonry is structured in such a way that we are properly prepared for all the positions of responsibility that we undertake, if we only listen to and observe the lessons that are presented to us. When we are given offices in our Lodges and Chapters, we should understand that these are honours bestowed on us because we have proved ourselves worthy of them. Let us always seek to learn the lessons that come our way and to prepare ourselves as well as we can for the weight and the gift of leadership.

July 31

The LORD reigneth, he is clothed with majesty; the LORD is clothed with strength, wherewith he hath girded himself: the world also is stablished, that it cannot be moved.

Psalm 93

In times of trouble and distress, when the cares of the world threaten to overwhelm us; when our way seems suddenly uncertain and we lose our centre, we must try to remember that we have in our lives a solid rock on which to ground ourselves.

If we can, even for a moment, distance ourselves from our distress and look at it from a wider, deeper perspective, we will see clearly how to move through it, acknowledging the feelings it leaves us with, taking the lessons that it might be teaching us, but ultimately rising above it, unscathed, our faith intact.

At these difficult times, take a moment. Breathe. Remember the teachings of our noble Craft and find within yourself that perfect centre which is our pole-star, our true north, our guiding light. The strength that we have chosen to rely on will not let us down.

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August 1

It cannot be too strongly asserted that Masonry is neither a religion nor a substitute for religion.

Points of Procedure

If religion is defined as a belief in a superhuman or controlling power, particularly a personal God, then it must be acknowledged that there is much that is religious in Freemasonry. But if religion is defined as a particular system of faith and worship, then Freemasonry can be seen as something rather different. In their wisdom, the founders of our Art recognised that religion is tied up with culture and self-identity, not only with belief. Religion not only provides a framework within which to see the world, but it provides ceremony and ritual to mark the milestones in our lives: birth, coming of age, marriage and death. Freemasonry does not provide those things, nor does it invoke a peculiarly Masonic deity. What it does is, taking faith in God as a starting point, provide a framework and a set of symbols over which one may lay one's religious life in order that it may be more clearly seen and more readily lived. Freemasonry can never be a substitute for religion, but it will always be an institution that will enhance and protect all religions that strive, as it does, for the common good.

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August 2

...at your initiation into Freemasonry you were recommended to study the V.S.L. as a guide to your faith, and I trust that, during the progress you have made in the different degrees of the Order, you have adhered to that recommendation.

Installation of ‘J’

In the first Degree we learn that our ascent to the ‘summit of Freemasonry’ is enabled by a ladder – Jacob’s Ladder. The rungs are made up of all the moral virtues, the three principal ones being Faith, Hope and Love. The foundation of the ladder, the base on which it rests, is the Volume of the Sacred Law – the word of God. This sense that we are God’s creatures and servants, subject to the Divine will that is revealed through scripture is a crucial tenet of Freemasonry and one that runs from the lowest to the highest degrees of our Order. Learning to understand and live by the Sacred revelations that we have been given – whatever our particular Religion or belief – is a process that never ends. There is always more to discover and there are always choices we can make to become better human beings and better Masons.

August 3

O LORD God, to whom vengeance belongeth; O God, to whom vengeance belongeth, shew thyself.

Psalm 94

Sometimes the hardest thing in life is to refrain from action. As Masons, we hate to see wrong done to anyone. We are sworn to help the weak, the poor, the dispossessed and when we see those who are vulnerable in our society being mistreated and abused in any way it is hard not to be angry and not to seek to punish the wrong-doers; to make them suffer as they have caused suffering to others.

The problem with that, of course, is that taking vengeance is not a Masonically correct course of action. All people are our brothers and sisters - even those who do wrong. At best we must treat them with the understanding and compassion they need - for surely to mistreat another human being is a sign of distress or ignorance. At worst, we must leave them to their own devices and trust that, in time, they will reap the just rewards of their actions and learn the lessons they need to find peace.

Perhaps one of the best things we can do in a situation like this is turn our attention away from the perpetrators and focus it on their victims, doing what we can to alleviate their suffering and minimising their distress. In this way, we fulfil our obligations and we trust God to do the rest.

August 4

Our Lodges are supported by three great pillars. They are Wisdom, Strength and Beauty. Wisdom to contrive, Strength to support, and Beauty to adorn the inward man.

First Degree Ceremony

The construction of that great Temple in Jerusalem is a great symbol and guide for us in our lives. It is a metaphor for the life we attempt to build for ourselves founded on the high moral principles of the Order. When we build and whatever we build - whether it be in word, thought or deed - we should check that our edifice is also supported by these three pillars.

We must ask ourselves, 'Is this wise? Is it built on firm foundations and therefore strong? And will it add something to the beauty and harmony of the universe?' Only if the answer to these questions is an unequivocal, 'Yes,' should we go ahead and lay the cornerstone.

August 5

Vouchsafe to us that mercy which Thou didst not withhold from Thine ancient people, so that, at the close of this, our mortal career, we may be numbered among those who shall be admitted into Thy temple of eternal bliss and glory.

Installation of ‘J’

Freemasonry is a path of action, of doing. We live and work in the world and are in no way separate from it. Freemasonry gives us an added framework within which to act and it provides a guide as to how best to live our lives to their full advantage – to ourselves and to all of those who come within our compass. In the Craft we are taught to live compassionate and generous lives in service to the greater good, understanding that the path of Faith, Hope and Charity leads to a greater life beyond this one. In the Royal Arch we are checked a little because now we must contemplate the truth that our own actions can only take us so far along the path. Without God’s mercy in meeting us at least halfway, we are too weak to climb to the summit. Let us remember that and tread our individual paths with due humility and gratitude.

August 6

Let us come before his presence with thanksgiving, and make a joyful noise unto him with psalms.

Psalm 95

To say that we become Freemasons 'for the fun' is very misleading and does nothing to promote the serious and worthy aims of the institution. Conversely, however, if our practice of Freemasonry is not enjoyable, then there is a strong likelihood that we are approaching it in the wrong spirit.

The idea of it just being 'for fun' is too lightweight to do it justice and so we must find other - perhaps more serious - ways to express the joy that we Freemasons feel when we come together for our meetings, our rituals and our social gatherings.

It is worth considering that this joy might come from the sense that we are doing good work, that we are endeavouring to be our best selves; that we are spending time with people with whom we have a deep and true connection. We communicate and interact with our Brethren from a position of spiritual understanding and insight into our true relationship and that cannot do otherwise than give rise to a natural upwelling of happiness. When we consciously align ourselves with that which we truly are - sparks of the Divine - joy is our birthright and our very being.

It's from that point and with that understanding that we can begin to have fun.

August 7

...as a Craftsman, you are expected to make the liberal arts and sciences your future study that you may the better be enabled to discharge your duties as a Mason, and estimate the wonderful works of the Almighty.

Second Degree Lecture

The seven liberal arts and sciences constitute the traditional foundations of our educational systems. The ancient concept of 'Mens sana in corpore sano' provided for the 'healthy mind' through a well-structured curriculum aimed at developing balance and tranquility as well as the cultivation of the virtues of Faith, Hope and Charity. Grammar, rhetoric and logic teach us how to think, how to structure our thought and how to express it. Arithmetic and geometry demonstrate in line and number the great harmony of the universe which is manifested audibly through music and visibly, in the Heavens, through the science of astronomy.

Learning does not end with our schooldays and Freemasonry is a system designed to continue our education, refining and polishing us until we are 'rendered fit for the intended structure,' perfect ashlar for the building of that 'ethereal mansion, not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.'

August 8

‘To that end you must subdue all passions and prejudices, and cultivate charity; not to Companions alone but to all mankind.’

Address to ‘Z’

Charity is love in action and charity in its most exalted sense is love. When we are called upon to cultivate charity, it is not an appeal to give in a material sense but it is a call to us to put all that we have learned with regard to our true relationship with God and with each other into the practice of our daily lives. To see and empathise with the burdens of others, to succour their weakness, relieve their distress and, yes, to give material aid where appropriate are all acts of charity; to lend a sympathetic ear and listen with an understanding heart; to care, unselfishly, for others are all signs of a good Freemason. And let us remember always that this charity, this love in action, must go beyond the bounds of our Masonic connections if it is to be truly Masonic.

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August 9

For the LORD is great, and greatly to be praised: he is to be feared above all gods.

Honour and majesty are before him: strength and beauty are in his sanctuary.

Psalm 96

We are very quick to attribute to God all the virtues that we, as Masons, profess to admire. Honour and majesty, wisdom, strength and beauty: these are the characteristics by which we recognise and through which we worship the Deity. They are elevated to divine status and exist in a sphere far beyond our mortal strivings - or so it seems.

The danger with this point of view is that it can feel like these excellences of character are out of our reach and that, in a way, we don't have to do anything about them other than admire them. But this is not enough. As Freemasons, we are committed to making the best of ourselves that we can and so when we recognise virtue we must do more than admire - we must aspire to it and try to live our lives by its precepts. We are taught that virtue, honour and mercy are the signs of a good Freemason and so we must make it our work to hold those things forever in our hearts and manifest them in our lives.

August 10

‘Where were you first prepared to be made a Mason?’

‘In my Heart.’

Second Degree Ceremony

There is much in our ceremonies that highlights the importance of a heartfelt appreciation of our Art. In the Scottish ritual the candidate has the meaning and symbolism of his preparation explained to him. It is stated that the purpose of the hoodwink is, among other things, ‘...that your heart might conceive before your eyes beheld the beauties of Freemasonry.’

It is in this preconceived love of the ideals and lofty vision of the Craft that the first seeds of our life in the Order are sown.

August 11

...the harmony of the Chapter should be your constant care; and as the glorious sun, when at its meridian, dispels the mists and clouds which obscure the horizon, so may your exertions dissipate the gloom of jealousy and discord should it ever appear.

Address to 'H'

All of us have a responsibility to maintain a harmonious atmosphere in the Lodge or Chapter. Indeed, it is impossible to imagine that any Masonic business could be conducted without it. But it is true that the more prominent a role we take in the Order, the more important our own individual demeanour becomes. Again, we must contemplate the relationship between authority and responsibility but we should also be reassured that we do have within us the power to dispel any unwholesome influences and that through our conscious exertions, the light of reason, truth and brotherhood may be brought to bear on any discord or darkness.

August 12

The LORD reigneth; let the earth rejoice; let the multitude of isles be glad thereof.

Psalm 97

In these troubled times, it can be difficult to find anything to rejoice about. We are bombarded daily with stories of violence and corruption, ecological breakdown, hatred, war and death. The world is not in a good state and it is at times like these that we must look inward and consider whether and how our words and actions are a force for good, counteracting the negative, or whether we, through inaction, omission, unconsciously or inadvertently contribute to it.

As Freemasons, such introspection should be part of our daily practice and, given our obligation to act as Brothers to all, we need to make sure that we are shining examples of good and that we act as healers and menders of all that is broken.

This doesn't mean that we need to make great, sweeping public gestures (although if we can, perhaps we should at least consider it!) It simply means that in our daily lives, we must do right by ourselves, by others, by our neighbourhood, our village, town, city, country and beyond. If each of us does this and encourages it in others, then there will come a time when the world will be able to rejoice.

August 13

That Masons are builders can be seen by the name... By teaching men the doctrines of temperance, fortitude, prudence and justice, together with the many lessons drawn from, and daily application to the activities of life, deep foundations are laid upon which the loftiest character must stand.

Owen Scott

It is not just the fact that we borrow much of our symbolism from operative stonemasons that is significant here, it is the fact that we borrow them specifically from the builders of God's house, that great Temple in Jerusalem. The craftsmen we so profess to admire, personified for us in the figures of the Kings, Solomon of Israel and Hiram of Tyre and of the master-builder, Hiram Abiff, worked to create a structure of such grandeur and beauty that it would be fit to house the Spirit and Presence of God. If we are to match their aspiration, we must aim to build, with our lives, a structure that is also fit for God's habitation.

August 14

It...is peculiarly characteristic of our Order, which has stood the test of ages and is distinguished by the beauty of its superstructure, namely universal brotherhood and benevolence.

Address to 'J'

The blue vault of heaven, in all its beauty, is used as a simile to describe the beauty of the Masonic structure. Just as the sky is always there to delight our hearts whenever we remember to lift our eyes towards the heights, so is the superstructure of Freemasonry always there to fill us with peace and a sense of rightness when we remember to pull ourselves away from the cares of daily life that so often threaten to engulf us. To dwell for just a moment in that gentle ocean of universal brotherhood and benevolence is to immerse ourselves in the truth of what we are and all that we aspire to be. And it is so close! When we reach up, we touch the sky; and when we think of these deeper truths, they come into being within us. Let us make a commitment to think of them for at least a moment every day.

August 15

O sing unto the LORD a new song;

Psalm 98

It is a time of change; a time when old structures and paradigms are breaking down and when many of the foundations that we thought were built on rock, have proved to be built on shifting sands.

There is no question of the foundations of Freemasonry slipping, however, and we should be grateful that our system is built upon values and beliefs that do not alter with time and circumstance. Having said that, it is also important to recognise that some things can be changed and that moving with the times is as important as holding fast to that which is timeless.

Our basic belief in Universal Brotherhood is the pivot around which all else can move because within that belief is everything that is fundamental to Freemasonry: the Fatherhood of God, the oneness of humanity, the sacredness of all life and the interconnectedness of all.

If we remember and cling to these core values, we will be able to meet new challenges and sing new songs, without ever losing our way.

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August 16

*Not what we give, but what we share,
For the gift without the giver is bare:
Who gives himself with alms feeds three,
Himself, his hungry neighbour, and Me.*

James Russel Lowell

Charity without feeling is unworthy of the name. When we give, we should do so from a spontaneous sympathy born of fellow-feeling and brotherly concern. If we give alms only to salve our conscience, then we fail to understand the true nature of ourselves and our relationship with our Creator. All life is One and is an expression of God. If we do not recognise our brother, we deny our Creator and to do that is to reduce ourselves to the level of beasts.

August 17

It is intended to remind you that in the breast of a Freemason those virtues should be as expansive and all embracing as the blue vault of Heaven.

Address to ‘J’

It is hard to imagine that our hearts can encompass such a wide-reaching and complete comprehension of the virtues that Masonry expounds. But we all know that the last and greatest of all these virtues is love and that the Mason who is in full possession of that virtue has attained the summit of Freemasonry. And so our hearts expand to encompass this great love, this great sense of compassion and charity towards all living creatures. As we are raised out of the darkness by those who stand beside us, we not only reveal the light but we are filled with it ourselves and we become instruments of that divine plan which bids us manifest true brotherhood here on earth.

August 18

Exalt the LORD our God, and worship at his holy hill; for the LORD our God is holy.

Psalm 99

We Masons consider our Lodges to stand on Holy ground and we identify strongly with that 'holy hill' which was the site of three grand offerings which serve as symbols and reminders to us of our relationship with our Creator.

The first, the willingness of Abraham to return to God his son, Isaac, reminds us that, without God, we have nothing and that everything we love and value has its beginnings in the Divine.

The second, the prayers offered up by King David, remind us that, no matter how elevated our situation in life, we are all humble petitioners at God's feet.

And the third, the building of the great Temple that is so central to our mythology and symbolism, carries as one of its many lessons, the reminder that we are enjoined to make of our lives a beautiful structure, fit for the indwelling of the Almighty.

August 19

I pray you with all earnestness to prove and to know within your hearts that all things lovely and righteous are possible for those who believe in their possibility, and who determine that for their part they will make each day's work contribute to them.

John Ruskin

Within each human being, at our very core, resides the soul that animates us. It is, at the same time, our deepest self and a spark of the Divine. The cares and trials of this life conspire to bury that spark ever deeper within us, to extinguish its flame, to bring us to a point where we believe that the material world around us is all there is.

But, like water, that divine spark seeks its own level and so it is that all human beings have something within themselves that aspires to great heights, that has an impulse to create beauty, to believe in and seek the ideal, to love that Light from which our innermost selves spring. As a result, the world, for all its woes, is full of individuals and organisations striving for the common good. We have embraced Freemasonry and we lift ourselves towards the light by our measured steps on Jacob's ladder.

Remember that the most important rungs are Faith, Hope and Charity. Tread them joyfully, knowing that in doing so, you fulfil your true destiny.

August 20

...impress your mind with a sense of your dependence upon God, and that perfection is not vouchsafed unto man upon earth, perfect holiness appertaining only unto the Lord.

Address to ‘J’

It's something of a brake on our progress when we are confronted with the idea that our own efforts will never be enough for us to attain the perfection to which we aspire. In the Craft we were encouraged, through intellectual study and contemplation and through good works, to aim for the peaks of love and compassion, the summit of Jacob's ladder, and it led us only to the brink of a figurative grave. Now, in the Royal Arch, we are taught to look towards God to provide us with the wherewithal to ascend those final rungs, for beyond the visible extent of the ladder lie further, higher realms that can only be reached through God's grace. Let us remember our dependence and use that remembering to deal more compassionately, more humbly, with the struggles and aspirations of all with whom we come into contact.

August 21

Make a joyful noise unto the LORD, all ye lands.

Serve the LORD with gladness: come before his presence with singing.

Psalm 100

There's a lot of talk about Freemasonry being 'fun' and, while our many and varied reasons for joining the Craft are all valid, we must recognise that, underlying them all, there is a solemn and serious task before us: to render ourselves fit vessels for the in-dwelling of God.

Having said that, we must also acknowledge that this is our destined work: to work to lift ourselves from the grip of materiality into the realms of Spirit. In doing what we are meant to do, there is great joy and, if ever our participation in Freemasonry ceases to be joyful, we would do well to take it for a sign that it is time to reflect upon the impulses that led us here in the first place.

If we exist to 'make good men better' then we must learn to take delight in the battles we face with our inner foes and rejoice in the victories we win, however seemingly small.

August 22

*‘In all cases of difficulty and danger, in whom do you put your trust? ’
‘In God.’*

First Degree Ceremony

This answer, so glibly put into our mouths by our conductor, even before we are truly made Masons, is one worthy of deep reflection for on it rests the whole superstructure of Masonic thought. As human beings, and particularly as Masons, we try always to do the best we can. We try to tailor our lives to conform to the plans of the Great Architect and so be free of the troubles that are our lot. But, as humans, we constantly fall away from our chosen path and succumb to the pitfalls that life puts in our way. When this happens, when we are faced by a task or a temptation that seems too big or strong for us to handle, to whom should we turn? To God, of course, the source of all our faith:

‘I will love thee, O Lord my strength.

‘The Lord is my rock, and my fortress, and my deliverer, my God, my strength in whom I will trust; my buckler, and the horn of my salvation, and my high tower.’

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August 23

Wisdom is the principal thing; therefore get wisdom: and with all thy getting get understanding.

Proverbs 4:7

Wisdom can be defined in many ways. It is not the same as knowledge and yet it clearly involves knowing. One definition of wisdom says it is the 'ability to discern or judge what is true, right, or lasting' and to do that we must have some sense of knowing what is true and what is right. Perhaps wisdom is the correct application of a certain type of knowledge: knowledge of things of the spirit and of eternity, rather than the material ephemera with which we are bombarded. As Companions, we have been lowered into the depths of material darkness and we have found that the word of God is what brings illumination. That is a high level of knowledge. If we now apply that knowledge meaningfully in our lives, that is the beginning of wisdom.

August 24

I will sing of mercy and judgment: unto thee, O LORD, will I sing.

Psalm 101

Freemasonry, for all its formality, is a very gentle path. It never asks of us more than we can give and it never expects perfection. Instead, it asks us only to be the best we can be in any given moment and it trusts us to fulfil that obligation.

Responsibility for our behaviour, our words, our progress along the path to perfection is placed squarely in our own hands and we willingly undertake to be true in our dealings with ourselves, with others and with God.

We know that living within the moral bounds that Freemasonry establishes makes us feel good and we know equally well that to fall short of those standards makes us feel less than happy. With the support of our Brethren, with our faith and with our own determination to be all that we can be, we walk this steady path in joy and gratitude.

August 25

...Happy to meet, sorry to part, happy to meet again.

Parting Toast at the Festive Board

It is hard to describe to someone who has not experienced it, the sense of comradeship that is created at our meetings. We come together from so many different walks of life, so many social groups, such a wide span of ages, of races and religions that, in any other sphere, it would be hard to see what could unite us. But, through our association with Freemasonry, we really do meet 'on the Level' and are united by our desire to make ourselves better people and the world a better place. If we allow it, our meetings will raise us to a higher plane where we act from the deepest levels of human existence and that is a place where all external differences become as naught. How lucky we are to be able to experience this. How true it is that we are happy to meet in such circumstances, sorry to part at the end of the evening and, even in the act of parting, we look forward to the next time we will join together to work for the benefit of humanity in the company of like-minded Brethren.

August 26

We have the fullest confidence in you, and believe that you will do your utmost for the comfort and prosperity of the Chapter.

Investiture of Treasurer

That Freemasonry encourages us to be the best we can is something that is clear from our earliest steps on the path. But sometimes we can miss the subtler messages and positive affirmations contained in the most seemingly unimportant pieces of ritual. By the time we take office in the Chapter, we are far along the road and our commitment and ability are proven. How lovely that this investiture – and the others that take place alongside it – express such heartfelt confidence in our abilities. How reassuring it is to be ‘seen’ to have it known that we are competent and that our motivation to continue along our chosen path is without reproof. Let us do all that we can to continue to make that so.

August 27

Hear my prayer, O LORD, and let my cry come unto thee.

My heart is smitten, and withered like grass; so that I forget to eat my bread.

Psalm 102

Freemasons walk a narrow path between the descent into materiality that is our human lot and the ascent towards divinity which is both our goal and our birthright.

It is easy to be disheartened by the things that befall us in our daily lives and easy to be despairing in these troubled times. It is not unusual or unnatural for our hearts to sink and our minds to become troubled. We are human, after all, and far from the perfection we crave.

But, as Freemasons, we also have a way out of the difficulties that beset us. Our lives are founded on faith in God and we trust that when we call out, we will be heard. More prosaically, perhaps, we are, at all times, just a short step or a phone call away from brothers who have sworn to be there for us, to assist us in our times of need. Just as you would be willing to help a brother in distress, remember that your brethren are there, ready and willing to help you.

August 28

All preferment among masons is grounded upon real worth and personal merit only;

Antient Charges

We are told time and again in our ritual that Masonry is a ‘progressive science’ and it is true that our system is so designed as to reveal to us aspects of truth as we develop our minds to receive it. Also, we progress through the various offices in the Lodge, usually in a well-defined order. Sometimes it seems that this progress is based purely on the question of who is next in line and little account appears to be taken of who most deserves preferment. From the outside, then, it could appear that ‘personal merit’ has little to do with progress but in fact the system works well because, once again, it assumes that all members of the Lodge are trying their hardest and are giving of their best. This genuine effort, for us, is proof enough of ‘worth and personal merit’ and is the only qualification necessary to proceed. Excellence is not required but a heartfelt and steadfast desire to keep trying, to keep improving, as human beings and as Masons, is.

August 29

Bless the LORD, O my soul, and forget not all his benefits:

Psalm 103

In spite of the difficulties that so often beset us, one of the distinguishing characteristics of a Freemason is - or ought to be - that of joy. We walk through this life upheld by our faith, supported by our brethren, happy in the knowledge that we are doing all that we can to alleviate the suffering of our fellows and treading a path that leads us towards our destiny.

With all of these things securely in our hearts, is it not easy to look at the world with joy and wonder? Is it not right that, beyond the shadows of earthly life, we see the light of heaven shining in all life and in all things?

How lucky we are to have this! Let us determine to remember, when things are hard, that we walk a path that ultimately leads to happiness.

August 30

You should make yourselves perfect in the work which falls to him, so that in the event of your being called upon to fill his place you may do so with credit to the Chapter.

Investiture of Assistant Sojourners

We are usually so caught up in the work we have to do in the Chapter that we can easily forget that there are others working just as hard. It is interesting here that those with less to do are enjoined to be ready to stand in, should another Companion be unable to fulfil his role. This is another example of how Freemasonry readies us gently for the offices and responsibilities that lie ahead of us but it also has wider implications. The idea that we should always be ready to step in to support or stand in for another is a very profound one. It forces us to be aware of them, of their work, their role, their place in our lives. It acknowledges without fuss our interdependence and the truth that we are stronger when united. Let us always be ready to step in to help another and to stand for them when needed. Let us trust that they will do the same for us.

August 31

I will sing unto the LORD as long as I live: I will sing praise to my God while I have my being.

My meditation of him shall be sweet: I will be glad in the LORD.

Psalm 104

When we start to see all the things that make our daily existence possible as manifestations of God's power and love, we enter into a state of being that is akin to grace. To look at the world and to see in every aspect of it the presence of the divine is a great blessing.

To be able to do this is not difficult but it does take practice and that is why all spiritual and religious paths encourage daily prayer, meditation or mindfulness. It is like learning a musical instrument or a new language: daily practice is the key to success.

When we consider how we might make our '...daily advancement in Masonic knowledge....' we would do well to remember how wide the definition of 'Masonic knowledge' may be, and remember that it very definitely includes the inclination to hone our skills of gratitude and joy.

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September 1

As Masons we should so act on the square as to enable us to part on the level with all mankind.

First Lecture

By square conduct, we, as Masons, understand that our actions should be marked by honesty and integrity. We are often reminded that these standards of behaviour are not to be limited to our Lodge meetings but should mark us out as 'good and true' to all the world. Although our meetings can act as an inspiration to us to strive always to maintain the highest standards of behaviour in regard to our dealings with all people, if that high-mindedness does not stay with us beyond the confines of the Lodge, it is of little value.

Our job as Masons is not to behave perfectly in Lodge and use that as a sop to our conscience when we fail to maintain those standards outside it, it is to try to carry that perfection into our daily lives and to learn to treat all of humankind as Brethren. And when we do depart from this world, as we all must, let the accolade, 'He was a good Mason,' be secondary to the greater acknowledgement of merit: 'He was a good man.'

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September 2

O give thanks unto the LORD; call upon his name: make known his deeds among the people.

Sing unto him, sing psalms unto him: talk ye of all his wondrous works.

Psalm 105

As Freemasons, one of our great lessons is trust. When we begin our Masonic path, we step into the unknown on so many levels: the obligations, the rituals, the company we commit to keep and more. Very early on in the process, we are asked, “In all cases of danger and difficulty in whom do you place your trust?” and our ability to answer this question with a clear conscience and in good faith is the key to understanding what lies before us.

One of the great joys of this path - indeed, any path with faith at its core - is that, in cultivating trust, we learn to let go of fear. The more secure we are in our trust in that Higher Power, the more free we are from the constraints and concerns of everyday life. It's not that we in any way denigrate the daily challenges that are our lot as human beings, it's that we learn to glide through them as a swan glides through water. We may paddle hard and feel resistance, but ultimately we emerge, unruffled, still beautiful and dry!

September 3

...but the public reputation of the Institution will be found generally to rise or fall as the character and conduct of its principal officers are estimable or censurable.

Charge to the Principals

The days of Masonic secrecy are – thankfully – over. It is no longer the norm for a Mason's family and connections to be unaware of their affiliation, indeed such a state of affairs would be unusual and strange in this day and age. There is no benefit in being a member of something we are embarrassed about, so our choices are to withdraw or to make it our business – by our behaviour, our relationships, by all our actions – to show the world that Freemasonry is something we take pride in and that it is worthy of our time and attention. The higher our position in Freemasonry the truer this becomes, but it is true of all of us. Let us remember, then, that beyond our circle of personal connections, our conduct matters in ways that we sometimes do not see and to people whom we do not always know. The world watches us – often with suspicion. Let us do all we can to reassure the world that we are a force for good.

September 4

Who can utter the mighty acts of the LORD? who can shew forth all his praise?

Psalm 106

We don't expect miracles in this day and age and we grow up hearing that 'the age of miracles is past' but if we learn to look more closely, we can come to see that everything is miraculous and the fact that we can largely explain it logically or scientifically makes it no less so.

Putting aside the greater mysteries of the universe and the existence of this beautiful green and fertile planet, you need think only of how you came to be here, at this moment in your life. Think of all the chances and coincidences that brought you here. The conversations you had, the choices you made, the possibilities you did or did not follow up. Think of your birth - the chance meeting of your parents, that brief coming together that created the uniqueness that is you, different from every other being, however close they may be in terms of genetics and DNA.

And think of what led you to this door: to knock at the portals of Freemasonry and bid you tread this path and to seek your goal through this profound and mysterious mystic way.

Is this not, in itself, a miracle?

September 5

Those three things did then, have since, and I trust ever will render the groundwork of Freemasonry Holy.

First Degree Ceremony

The First Degree Tracing Board contains a huge amount of information for the new initiate. It begins with an explanation of the symbolism of the outer form of the Lodge and it seeks to explain how it may be considered a Temple. It asks the initiate to consider that there are three things that lend our lodges holiness. They are compliance with the will of God, demonstrated by the willingness of Abraham to sacrifice his son; prayer, particularly for others, exemplified by the prayers of King David on his people's behalf; and thanksgiving like that shown by King Solomon and his household at the completion of the great Temple in Jerusalem.

Remembering this, we teach the initiate that when we enter our Lodges, we should try to put aside mundane matters and walk in humility in God's presence, for we stand on Holy ground.

September 6

Whoso is wise, and will observe these things, even they shall understand the lovingkindness of the LORD.

Psalm 107

We know that Freemasonry is spread over every corner of the globe and we therefore understand that there are men and women in every country and from every cultural, ethnic and religious background to whom we are bound with ties of brotherhood and promises of help and support.

Remembering this, we must acknowledge that our first duty in times of difficulty, difference or conflict is to look for a way to smooth the troubled waters, to look for peaceful outcomes that promote our understanding of the interconnectedness of all life on Earth.

We are all God's children and we all have the opportunity to see and understand the beauty of the world around us. As Freemasons, we have a particular duty to promote peace and to add to the aggregate of human happiness and fulfillment.

September 7

You are to see that your officers are capable and faithful in the discharge of their respective offices. Should they lack ability you are expected to remedy their defects.

Charge to the Principals

It's always easy to be disparaging of another's weaknesses and it's easy to take a position where one feels superior. How disturbing it is to be told that we are responsible for the shortcomings of our Companions! But how beautiful it is to be reminded of our unity and of the importance of the work we do together! In the Lodge and Chapter and out in the wider world, we are responsible for each other and – without detriment to ourselves or connections – we are committed to help lift all of humanity out of darkness and bring them towards the light. If we are further ahead on the path, we are no better than others: it is only time that is the difference between us and them. We got to where we are with the help and guidance of others and we continue to progress because of it. Now it is our turn to help those behind us and smooth their way as much as we are able.

September 8

O God, my heart is fixed; I will sing and give praise, even with my glory.

Psalm 108

What a lovely idea, that our hearts should be ‘fixed’; that we could rest always in the certainty of knowledge and never experience a moment of doubt. It may be true that, as Freemasons, with our clearly and beautifully structured system for making sense of the world, we do have moments of utterly joyful certainty but we must also admit that we all equally suffer from moments when our faith wavers and our path is rocky and steep.

It is in these dark moments that our daily practice comes to our aid. By being steeped in habits of gratitude, knowledge, and faithfulness; by being kind, generous and thoughtful in our daily lives and by holding the welfare of others as one of our guiding principles, we create in ourselves conditions where darkness cannot take root and where negativity cannot thrive. Of course it can come to us all and sometimes it can bring us down - but not for long. If we remember always to face the light, our shadow will always fall behind us.

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September 9

...and from the foundation laid this evening may you raise a superstructure perfect in its parts, and honourable to the builder.

First Degree Ceremony

Becoming a Freemason is no great accomplishment. A phone call to the local Masonic centre could do it; meet a few people, pay your dues, confirm your belief in a Supreme Being, promise to attend meetings regularly...and that's about it. A whole world of social opportunities opens up to you; the regular comradeship of your fellow Lodge members; even travel to other parts of the country or, indeed, other countries will afford opportunities for Brotherly visits. The process is simple, the benefits are obvious: in itself, it is no great accomplishment. But to be a good Freemason, that is something more.

A good Freemason, while enjoying and valuing the society that Masonry brings, knows that there is more to the Craft than that. We have to understand that becoming a Freemason is not the end of a journey but the beginning of one. Being a Mason does not automatically make us good people. That requires our own effort. The philosophical basis of Freemasonry and the discipline of its rituals provide us with the firmest of foundations but the building of the perfect superstructure is up to us.

September 10

I will greatly praise the LORD with my mouth... For he shall stand at the right hand of the poor, to save him from those that condemn his soul.

Psalm 109

It's completely natural to want to be thought of well by others but there are times when we are forced to make a choice between doing or saying what we know to be right and true or doing what we know will win us approval. Hopefully, in most cases, these are the same but when they are not, it can be difficult and painful.

As Freemasons, we are committed to the truth and to the practice of virtue. But we must also remember that we are committed to kindness, too; to gentleness, thoughtfulness and the welfare and happiness of others.

Before we speak or act from our position or sense of uncompromising rightness, we must ask ourselves who benefits from such a righteous stance. Is there room for compromise? Could there be another point of view that is also correct?

Once we are sure that our actions or words are justified in the sense that they will, hopefully, have the most positive and unifying effect, then we must act and speak fearlessly.

There will still be those who slander and mock and vilify but we can cope with that. We have support all around us and our strength comes from above.

September 11

It also strongly typifies that invariable adherence to social order and the spirit of fraternal union which has ever given energy and permanence to the whole constitution of Freemasonry, thereby enabling it to survive the wreck of mighty empires, and to resist the destroying hand of time.

Symbolical Lecture

Once again, we are called upon to consider the strength and symbolism of the catenarian arch. Interestingly, the word derives from the Latin word for 'chain' and we are immediately reminded of the symbolism contained in that lovely piece of ritual, given at many festive boards, The Entered Apprentice Chain. With the links of the chain, and the stones of the arch, a key understanding is that every link, every stone is vital to the strength of the whole. And while there is much symbolism to be derived from the keystone of the catenarian arch, for the moment let us just consider our interdependence, the fraternal bonds that link us as a chain around the globe, not only with our fellow Masons but with all of our Brothers and Sisters in the wider human family.

September 12

Thy people shall be willing in the day of thy power, in the beauties of holiness from the womb of the morning: thou hast the dew of thy youth.

Psalm 110

We know that worldly fame is fleeting and that riches and power are distractions from the real business of being human. We know that our true position is one of loving service, to our families, our communities, to the world at large and, ultimately, to our conception of the Divine.

But power comes in many guises and we all wield it in many ways in our daily lives. We may have financial power over our families, power over our employees, over the people we encounter daily whose jobs are to serve us in some way. There are power relationships in every nook and cranny of our lives and the more able we are to identify them, the more likely we are able to approach them in ways befitting a Freemason: with honesty, respect and love.

If we can treat those over whom we have power in this way, we can expect that we, in turn, will be treated respectfully and well by those who have power over us.

With mutual respect and a mindfulness of our true relationship as God's children, we will never go far wrong in our dealings with others.

September 13

You agree to promote the general good of Society, to cultivate the Social Virtues, and to propagate the knowledge of the Mystic Art as far as your influence and ability can extend.

Antient Charges

Perhaps one of the greatest difficulties that Freemasonry faces today is the question of how to present itself to the world. We are enjoined here to spread the knowledge of 'the Mystic Art' as widely as we can, and yet we undertake a most solemn obligation never to 'wilfully reveal any...of the secrets or mysteries of Freemasonry...' There appears to be a clear conflict between the two duties outlined here and we need to consider the question in greater depth. What is it that we are to spread and what does honour demand that we never reveal?

The true lessons of Freemasonry, as of all Spiritual teachings, are open to all. The key message of universal brotherhood under One God can, and should, be proclaimed by us, even if it is without words, in all we do and in all our dealings with others. What we have promised to keep secret are the things peculiar to Freemasonry that are designed, not to exclude outsiders, but as a gift and a privilege to those who choose to commit themselves to this particular path.

September 14

The works of the LORD are great, sought out of all them that have pleasure therein.

Psalm 111

We live surrounded by such beauty. As Freemasons we talk about the symmetry and order of creation in our rituals, we acknowledge the wonder of the world and our own part in it, but how many of us take time to study it closely and give ourselves the opportunity to experience that glory first hand?

The slow budding of the trees in spring; the gradual unfolding of a leaf or flower; the movement of the birds above us - all these things are living examples of what we learn and teach in Freemasonry. They are the application of our laws and the proof of our conjectures.

We are enjoined to make a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge and there is no doubt that to read and study and to contemplate the hidden mysteries are worthy actions for a Freemason to undertake. But let us not forget this beautiful world that supplies all our needs and which is the living tracing board of our Master, whereon can be found written the answers to all mysteries.

September 15

Companions in Office, precept and example should ever advance at an equal pace. Those moral duties which you are required to teach to others you should never neglect to practise yourselves.

Charge to the Officers

‘Practise what you preach’ is a well-known guard against hypocrisy and we all understand that to say one thing and do another renders a person untrustworthy and a source of instability to their connections. But it should not just be seen as a negative admonition because it is also a positive affirmation of a deep truth. To explain something well we have to understand it fully and to understand something fully we have to have experienced its truth for ourselves. So let us take this as a gentle reminder to be in a position of knowing before we attempt to teach. Let us remember that we must be willing to learn and practise all that we would like to share with others.

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September 16

Blessed is the man that feareth the LORD, that delighteth greatly in his commandments.

Wealth and riches shall be in his house: and his righteousness endureth for ever.

Psalm 112

It is not material wealth that Freemasons value. It is not material wealth that we strive for. Our ritual clearly calls on us to remember that we come from all backgrounds and that, while some are financially secure, for others, even paying Lodge dues and dining fees can be a struggle and a sacrifice.

The things that Freemasons do value and strive for are riches of a different kind: peace and harmony within ourselves, within our homes and families and within our communities; truth and justice; fairness; kindness; brotherhood; love. These are riches of the spirit that are never subject to the whimsical turns of Fortune's wheel. These are riches that will not rust and cannot be stolen.

They are won by our own daily practice, by our determination to live lives of service to our fellows and by a general and sincere upholding of all the Masonic virtues.

September 17

The distinguishing characteristics of a good Freemason are Virtue, Honour and Mercy, and may they ever be found in a Freemason's heart.

First Degree Ceremony

There is a certain irony in that we, as Masons, are to be distinguished by three things that are not always seen by our wider materialistic society as being of any value at all. The three excellences of character mentioned here are quiet ones, ones that grow and bear fruit in humility and strength of character. It is significant that they are to be looked for in a good Mason's heart, for they are inner, Spiritual virtues. While many in the outside world might value wealth, power and fame as an end in themselves, we prefer to strive for a different kind of riches and we know that a simple life, well lived, is the 'highest to which human nature can attain.'

September 18

*The LORD is high above all nations, and his glory above the heavens.
He raiseth up the poor out of the dust, and lifteth the needy out of the
dunghill;*

Psalm 113

When we step onto the Masonic path, we accept a view of the world that can put us at odds with some of the accepted orthodoxies of modern life. One of our greatest realisations is the understanding that all men and women are our brothers and sisters as children of God, regardless of every other consideration in terms of race, belief, sexual orientation or identification and all the many other things that can potentially divide us. This is, of course, the central concept of Freemasonry.

Although it is a simple enough concept, some of the implications of this idea are difficult because the acceptance of the truth of universal brotherhood transcends not only personal but also political, philosophical and national differences and so the whole question of conflict must be seen in a softer light.

It is not unusual or wrong for us to be proud of where we come from but Freemasons are called upon to go beyond a simple world-view of “us and them.” Freemasons understand that, in truth, there is only “us” and so they are slow to make war and keen to find peaceful solutions to conflicts - personal and societal - if they can.

September 19

*May your Chapter become beautiful as the Temple of King Solomon,
sacred as its most Holy Place and peaceful as the Ark which it enshrines.*

Charge to the Officers

What a beautiful thought! That our Chapters should be so blessed with beauty and holiness and peace. Is it possible? And what does it mean?

Yes, it is possible – but only through our own endeavours. What we do in the Chapter, how we behave towards each other, the solemnity we bring to our rituals and the joy with which we enact them will bring all of these things among us.

What was it that made the Temple so beautiful; the Holy Place so sacred; the Ark such a source of peace? The answer to all three questions is the same: the Presence of God.

To make God present among us is a simple thing: act with sincerity and with love; embody those truly Masonic virtues of Faith, Hope and Charity and the Spirit of God will be with us, in the Lodge, in the Chapter and in our hearts, wherever we go.

September 20

When Israel went out of Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of strange language;

The sea saw it, and fled: Jordan was driven back.

The mountains skipped like rams, and the little hills like lambs.

Psalm 114

This moment of freedom is one that is mentioned frequently in our ritual. It is the moment, some would say, when the foundations of our current western civilisation were laid. It is the moment of law-giving, of submitting to a shared code of behaviour and ethics that unifies a people and makes a coherent society.

From a Masonic point of view, it is also the time of the laying down of the ground plan of the Temple that would one day be built at Jerusalem by King Solomon, the orientation of which was determined by Moses.

There are modern lessons too: we can reflect deeply on the importance of shared languages and understandings; we can and should consider the many forms of bondage that still exist in our societies today and we should consider it our duty to not only learn to find freedom for ourselves but also actively seek to free others who may be stuck in situations of suffering from which they cannot escape without help. In doing so, of course, we must not seek to bind them to our ways of thinking, but must bestow true freedom, in thought, word and deed.

September 21

*May our work, begun in Thee,
Ever blest with order be,
And may we, when labours cease,
Part in harmony and peace.*

Opening Ode

The process of opening the Lodge is an important one. So much of the early part of the ritual of any degree is designed purely to focus our minds and hearts on the main work of the ceremony that is to come. Gradually our attention is drawn away from the outer world and brought to rest on the teachings and symbolism to be found within the Lodge. The singing of an opening hymn is a part of this process and it has the added virtue of forcing us to unite in a song of praise and, literally, fill the very air with vibrations of harmony and peace.

September 22

But our God is in the heavens: he hath done whatsoever he hath pleased.

Psalm 115

The seductions of the world are many and there is such a fine line between appreciating its beauty and its bounty and being overwhelmed by it. Our constant desire for “more and better” is killing the very world that we are seeking so desperately to possess.

If we can learn to let go, to step back, to loosen our hold on and desire for material comfort and possessions, we will be able to reflect more readily and easily on the things that truly matter.

This life is beautiful and definitely to be enjoyed as far as is possible without detriment to others, but we must never lose sight of the fact that it is temporary and fleeting and that, beyond its illusory veil, another, greater life awaits.

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September 23

CULTOR DEI CIVIS MUNDI

Royal Arch Jewel

This small inscription, to be found (after careful search) on the Royal Arch jewel is, perhaps, the clearest and most profound statement of what it is to be a Freemason. It is translated in the explanation of the jewel as: 'A worshipper of God and a citizen of the world.' And this, quite simply is what we are. When all else is washed away; when all the things that can divide and separate us and set us against each other are gone, this is what we are. No creed or colour, no religion or race; no sexuality or nationality, no tribe or clan or political persuasion: we worship God and we are citizens of the world: kin to all; brothers to all; and we work for the good of all.

September 24

I love the LORD, because he hath heard my voice and my supplications.

Return unto thy rest, O my soul; for the LORD hath dealt bountifully with thee.

Psalm 116

As Freemasons, we all profess to have a belief in a Supreme Being. We have Faith. It is not necessarily something we choose to define or even talk about but it is one of the chief characteristics of a Freemason.

A life of Faith does not need to be discussed or defined but it does need to be lived. There is nothing to be gained if we profess faith but live in fear: it doesn't make sense. If we have faith, we need have no fear and so the true manifestation of a life lived in faith is a life lived fearlessly; a life dedicated to living truthfully and generously; a life of kindness and service; a life of joy and tolerance and love.

Freemasons have the opportunity to be fearless in their pursuit of a better world. This doesn't mean that we must all take up lives of political activism, it simply means that in our daily lives, in all our interactions with others, however insignificant they might appear, we must be our best selves, our true selves, our faithful selves.

September 25

‘What is Freemasonry?’

‘A peculiar system of morality, veiled in allegory and illustrated by symbol.’

Second Degree Ceremony

When asked by non-Masons to explain what Masonry is, we often struggle to find the right words. We tend to answer in terms of what Freemasonry does in the outer world, particularly in terms of the amount of charity it does. It is as if we can only understand it ourselves and justify it to others in a way that is acceptable and concrete and so we end up by presenting ourselves purely as a charitable institution. This is not untrue: we do a great deal of good in the world, but it is not what we are.

Charity is the logical outcome of a system that stresses the correct relationship between humanity and God. But being a charitable organisation is not enough to explain why we have ‘strange’ and private rituals. We need to be clearer in our understanding of what we are and present that understanding in a clearer light to society at large. We are private and it is true that we do have secrets, but that is our right and our privilege. That we work for the benefit of humankind is neither private nor secret. Let us be proud of what we are and let the truth of the fact that Freemasonry teaches morality above all else shine out from us all.

September 26

*O praise the LORD, all ye nations: praise him, all ye people.
For his merciful kindness is great toward us:*

Psalm 117

Living a good life is not so difficult. It only takes the smallest of mental shifts to turn negative into positive.

To be grateful and to count our blessings may be the most powerful exercise we can undertake to turn our lives around and to ensure that we not only remain positive but that we also help and support others to find the positives in their lives.

We have much to be thankful for. Let's get into the habit - every day - of acknowledging it. Let's make it part of our daily practice, part of our 'daily advancement.'

September 27

The Circle is an Emblem of Eternity. The equilateral triangle point upwards is a symbol of Fire, and as the flames rise this represents the aspirations of man to higher things; the equilateral triangle point downwards is a symbol of Water – Dew, the Grace of God falling on all mankind. Thus we have Man's Aspirations and God's Grace all within the Circle of Eternity;

Presentation of Supreme Grand Chapter Certificate

Again we are reminded that while we can aspire to reach the heights, we can only fully achieve them by being met halfway by the Grace of God descending to us. This lovely symbol of the fire in our hearts, burning for the Divine, and the cooling balm of the dew descending from Heaven should awake in us an awareness of our role as sharers with God of the responsibilities of being human. We are made to look upwards, to progress from the material to the spiritual but at the same time we are here to manifest God on earth. What is spirit helps lifts us up and what is physical helps God come down. It is a profound thought and a weighty responsibility but within the eternal circle we are held secure.

September 28

It is better to trust in the LORD than to put confidence in man.

The stone which the builders refused is become the head stone of the corner.

Psalm 118

The values of the world and the values that actuate those who are committed to a path of inner, spiritual development are not the same. The material delights of the physical world are not what motivate the true seeker and that which is of value to the aspirant is worthless in the material world.

Thus Freemasons often tread a lonely path when they walk through the outer world and, while we acknowledge the beauty to be found on this earthly plane, we know that it is fleeting - a shadow of the true life that lies within and beyond.

This is why the brotherhood and companionship of our fellows are so important to us - we do not need to walk the path alone. And this is why we hold so fast to our faith - for when we fix our minds on God, we see things for what they truly are.

September 29

To all poor and distressed Masons, where'er they may be.

The Tyler's Toast

The Tyler's toast is the last ritual act of the evening. After the formality of the ceremony within the Lodge and the structured but less formal gathering of the festive board, where we often enjoy good food and fine wine, we are called upon to remember our less fortunate Brethren. This moving toast reminds us that even within the ranks of Freemasonry there are those who suffer or who are adrift and lost on the stormy seas of life and we pray for an end to their wanderings and their pain.

It means that, before we leave the comradeship of our fellows to return to our daily lives, our attention is once more drawn to the fact that Freemasonry widens our sphere of interest and influence enormously. There are Freemasons and, therefore, people generally, across the whole of the globe, living in conditions that we would consider beneath human dignity. Our prayer for 'poor and distressed Masons' should not only cause us to consider the suffering of our Brothers, but also that of our wider human family. Let us be thankful for what we have in comparison, but let us also determine to do what we can to work for a better, fairer world.

September 30

*Blessed are the undefiled in the way, who walk in the law of the LORD.
Blessed are they that keep his testimonies, and that seek him with the
whole heart.*

They also do no iniquity: they walk in his ways.

Psalm 119 ALEPH.

It's not easy to navigate the paths and pitfalls of this world. There is so much to distract us, so much to confuse us, so much dross to interfere with our inner compasses that we can quickly and imperceptibly find ourselves lost and adrift.

So many of the certainties with which we grew up have proved to be wrong or have been reframed in the light of new understandings or new sensibilities that we can find ourselves wondering if the world we thought we knew ever really existed.

The truth is that the material world has always been an unreliable reflection of reality and is always shifting and changeable. The only way to maintain certainty is to live with an attitude and a sense of love, devotion and service to God and to our fellow creatures. Acting in this way relieves us of the agony of wondering whether this or that action is right or wrong because every action undertaken in the service of others and performed in love, is almost certain to be positive. Here is another 'secret' of Freemasonry.

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October 1

They gave money also unto the masons, and to the carpenters; and meat, and drink, and oil, unto them of Zidon, and to them of Tyre, to bring cedar trees from Lebanon to the sea of Joppa, according to the grant that they had of Cyrus king of Persia.

Ezra 3:7

It's nice to think that we have some sort of connection – even if it's a symbolical one – with those ancient masons who helped rebuild the Temple in Jerusalem. It's also interesting to note the number of different people involved in the labour besides the masons: from Cyrus himself to the administrators that must have been needed, to the sailors and woodsmen and carpenters. If we are to learn anything from this, let it remind us that we never work alone. Imagine a Temple built of stone alone: no cloth for the floors and walls, no ornaments for the Holy of Holies, no metal artefacts or ornaments. We need others around us just as they need us around them. All of us, everywhere across the globe, are connected in a web of interdependence. Let us determine to use this interconnectedness positively

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October 2

I am a stranger in the earth: hide not thy commandments from me.

Psalm 119 GIMEL.

Freemasonry recognises that the paths of this world are sometimes hard to navigate and it offers us various tools to help us when we are lost and troubled. Of course, our faith in God and the loving guidance of our brethren are often our most obvious and immediate supports but there are others.

In the second degree ceremony we are reminded that Freemasonry offers us a boat with which to sail the stormy seas of passion and ignorance and in the lecture on the first degree tracing board it is stated that the VSL offers us a clear way through. We are encouraged to consider that it is the tracing board we should constantly consult as we build the temple of our earthly life and make it a fit place for the in-dwelling of divine light.

Of course, not all Freemasons follow the same VSL and so, if this teaching is a true one, we must consider what it is that is common to all and the answer to that question lies in the golden rule: that we must simply 'do unto others as you would have them do unto you.'

October 3

There is no truth more thoroughly established, than that there exists in the economy and course of nature an indissoluble union between virtue and happiness, between duty and advantage, between the genuine maxims of an honest and magnanimous policy, and the solid rewards of public prosperity and felicity.

George Washington

Much of what we are and what we do as Masons involves the progress of the individual along the path of life. We strive to ensure that the path we take and along which we try to guide our Brothers is one that will, through correctly applied effort, lead to virtue. We understand the connection between virtue and happiness and that we will all reap what we have sown. What we sometimes forget is the wider picture, the benefit to society at large that our attempts to improve ourselves will bring. Like yeast in dough, the benevolent actions of individuals are what results in 'public prosperity.' Let us not lose sight of this great truth; when the condition and direction of the world gets us down, let us not become disheartened. What we do and how we behave as individuals does matter.

October 4

*My soul cleaveth unto the dust: quicken thou me according to thy word.
My soul melteth for heaviness: strengthen thou me according unto thy word.*

Psalm 119 DALETH.

When we speak of ‘darkness visible’ we recognise that this earthly life and these human bodies are but shadows and reflections of reality. The fact that they are material and temporary when we know ourselves, as children of God, to be spiritual and eternal is proof enough of that.

That we are souls, lighter than air but encompassed by dust and heaviness, is a truth on which we must learn to meditate night and day.

Where is the self that calls this body home? It is clearly not the body but nor is it the mind: the fact that we can watch ourselves think proves that.

To truly know ourselves, we must look deep within. We must find stillness; we must watch our minds at work and learn to understand its ways. We must learn to find that centre from which we cannot err. This is the Mason’s way.

October 5

Even God cannot change the past.

Agathon (attrib.)

On the one hand, whatever lies behind us is done and finished with, but on the other, what has gone before defines and shapes us and is what has made us what we are. All of our deeds, good and bad, remain and live on in the echoes and repercussions they had – and have – in the lives of those who were affected by them. As Freemasons, we are encouraged to always look forward, to raise our eyes to the heavens and direct our steps on paths that will lead us to our avowed destination: a life lived in ever greater appreciation of our relationship with our Creator and in greater harmony with the world around us. None of us can change the past but all of us can determine to create a more hopeful future.

October 6

And take not the word of truth utterly out of my mouth; for I have hoped in thy judgments.

Psalm 119 VAU.

As Freemasons, we are committed to make a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge and when we understand the scope and breadth and depth of Masonic knowledge, we begin to understand that this is deeply spiritual work, for it is knowledge of the self and knowledge of God that we seek. We make progress along this path with the support and guidance of our brethren but also, largely, by our own efforts: our determination to live well; to study, to think and to meditate on the deep truths that are presented to us.

But we rely on grace, too. We rely on God's mercy, on the promise and understanding that our efforts to ascend will be met with a commensurate descent of spirit to meet us and raise us up. The first step is always for us to make, but we should never doubt that it will be reciprocated.

The descent of spirit into matter and the ascent of matter back to spirit are the foundations and key to an understanding of what this human life is for and it is the primary meaning to be found in our primary symbol: the square and compasses.

It is in humankind that spirit and matter have the chance to become self-aware and so find enlightenment and freedom.

October 7

A younger brother shall be instructed in working...for increasing and continuing of brotherly love.

Antient Charges

When we come to Freemasonry, we are initiated into its customs and mysteries not only through the formula of its ritual, but by the words and attitudes of our new-made Brethren. Just as members of a family may treat each other with easy familiarity when alone, but demonstrate their strength and solidarity when with others, so should we take care to show off our Craft in its best and most dignified light to a new-comer when, with more experienced Brethren, we might be more carefree in our approach. To enjoy the company of our Brethren in Lodge and at the festive board is important, but more important is to instil in a new candidate a proper reverence and respect for the rituals and customs of the Order. Masonic ritual is fine, well-crafted and noble but without people to use and transmit it carefully and respectfully, it is just so many words.

Let us aim to transmit the outer form and inner spirit of Freemasonry to our 'younger' Brethren in such a way that they will easily and quickly learn to love our mystic Art.

October 8

I have remembered thy name, O LORD, in the night, and have kept thy law.

Psalm 119 ZAIN.

People ask us what it is that we get out of Freemasonry and they often feel cheated when we explain that there is no material gain whatsoever. In fact, Freemasonry can cost us a great deal of both time and money.

We do gain something from it, nevertheless, something fine and wonderful and, for those looking for the 'catch', almost impossible to understand.

The gifts that Freemasonry gives us, as we know, are felt in the heart. They are, amongst other things, a sense of brotherhood; a deep peace that comes from knowing that we are beginning to align our lives with their true purpose; the satisfaction of serving and helping others; the joy of giving.

And, as we progress in our understanding, it is the confidence that comes with knowing who we truly are and realising with certainty the true nature of our relationship to our Creator.

These things are all delights to the spirit and they are available to all people at all times - not just Freemasons. We have only to remember and to ask.

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October 9

*Here's a health to all those that we love,
Here's a health to all those that love us,
Here's a health to all those that love them that love those
That love them that love those that love us.*

Anon

As we make the conscious effort to live lives that are kinder, more gentle, more considerate; more conscious of our Creator and our fellow creatures, we come more and more into loving relationships with those around us. We soften and grow and learn to value that warmth of brotherhood that is the key to our enjoyment of Freemasonry. And the great thing is that love, by its nature, spreads and grows the more it is acknowledged and invoked so that, if we wish, with very little effort on our part, we can find ourselves at the centre of an ever-widening circle of love that will support and hold us; and we can know that the same is true for the circle of our friends and connections. What a great gift to bring to the world!

October 10

Thou art my portion, O LORD: I have said that I would keep thy words.

Psalm 119 CHETH.

It's easy to keep our faith when things are easy and flowing well. Sometimes the sun shines every day and everything we say and do feels like it is just the right thing to say and do in any given moment. We feel, at times like this, that we are truly blessed and we sing the praises of that Divine Being in whose hand we are so gently yet securely held.

But when things go wrong - which they do, equally often - that is the time when our faith is tested and the foundations of the temple we are trying to build are shaken.

If we can hold firm in the dark days, in the difficult days, when the world seems to be against us and we are reviled and misunderstood, then we know that our faith is firm and our foundations are strong. And this knowledge and this experience is enough to ensure that, when the darkness threatens to engulf us again, it will be a little less dark; its hold on us will be a little weaker and we will recover from it a little more quickly.

This is the mercy that is given to the faithful heart: a promise of the end of suffering.

October 11

...ever remembering the intention, which is the acquisition of love, wisdom and understanding...

Ceremony of Exaltation

For all the pleasure we derive from our association with Freemasonry, for all the festive boards and social gatherings, even those with a charitable purpose, we must remember that we are engaged in a Spiritual pursuit and our great and final aim is to move humankind closer to God. Social and charitable activities and the enjoyment of the companionship of our Brethren are not necessarily of less value than the business within the Lodge, but we need to differentiate between what is cause and what is effect. Masonic ritual and philosophy lie at the core of what we do; it is this that brings us together as companions with shared experience and it is this that actuates us to give to those less fortunate than ourselves.

So let us enjoy our gatherings, our festive boards, our charitable galas and let us continue to bring material benefit to those in need. But let us not lose sight of that mountain peak of love, wisdom and understanding which is our highest aspiration and the source of true Brotherhood.

October 12

Thou hast dealt well with thy servant, O LORD, according unto thy word.

It is good for me that I have been afflicted; that I might learn thy statutes.

Psalm 119 TETH.

We all have our share of suffering to endure in this world. The vagaries of material life mean that we all, at some point, suffer pain, heartache, grief and loss. This is part of the human experience.

In the same way, we all carry with us regrets about our past behaviours: about things we did that we wish we hadn't done or things we didn't do that we wish we had. It's almost impossible to get through life without regret of some kind, without falling down and falling short of our own high standards.

One of the most reassuring things that Freemasonry gives us is the fact that it is a path of forgiveness; a path that recognises human weakness and which encourages us to simply be the best we can be at any given moment. It tells us always that, here and now, in this moment, our best is good enough. We are good enough. And in a world that lives so much by the doctrine of 'could do better', that message is an important one for us to hear and assimilate.

October 13

*Hierusalem, my happy home,
When shall I come to thee?
When shall my sorrows have an end,
Thy joys when shall I see?*

Anon.

As Freemasons, we profess a belief in God – whatever we conceive that God to be – and our belief creates in us a hope that beyond this mortal life there lies another, greater, more real existence. Whatever that other existence proves to be, we can only express it now in terms of the ideals that we hold and the limited idea of perfection that is available to us in our current, imperfect state. The Temple that we build of our lives on earth may have its foundations planted on the ground of this reality but, as we build, we do what we can to ensure that its heights will reach beyond this life into that great hope of futurity. And so we build, not just for our present concerns, but also for our anticipated future in a holy city only hinted at by this earthly Jerusalem.

October 14

They that fear thee will be glad when they see me; because I have hoped in thy word.

Psalm 119 JOD.

Being a Freemason carries many responsibilities. Not only do we accept the task of bettering ourselves, we also take on the role of mentor and support to our Brethren. More than that, we also undertake to ameliorate the lives of others in any way that we can and to be a constant example of a life well lived.

And we are ambassadors, too, representing the institution of Freemasonry in the outer world, showing always that those who are members of this ancient Craft are honourable, ethical and true. The order is judged by the behaviour of its members and we must be conscious of the fact that, rightly or wrongly, our actions as individuals will determine how the whole superstructure is seen. The building is only as strong as the individual stones from which it is made.

And lastly, of course, we stand as believers in God and our greatest task is to show that faith is capable of bringing a force of love and healing to a fractured world.

October 15

We deem the lowest service in the work of the Lord to be to us an honour...

Ceremony of Exaltation

The real test of Brotherhood does not lie in fine words or in lofty philosophy; it is not brought to light in high ideals or a good heart alone. All these things might inspire the belief in universal Brotherhood and help it to actuate and inform a person's approach to life, but it is only in the living of that life that these principles can be truly seen.

For the concept of brotherhood to mean anything, it must be with all humankind and this means with the lowest as well as the highest in society. Understanding our true relationship with our Creator, Masons must strive to serve all people without distinction, without fear of reprisal or hope of reward other than that which comes from knowing that we are doing 'the work of the Lord.'

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October 16

My soul fainteth for thy salvation: but I hope in thy word.

Mine eyes fail for thy word, saying, When wilt thou comfort me?

Psalm 119 CAPH.

As Freemasons, we place great store by the promises contained in the Volume of the Sacred Law. We know that it is our faith in the promises contained in that holy book that enables us to take the first steps on Jacob's ladder and which engenders in us the dream of perfection and the hope of futurity.

But reliance only on the written word is not enough. The entirety of God is not to be found in ancient texts despite the fact that, in their pages, clear glimpses of Him can be seen. If we are truly to manifest a worthwhile and dynamic faith that can bring love and healing to all, then we must lift our eyes from those dusty pages and learn to read the book of ourselves; the book of our hearts.

Freemasonry, descended as it is, from ancient initiatory paths, must move us away from the fixed doctrines of the past and be the vehicle by which we rise above all doctrines and dogmas to find the one universal truth: that all is one and Love is all.

October 17

The nature of God is a circle of which the centre is everywhere and the circumference is nowhere.

Anon.

This is an image that should please every Freemason. We are taught to consider the idea that our 'lost secrets' are to be found with the centre but it is never fully explained what that centre is. We know it is a point from which we can act without error but what is it, really, in our lives? We can begin to understand the concept by thinking that the centre is our innermost self but from there we need to consider the idea that at the centre of our innermost self is God. To understand that the circle is God and is therefore everything in our lives and our world, is to begin to approach the truth. The circle is so all-encompassing, so vast, that the point that is its centre is already everything we can conceive of; therefore its limits, its outer edge or circumference is so far beyond our understanding as to be nowhere in so far as we can comprehend it. To meditate on this image is to let your mind expand to the very limits of human consciousness and, perhaps for a moment, to touch the infinite.

October 18

For ever, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven.

Psalm 119 LAMED.

The laws that govern the order of the universe are not varied or variable according to the whims of a capricious deity. The operations of nature and science are set and evolve according to principles that are universal and unalterable.

Freemasons seek to discover and to live within these natural laws because we know that this is the way to be happy and at peace. We know that when we fulfil our proper function as human beings and children of God, recognising the Divine in every other creature, we manifest those laws and heal the world.

And what is our proper function? To love, to serve and to build within our hearts that temple fit for the in-dwelling of our Lord.

October 19

There is no secret with regard to any of the basic principles of Freemasonry...

Aims and Relationships of the Craft

It is a great shame that so many in the world look upon Freemasonry with mistrust. Of course, it is often the case that where a group of people keep secrets, there will be anger, resentment and suspicion; but we need also to ask ourselves if we have not played a part in allowing this negative image to go unchallenged. Pointing out that we do much for charity is seen as something of a sop because it simply does not explain why secrecy and privacy are so prized by us. We are confused about what may be spoken of openly and what constitute our 'secrets', so that many of us maintain a silence about all our involvement in Masonry and thus the suspicions are allowed to grow.

All the basic principles of Freemasonry are open; indeed, they only have value because they are universal. The form and content of our rituals are private and to talk of them out of context and to those who have not taken part in them is to invite ridicule and mockery from those who cannot appreciate their solemnity. The secrets of Freemasonry are those signs, words and tokens by which Masons 'are known to each other.'

October 20

Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.

Psalm 119 NUN.

It has always been known that, if we want to walk a particular path in life, it is far, far easier if we walk it in company, with others travelling in the same direction. We can travel alone if we wish - there is nothing to stop us and sometimes aloneness is both soothing and necessary for the spirit - but we are social animals by nature and we do better in communities and societies of like-minded people.

One of the reasons Freemasonry is so strong is that it caters to our need for company and, at the same time, it recognises where discord can arise and takes steps to prevent it. And so it is that, as Freemasons, we meet in a space that upholds the widest sense of what it is to be human; the broadest understanding of the spiritual path; the deepest conception of our relationship with our Creator.

When we say we meet 'on the level,' we should remember that it is not the lowest level of commonality, but the highest.

October 21

We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created equal.

American Declaration of Independence

Some things are so obvious that we think they don't need saying. And yet some truths are so important, so overwhelmingly central to the way we understand ourselves and the world around us that they must be stated and repeated so that they become totally assimilated into what we are. Sometimes things are so obvious that we don't say them enough and then we forget them, or at least forget their importance.

So let us state again, and remember it in our lives and make its truth self-evident in the way we interact with everybody with whom we come into contact: we believe absolutely that all human beings are the children of God and that we live with them as brothers and sisters, over, above and beyond any Masonic connection. If we are Brothers to our fellow Masons, we are, surely, Brothers to all.

October 22

*Make thy face to shine upon thy servant; and teach me thy statutes.
Rivers of waters run down mine eyes, because they keep not thy law.*

Psalm 119 PE.

To be saddened by the state of the planet is an entirely appropriate response. There is so much beauty and such great abundance and yet, somehow, our species has managed to create a world full of poverty, suffering, deprivation and need. Even in our most prosperous cities there are malnourished children and vulnerable adults living without homes and with no means of support, abandoned by uncaring societies and punitive governments.

Freemasons, who understand their connection to all people and who see that it is their brothers and sisters who suffer, are often moved to help. It does all of us great credit when individual lodges or even whole jurisdictions get out on to the streets to support those in need and there is no doubt that to do so is a right and proper undertaking for any Mason.

But there is more. Our Masonic obligations should lead us to be a force in the creation of societies that are fair and equitable; that encourage the strong to support the weak, remembering always that we, too, are just the humble sons of a poor widow.

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October 23

Let a man's religion or mode of worship be what it may, he is not excluded from the order, provided he believe in the glorious architect of heaven and earth, and practise the sacred duties of morality.

Antient Charges

Freemasonry has not always been looked upon kindly by those who profess to be religious. In this exhortation, one can begin to see why. Here is truly progressive thought; here is true liberalism; here is a monotheism so inclusive as to put many practitioners of the world's great religions to shame. That any person may draw closer to God, irrespective of any other consideration save that he believe in God and live an upright life according to custom and ability, is a radical thought indeed. It is central to our understanding of Freemasonry and it is, perhaps, one of the greatest gifts that the Craft can give to the world: living proof that people of all races and creeds can join together to work for the common good.

October 24

*Righteous art thou, O LORD, and upright are thy judgments.
Thy testimonies that thou hast commanded are righteous and very
faithful.*

Psalm 119 TZADDI.

Although we are enjoined not to discuss religion in our lodges, it is important that we consider the relationship between the Craft and our personal faith. Many of us have come to Freemasonry by way of a sincere desire to live a more meaningful, spiritual life and many of us are actively involved in our own particular religious traditions.

One of the greatest delights of Freemasonry is its ability to bring people of different religions together in complete harmony and it is very important that we are aware of how this is made possible when different religions - and even different strands of the same religion - can appear, on the surface, so contradictory.

As Freemasons, one of our gifts to the world is our understanding that, despite all of our apparent differences, we are one people, beloved children of one true, eternal God.

October 25

From the gods comes the saying, 'Know thyself.'

Juvenal

In the ceremony of exaltation, we are led, eventually, to an understanding that our ultimate task is to realise our true relationship with our Creator. We are not asked to do this by trying to understand God's nature fully because it is a given that we are not able to conceive of it in anything other than very simple terms. This is why we approach with head bowed and eyes shielded. However, we can come to an understanding of God through an understanding of ourselves and it is for this reason that we are lowered into the darkness that represents the human condition to find God's word, through which we are once more restored to the light of knowledge. In coming to know ourselves, we step ever closer towards the source of that light and we trust that, one day, we will be provided with the tools we need to render our knowledge complete.

October 26

*Consider mine affliction, and deliver me: for I do not forget thy law.
Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous
judgments endureth for ever.*

Psalm 119 RESH.

Some things last and some things change or disappear with the passing of the years. The idea that the world was flat; that the sun and planets revolved around the Earth - these ideas were the accepted truths of their day but as knowledge and consciousness expanded, so understanding grew and the old 'truths' gave way to new ones. This is a natural part and pattern of human development.

But some things do not change. Some truths are always true and it has always been the burning desire of the spiritual seeker, the aspirant, to find those truths that are eternal: always true because they reflect the actual reality of how the universe works and is governed.

Freemasons, too, are seekers of these eternal truths and all our talk of building in stone is a metaphor for the lasting structure we wish to build with our lives: structures founded on reality and therefore eternal and true in the deepest sense of the word.

October 27

It is not enough that in the lodge room or among Freemasons the bond of brotherhood should hold. It is the mission of the craft to spread the gospel of human kinship that all the world will acknowledge the bonds of amity and accord.

Anon

The concept of brotherhood is not like a piece of regalia that we put on for our meetings and then put aside until we next come together. While it may be recharged and renewed in Lodge, it must be carried with us into our daily lives and inform all our relationships with others. The lamp that Freemasonry holds up for us is not designed to just illuminate itself, it is to help shed light on all the world. If this, truly, is Freemasonry's mission, let us once more dedicate ourselves to living out our belief in 'human kinship' every day.

October 28

Great peace have they which love thy law: and nothing shall offend them.

Psalm 119 SCHIN.

Faith is an interesting concept because while it is so often assumed to be belief based on nothing more than hope or hearsay, it is, in fact, more complicated than that. A life lived in faith is a life founded on a deep, personal knowing. It is a direct and dynamic relationship with our highest self and with our Creator, the Supreme Being - with God, if that is how you wish to frame it.

And a life lived in such a way is a great source of peace because when we have at least a degree of certainty about what Masonry refers to as ‘...the prospect of futurity...’ we are released from the fear of death that is the curse of humankind.

Having, as we do, this deep and personal relationship with God, we can remain calm in the face of challenge, sure of our ground and unaffected by the vagaries and fashions of the outer world.

October 29

If a man will begin with certainties, he shall end in doubts; but if he will be content to begin with doubts, he shall end in certainties.

Francis Bacon

Sometimes knowing can be an impediment on the road to true understanding. When we are sure we know something, we close our minds to the possibility that there may be yet more to comprehend. But if we approach with an open mind and an open heart, willing to listen, willing to adopt a more humble demeanour, we may learn more than we could have imagined. Freemasonry always offers more lessons, deeper insights and the possibility of ever greater levels of understanding and we must be sure to stay open to this great gift that the Order offers to us. It is for this reason that we are encouraged 'to make a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge.' Those who suggest that this injunction only applies to the learning of ritual have already closed themselves off from the infinite possibilities that deeper study might afford them. Let us determine to remain open, to allow a level of doubt in our knowing and to trust, all the while that this will lead, in the end, to certainty.

October 30

My tongue shall speak of thy word: for all thy commandments are righteousness.

Psalm 119 TAU.

The arms of Freemasonry bear the Latin words, “Aude, Vide, Tace” which translate as: “Listen, Watch, Be Silent.” This alludes to the long tradition in Freemasonry and in the mystery schools that preceded it and on which it is modelled, to remain silent about the inner teachings of the order because of a belief and an assumption that the majority of people were not ready to understand them. Times have changed, however, and there is no doubt that all over the world there is a great need and a great hunger for truly spiritual teachings that can bestow peace and sanity on a chaotic and frightening world.

Of course, we are bound by our obligations to keep certain secrets relating to the ways in which we identify ourselves as Masons, but beyond that, there is a definite shift of attitude and consciousness and a genuine desire for us to share our knowledge and understandings with the world at large.

Remembering that the most important teaching of Freemasonry is the great truth that we are all one, we can allow that understanding to guide our speech and, in doing so, we can rest assured that we will say the right things to the right people at the right time.

We can do no more than that.

October 31

But men must know, that in this theatre of man's life it is reserved only for God and angels to be lookers on.

Francis Bacon

One thing that can be said about Freemasonry is that we understand that our task on earth is to build; and that what we build is a Temple to the glory of God. But, of course, the Temple is a metaphorical one and what we actually build are good lives and good relationships. What is important, though, is that we act; that we actually do something constructive to bring about that better world that we believe is both possible and natural for us. We are not onlookers here; these are our lives, our friends, our families, our brothers and sisters across the world whose lives can be touched and bettered by our actions. In becoming Freemasons, we made a conscious acknowledgement of our interconnectedness with all of God's children and now it is up to us to act in such a way as to demonstrate that fact in a way that improves the lives of those around us. We don't need to be world leaders to do this, we just need to be the best that we can be with those within our circle, however small and humble.

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November 1

In my distress I cried unto the LORD, and he heard me.

Psalm 120 A Song of Degrees.

The Winding Staircase 1

The fifteen Psalms that begin with Psalm 120 are each subtitled with the phrase, 'A Song of Degrees/Ascents' and they are of particular interest to Freemasons.

They are said to correspond to the fifteen steps in the Temple at Jerusalem that led, according to scholars, from the main courtyard up to the women's court. In Masonic mythology, we know that those steps led to the middle chamber of the Temple, where our ancient brethren went to receive their wages and where they discovered the sacred symbols.

The symbolic meaning of the gradual ascent is relevant on many levels. Freemasonry is an initiatory path and knowledge is imparted as the candidate progresses upwards. Our human lives are a gradual ascent from base materiality towards pure spirituality, manifested in our attainment of God. This ascent is made in stages, each step taken once the lessons of the former are learned and assimilated. In Masonic ritual the staircase is described as consisting of three flights of steps, the first numbering three, the second five and third, seven. Our first step, therefore, on the flight of three may be seen as our first regular step in Freemasonry: a new initiate, seeking knowledge and light, ready to be instructed in the secrets and mysteries of the Craft.

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November 2

*The LORD shall preserve thee from all evil: he shall preserve thy soul.
The LORD shall preserve thy going out and thy coming in from this
time forth, and even for evermore.*

Psalm 121 A Song of degrees. The Winding Staircase 2

On the second step we learn trust. Our second regular step in Freemasonry is taken with our eyes open, the darkness of our first entrance into the Lodge behind us and the trials of a Master Mason still before us. In this degree we learn more about the great Temple at Jerusalem and some of the mythology and symbolism surrounding it. On the middle rung of this flight of three steps, it is fitting that we learn of the three who rule the lodge and whom they represent. We learned in the first degree that they also represent the three divine attributes of wisdom, strength and beauty and so here our minds are turned to the wonders of creation and the role of humanity in assisting in the great endeavour of building a place fit for the in-dwelling of God.

Although more light is revealed in this degree, we remain in a certain amount of ignorance with regard to what lies ahead and so we continue to move forward trusting the brethren who conduct and support us, trusting our own sense of the rightness of this, our chosen path; trusting, ultimately, in God, our keeper.

November 3

*Peace be within thy walls, and prosperity within thy palaces.
For my brethren and companions' sakes, I will now say, Peace be
within thee.*

Psalm 122 A Song of degrees of David. The Winding Staircase 3

Our third step is taken in darkness, metaphorically to represent the darkness of the grave and to remind us that, on this earthly plane, even the light we see by is only a feeble reflection of the true Light that comes from within and from above.

On this step we are encouraged to contemplate the mystery of our own mortality, to reflect on eternity and understand more fully the interplay of light and dark, the intertwining of matter and spirit that is at the core of human nature. It is through a full understanding of this that we will, eventually, come to a realisation of what is real and what not; of what is true and what is not and so come to the reality of what we are.

But it also on this step that we learn that there is more. The end of this journey is, if we choose, the beginning of the next. There is more knowledge to be gained, more light to be uncovered. A Master Mason, symbolically at least, gains self-knowledge. The next step is knowledge of the Divine.

November 4

Unto thee lift I up mine eyes, O thou that dwellest in the heavens.

Psalm 123 A Song of degrees.

The Winding Staircase 4

If we follow the idea that our winding staircase is divided into three sections, then the second section begins here, with the first of five steps. These represent the 'five who hold a Lodge' who are the WM, the Wardens and two Fellow-Crafts. The steps also represent the five noble orders of architecture, the first of which is the Tuscan.

This 'order' is only mentioned once in our ritual and no particular symbolism is attached to it, but perhaps, as the oldest and plainest of the pillars we could take it to represent a Freemason at the beginning of the Masonic path: to all external appearances, simple and efficient, strong and upright. It supports the porch or the roof, doing its job without fuss or undue ornament or ostentation. Let us take this to represent the new initiate, who comes to us ready to take that first step on the Masonic path but who comes, at first, only with a desire to learn and to become a better person. This is strength and uprightness of character and the kind of material that will, through the benefit of Masonic knowledge, be refined and beautified on the path to ultimate perfection.

November 5

Our help is in the name of the LORD, who made heaven and earth.

Psalm 124 A Song of degrees of David.

The Winding Staircase 5

The Doric column is also strong and relatively plain. It represents wisdom. The ritual specifies, 'wisdom to contrive' which is significant because it implies that the knowledge of making is not enough. Knowing how to make something is all very well, but wisdom is needed to discern whether a thing is worth making in the first place. It's an interesting idea and one which we, in our world of overconsumption and dwindling resources, might do well to consider. Just because we can make it, does not mean that we should. Wisdom should guide us in all our undertakings and must support knowledge. If we ask ourselves whether a course of action is wise and will be for the common good before we go ahead with it, we might find ourselves walking a happier and less cluttered path.

Wisdom is also represented by King Solomon who chose to build something of great practical and symbolic value, something that, while it may have glorified him to an extent, was built for the greater glory of God. Part of our obligation as Freemasons is to emulate those three 'grand originals' who contribute so much to our mythology and so, in this case, we try to ensure that all that we build is also founded on wise choices.

November 6

They that trust in the LORD shall be as mount Zion, which cannot be removed, but abideth for ever.

Psalm 125 A Song of degrees. The Winding Staircase 6

The Ionic column represents strength. In the ritual, this is particularly framed as ‘strength to support’ and this again, has interesting and subtle implications.

Force alone is not what is required here; strength on its own is no great virtue. But strength in the service of something worthy and good is strength well used. Firstly, the ritual mentions strength in support of and allied with wisdom. Secondly, it talks of an inner strength, the strength required to overcome our own personal difficulties and, again, it is implied that this strength must be founded on wise choices and, of course, on the bedrock of our faith.

Hiram, King of Tyre, is given as the exemplar of this virtue and we can read into this that having strength is not an end in itself, but using strength wisely is the key to success. King Hiram had the resources needed but it was the act of using those resources to assist in the building of the Temple that gave them their true value.

Again, for us to learn this lesson, we must endeavour to use our resources, our influence, our many strengths, for the common good under the guidance of wisdom.

November 7

The LORD hath done great things for us; whereof we are glad.

Psalm 126 A Song of degrees.

The Winding Staircase 7

It is not surprising that the Corinthian pillar, with its ornamentation and slender, fluted column represents beauty. Here we find allusions to the beauty of the outer world and also to the beauty that is found within. Both naturally exist in the world and within each of us but our work as human beings - and therefore as Freemasons - is strongly implied here.

Whatever we make in the world, we should strive for beauty. Beauty is the distinguishing characteristic of creation and if we are to be co-creators of the world, we must aim to emulate it in all our undertakings: in our institutions, our relationships, our buildings, our possessions; everything. Our job is to reflect and manifest the divine and that means, in all things, to reflect and manifest the beauty of the natural world.

Within ourselves, we must learn to uncover the natural beauty of our higher selves through our daily practice of contemplation, an attitude of gratitude and through service to our fellows.

We must remember that the central character and 'hero' of Freemasonry was not the great King, but the humble builder who beautified and adorned the Temple and who chose death over dishonour.

November 8

Except the LORD build the house, they labour in vain that build it:

Psalm 127 A Song of degrees for Solomon.

The Winding Staircase 8

The last step on this middle section of the winding staircase represents the composite column, featuring design elements from Greek and Roman architecture and beautifully and intricately ornamented.

No particular symbolism is attached to this column, so let us return to that new initiate we left on the first of these five steps.

Through treading the Masonic path, through knowledge gained, through learning the lessons that are available on this winding staircase, that new initiate is now a Master Mason, well versed in the teachings of the craft, ornamented by the fruits of wise actions, activated by the strength of purpose that such wisdom brings and beautified by the acquisition of knowledge and understanding.

That Master Mason is - or could be - each one of us, perfected by the study of Masonic knowledge and the constant practice of Masonic virtues to be a source of strength, wisdom and beauty in this world.

Let us strive, in all our undertakings, to be the best we can be; to be the aggregate and sum of all good things and thereby offer support and shelter to the world.

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November 9

Blessed is every one that feareth the LORD; that walketh in his ways.

Psalm 128 A Song of degrees.

The Winding Staircase 9

The final section of the winding staircase consists of seven steps. These are a reminder to us of the seven long years that it took to build the Temple at Jerusalem.

One of the great lessons of Freemasonry is that of patience. Through the initiatory process and through the slow unfolding of our inner selves, we come to learn that spiritual development is something that must be allowed to proceed at its own pace, with past lessons properly assimilated before the next step can be taken.

The seven steps also represent the seven liberal arts and sciences. From the time of classical antiquity, these seven areas of knowledge were considered to be the basis of the education of a person who was truly free, as they allowed active participation in the serious business of democratic governance. The first of the seven is grammar, the study of the form of language. As Freemasons, we comprehend that if we are fully able to understand the power of language and to use it effectively, we will be less able to be manipulated by it. Grammar anchors us in our sense of what is right and allows us to make sense of the world around us.

November 10

The blessing of the LORD be upon you: we bless you in the name of the LORD.

**Psalm 129 A Song of degrees.
The Winding Staircase 10**

Rhetoric is a vital tool in our efforts to make sense of the world around us. Particularly in these times of misinformation, our 'post truth' era, it is important that we can identify a false argument, a faulty logic or a line of reasoning that leads to an erroneous conclusion. To be able to see and understand the workings of speakers and demagogues who would seek to manipulate us is to be free of their manipulation, whether they are religious leaders, politicians or salespeople.

And to have the tools of rhetoric at our command as we tell people of the truth of Brotherhood, also puts us in a position of power and, thus also of responsibility.

Rhetoric gives us the ability to move others and if we are to accept and use that power, we must also accept the responsibility to use it only to promote that which is positive, selfless and true.

November 11

Lord, hear my voice: let thine ears be attentive to the voice of my supplications.

If thou, LORD, shouldest mark iniquities, O Lord, who shall stand?

Psalm 130 A Song of degrees.

The Winding Staircase 11

Logic is the last of the language-based arts and it is, in many ways, the key and the mortar for the other two. Here, again, we are led to the knowledge we need to make sense of this confusing and contentious world. If an understanding of rhetoric helps us to overcome the emotional power that language can hold over us, then an understanding of logic helps us to bore down into the bones of any argument or proposition to see that it holds together.

One of the clearest lines of logical argument in regards to Freemasonry begins from the (arguably illogical) proposition that, since God exists, we must all be His children - therefore we are all brothers and sisters. It couldn't be simpler or clearer and anyone who fails to live in the light of this truth and who treats his fellow creatures as anything less than that, has a long way to go on the path to perfection.

November 12

LORD, my heart is not haughty, nor mine eyes lofty: neither do I exercise myself in great matters, or in things too high for me.

Psalm 131 A Song of degrees of David. The Winding Staircase 12

The clarity of language sought in the study of logic leads seamlessly into the study of arithmetic. The manipulation of number, the ability to calculate, to estimate and to measure with great precision - all of these have obvious resonances in the workings of operative Masons.

But we, too, have arithmetical references within our symbolic rituals. Look, for example at the 24-inch gauge which calls on us to number, measure, and divide our days wisely for our own benefit, for the good of our connections and for the betterment of the world at large.

The very imagery of this winding staircase; the repeated pattern of 3-5-7; the two pillars; the three pillars; the five pillars; the twelve fellow-crafts who were once fifteen; the three who rule; the five who hold; the seven who make perfect: the list of numerical references is long and it is for us, in our times of meditation and contemplation, to consider the power and influence and significance of these numbers in our lives.

November 13

*I will not give sleep to mine eyes, or slumber to mine eyelids,
Until I find out a place for the LORD, an habitation for the mighty God
of Jacob.*

Psalm 132 A Song of degrees. The Winding Staircase 13

Being the study of shape and form, geometry has clear and obvious interest for Masons. For the operative masons, an understanding of geometry was vital in the building of a structure that was both functional (in so far as it didn't fall down) and also beautiful.

For the speculative Mason, the study of the outer forms of the world leads, if we allow it to, to the consideration and contemplation of its inner form and workings and it is here that we begin to be aware of the echoes of the truth we seek.

Consider the compass: a simple instrument and yet with it we can measure and draw in proportion; we can divide and subdivide even straight lines and we can create complicated, beautiful designs. It is no wonder that we are enjoined to apply its lessons to our lives.

November 14

Behold, how good and how pleasant it is for brethren to dwell together in unity!

**Psalm 133 A Song of degrees of David.
The Winding Staircase 14**

Psalm 133 is loved by Freemasons around the world as it speaks specifically about the joys of brotherhood. Indeed, it is read as part of the opening ceremony in many Lodges and the VSL is opened to that page throughout certain ceremonies, particularly initiations. Here it represents music and with it we take the simple logic of arithmetic and the regular forms of geometry and we apply them to an art that begins to lead us into ethereal planes of beauty and spirituality.

Music is the order of the universe made audible and at its best it has the ability to transport us beyond ourselves, into realms where we begin to sense the presence and power of that Being who is greater than ourselves. We begin to sense a great peace, an overwhelming sense of oneness. We begin, if we are open to it, to touch the numinous.

And, of course, it is under the influence of this art that we may feel a strong sense of brotherhood. As Freemasons, many of us sing together at the opening and closing of our Lodges and even in this simple act, we manifest our togetherness and bring the Divine a little closer to the earth.

November 15

The LORD that made heaven and earth bless thee out of Zion.

Psalm 134 A Song of degrees.

The Winding Staircase 15

Finally we arrive at the summit of the winding staircase and it is here that we are enabled to discover the sacred symbol which represents and reminds us of God, the Grand Geometrician of the Universe.

Perhaps it is no coincidence that, as we arrive at the summit, we are called upon to look upward and outward into the very depths of the created universe. Astronomy, the study of the heavens, uses all those liberal arts and sciences previously mentioned to attempt to make sense of the universe, to explain its origin and its evolution.

And so it is that Freemasons, gazing up in wonder and rapture at the night sky, are drawn once more to remember their faith. and their belief that within this vast cosmos there is order and connection; that at the heart of everything there is something that holds this all together; something whose very nature is love.

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November 16

The earth constantly revolving on its axis in its orbit round the sun, and Freemasonry being universally spread over its surface, it necessarily follows that the sun must always be at its meridian with regard to Freemasonry.

Second Degree Ceremony

This is a piece of ritual spoken by every Freemason who has passed through the second degree ceremony. There are two beautiful images here. First of all, the idea that all Masonic ceremonies, contrary to all physical evidence, take place at high noon is symbolic of the fact that Freemasonry is considered always to stand in the Light, with all that symbolises in terms of knowledge, openness and goodness. The second, somewhat inversely, is the fact, inherent in the explanation, that there really are Masonic lodges all over the globe. In many languages, for people of so many creeds, Freemasonry offers a common ground of fellowship and union that transcends even the natural affinity we feel for all that we consider our own. To be part of something so universal is humbling indeed and should serve to help us keep our lives in perspective.

November 17

This knowledge is the king of education, the most secret of all secrets. It is the purest knowledge, and because it gives direct perception of the self by realization, it is the perfection of religion.

Bhagavad Gita 9:2

Freemasonry is a lot of fun. In fact, many Masons will tell you that they are only in it for the fun they have. Even promotional literature from Grand Lodge aimed at recruiting new members suggests that Freemasonry is worth joining because it is fun. But ‘fun’ is not at the core of what we are. Ultimately, we are on a quest for the deepest and most profound knowledge to which human beings can aspire: the knowledge of ourselves. We do have fun along the way and much of the enjoyment we find is a reflection of the fact that we are treading a ‘true’ path which brings joy to the human spirit, as well as the fact that we tread the path with like-minded Companions. Let us determine to make the effort to look beyond the surface attractions of Freemasonry to find its hidden core of knowledge and truth.

November 18

Men have been imprisoned, tortured and burnt at the stake for defending its teachings.

Bible Presentation

Most of us who hear these words live in societies where Freemasonry is able to exist legally and openly and it is no coincidence that these are usually countries that uphold the democratic freedoms. Not all Freemasons are so lucky, however, and it is important that we remember not only their plight, but also the plight of all people whose lives are circumscribed by oppression. Remember, in all ages Freemasonry has been the enemy of every tyranny of religion or politics for the simple reason that it operates on the principle that all people are equal in God's sight. Freemasonry upholds human dignity and strives to create a climate where these basic freedoms can thrive. Such freedoms are very precious. They provide the nutrients for the soil in which the seed of a person's soul can grow and develop. Let us aim to be proud of such a heritage. Let us commit ourselves to strive to be worthy of it.

November 19

All good moral philosophy is but an handmaid to religion.

Francis Bacon

There is so much about Freemasonry that is positive and good. Look how it encourages us to be better people and to see our fellow human beings as brothers and sisters. Look at the charitable work that we do; look how we encourage fellow feeling, how we encourage learning and contemplation and the sense of community. There is so much of which we can be proud and there is so much that we can show to the world and say, 'Look, this is what we are.'

But to just look at this and to think that this is all we are is to miss the point. All of these things are true but they are only given validity and depth by the fact that we have as our central tenet, our most important Landmark, the belief in God. Without this belief we are just another social and charitable organisation – not that there is anything wrong with being 'just' that – but we are much deeper. Our moral philosophy is underpinned by true religion: love of God and of our neighbour.

November 20

...but let me assure you that, in these vows, there is nothing incompatible with your civil, moral or religious duties.

First Degree Ceremony

Everything about Freemasonry is designed, not to undermine our sense of social responsibility, but to enhance it, making us ‘respectable in life and useful to society.’

The obligations we take are serious and solemn ones but they neither cut us off from society as a whole, nor do they deprive us of our individual freedom. Rather, they stand for us as a commitment to throw in our lot with that of the Order and like any such obligations, such as marriage vows or those for joining a religious order, they provide a bedrock, a foundation, on which we may build the structure of our future selves.

By accepting the constraints of those obligations, we ourselves set the bounds of our daily lives, willingly stepping out on a path that may be narrow, steep and sometimes rocky but which eventually will lead us to our true selves and, beyond, to God.

November 21

If a man be gracious and courteous to strangers, it shows he is a citizen of the world.

Francis Bacon

To be kind to all is the mark of a person who feels comfortable with their own humanity and who is secure in the knowledge that they are no better or worse than anyone else in the world, however seemingly different their background or position, their education, religion or culture. We understand what it means to consider ourselves 'on the level' with each other within the confines of Freemasonry, but to understand that we are on the level with all of humanity is a further step towards a fuller appreciation of our place and role in the world. As Freemasons, this should be how the world sees us and how we should interact with the world: with grace and courtesy, so that all the world will know that to be a Freemason is to be gentle and thoughtful, selfless and caring, a true citizen of the world.

November 22

He has achieved success who has lived well, laughed often, and loved much...who has left the world better than he found it...who has always looked for the best in others and given the best he had; whose life was an inspiration, whose memory a benediction.

Anon

It is easy to get caught up in the trials and tribulations of daily life but it is important that we try always to keep a proper sense of perspective. One of the greatest lessons that Freemasonry teaches is that it encourages us to realise that, while our earthly existence is important, it is short and that, beyond this life, the possibility of a greater, more 'real' life awaits.

To consider our cares, our connections, our hopes, our aspirations and our accomplishments from a perspective beyond this life, to wonder what, really, has been the value of our sojourn on Earth in the face of our certain death, is the mark of wisdom and understanding. All material connections and considerations are, ultimately, temporary and therefore, in a sense, unreal. All that will be left of us will be a memory, so let us determine to ensure that we each live a life that will be an inspiration and a blessing to those who come after us. There is no greater legacy.

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November 23

Then Zerubbabel the son of Shealtiel, and Joshua the son of Josedech, the high priest, with all the remnant of the people, obeyed the voice of the Lord their God, and the words of Haggai the prophet, as the Lord their God had sent him, and the people did fear before the Lord. '

Haggai 1:12

To say that the Royal Arch asks us to consider our relationship with God in greater depth is undoubtedly true, but it also asks us to listen more closely to our inner selves and to align ourselves more closely with our own soul. Acting from this deep core of knowing and feeling and intuition, from this deep sense of rightness, cannot help but make our lives, and the lives of those around us, happier and more full of light. But if we hear this voice, or feel this intuition, and then ignore it, it is worse than not hearing it in the first place because we bend ourselves out of shape, doing what does not feel right and what does not accord with our innermost selves. Zerubbabel and Joshua would not ignore the word of God. Nor must we.

November 24

The Sacred Writings are to rule and govern our faith, the square to regulate our actions and the compasses to keep us within due bounds with our Brethren in Freemasonry, as with all mankind.

First Degree Ceremony

Faith in God, right conduct and a true understanding of the kinship of humanity may be said to be the three attributes of a good and virtuous person. All three of them are encompassed by the teachings of Freemasonry and from this fact we are able to understand that Freemasonry offers a complete system of living to those who follow its precepts. The symbolism inherent in the Craft, in its three 'great lights', are all that we need to make progress on the path to perfection that we humbly tread.

But the fact that the teachings of Freemasonry are 'veiled in allegory and illustrated by symbols' means that we must be prepared to investigate this symbolism in its entirety, not just be content with a shallow and surface understanding. Anything worthwhile needs working at and this is certainly true of Freemasonry. The whole of Masonic ritual is steeped in meaning and any one piece of symbolism or teaching has many levels. Nothing is random or accidental. Remember this as you try to make '...a daily advancement in Masonic knowledge.'

November 25

God help all poor souls lost in the dark.

Robert Browning

We enter the world from the darkness of the womb; we enter Freemasonry hoodwinked and in the dark. At our Raising we face the darkness of death and are told that even the light by which we see the world is but 'darkness visible.' Metaphorically, darkness symbolises ignorance and we accept that for much of our lives we grope blindly, not knowing who or what we are. In the Royal Arch we finally face the darkness that surrounds us and we descend knowingly and willingly into the vault. We are rewarded by the discovery of the light of God's word and we then bring this light back into the world. As we share our discovery, we come slowly to understand that we are all 'poor souls lost in the dark' and that God is our only help.

Let us determine to remember the source of light in our lives and, more importantly, to share that understanding and so help to bring illumination and enlightenment to all.

November 26

...now comes of his own free will and accord, humbly soliciting to be admitted to the mysteries and privileges of ancient Freemasonry.

First Degree Ceremony

There are many reasons why Masonry is described as ‘free’ and, because of the multi-layered nature of the Masonic system, they are all true and all teach an important lesson. One of the explanations we are given early on is that it is ‘free’ because ‘...it requires a perfect freedom of inclination in every candidate for its mysteries.’ This is a very important concept because it contains within itself the understanding that there are many paths that lead humanity to the throne of God and that different people approach that throne in different ways. No one path will suit everyone and this is certainly true in the case of Freemasonry.

Although we know that its teachings remain relevant to today’s world, we must acknowledge that many of the outer forms and customs of Freemasonry are old-fashioned. Therefore, Freemasonry appeals to many for whom formality of language and action are attractive while others may see it as rather archaic. This is one of the reasons why we have generally been discouraged from soliciting members: because we understand that the path a person treads is a matter best left between them and their God.

November 27

*Through such souls alone
God stooping shows sufficient of His light
For us i' the dark to rise by. And I rise.*

Robert Browning

The six-pointed star in Freemasonry hints at our understanding that, as we reach up to God, so God comes down to meet us and lift us higher. All over the world, in every culture and religious tradition there are stories told of those who have given their lives to help illumine the way for others. When we recognise the help that is thus offered, it would be foolish to refuse, especially now that we have made a commitment to raise ourselves up in this way. But having taken a few faltering steps along the path, we must be aware that while there are those ahead, helping us, there are also those behind whom we could help. And, though we might not feel qualified to do so, we must understand that we, too, through the understanding that Freemasonry has inculcated within us, may be able to show some of God's light for others to rise by.

November 28

...contemplate on your destiny, and guide your reflections to that most interesting of all human studies, the knowledge of yourself.

Third Degree Ceremony

There are so many important lessons wrapped up in the symbolism of the Third Degree that to understand them all would be a lifetime's work in itself. Serious contemplation of our destiny inevitably leads us, with the rest of humanity as our companions, to the brink of the grave. We must then consider what may lie beyond that grave and so it is that the apprehension of our mortality sets us on the rungs of Jacob's ladder: to our faith, our hope that our journey beyond this life will lead us to God and to our understanding that we share these hopes (and their attendant fears) with all humanity, which is the beginning of true charity.

We are taught in Freemasonry that to strive to overcome our baser instincts and sail the boat of this life over the rough seas of passion with equanimity and rectitude is the highest degree of perfection to which a human being can aspire. True self-knowledge is undoubtedly the beginning of wisdom and if we are indeed, in some mystical fashion, made in God's image, understanding ourselves is the first required step to knowing God.

November 29

*Courage, brother! Do not stumble,
Though thy path is dark as night;
There's a star to guide the humble:
'Trust in God, and do the Right.*

Norman Macleod

As Freemasons – and especially as Royal Arch Companions – we need not fear the dark. If we allow it to, our Order provides us with all the tools we need to walk this life without fear of any kind, confident that we are supported every step of the way. It's not that we never stumble: we do, and sometimes we fall. It's not that there isn't darkness in our lives: of course there is, and sometimes it feels as if it's more than we can bear. But if we remember to raise our eyes, that guiding star is always there for us, constant and unchanging, lighting our way and guiding our feet towards what we know, deep down, is truth and freedom and peace.

November 30

Your trust being in God, your faith is well founded. Relying on such sure support, you may safely rise and accompany your conductor with a firm but humble confidence, for where the name of God is invoked we trust no danger can ensue.

First Degree Ceremony

Having entered the Lodge for the first time and having knelt for prayer, these words are spoken to us before we rise and the ceremony begins in earnest. Obviously, they are spoken to reassure us that we need have no immediate fear about what is to befall us but they have a wider meaning too. They remind us, firstly, that whatever we have got ourselves into with regard to Freemasonry, whoever we associate with in the Craft or outside, ultimately our relationship with God is ours alone and nobody can interfere in it unless we let them. Secondly, the simple faith expressed in the statement is a beautiful and important lesson for us in the whole of our lives, not just within the confines of Freemasonry.

So 'firm but humble confidence' is not just the attitude we should adopt in the Lodge; it is not a ritualistic formulation but a true and practical reminder of how we should tread that greater path which is our life on Earth.

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December 1

Praise ye the LORD. Praise ye the name of the LORD; praise him, O ye servants of the LORD.

Praise the LORD; for the LORD is good: sing praises unto his name; for it is pleasant.

Psalm 135

These days we recognise that the idea that different people serve different gods is a belief that can only be harboured by people who have a very limited idea of what God may be. Freemasons, having been ‘accused’ for many years of worshipping a ‘Masonic god’ should see only too clearly that the very idea is laughable.

The first step to wisdom is the simple understanding that there is only one God and that the notions of different cultures as to what that one God is, reflects on them, not Him, and has nothing to do with the actual reality and truth of the matter.

The Upanishads, sacred Hindu writings, express it thus: “Truth is one, the wise call it by many names...” or, put another way, “The real God is one, the enlightened ones, speak of Him in several ways...”

Many Freemasons are devoutly religious, while many others follow paths that are more individual and often more esoteric, perhaps, than traditional religious practices, but all of us, if we are to promote peace and harmony in this world, must learn to abide by this fundamental truth: we all worship the same God.

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December 2

*...yet from those flames
No light, but rather darkness visible
Serv'd only to discover sights of woe...*

John Milton

As Freemasons, we have a hope that there exists a greater life beyond this one and that within our mortal frame there resides a spark of the Divine. At our exaltation into the Royal Arch, we descended into the darkness of the vault and found there the Great Light of God's word. Is it not possible, then, that this idea of 'darkness visible' is simply a reflection of the fact that the 'lesser lights' of the sun and moon are physical and temporary? Therefore, it follows that when taken with eternity in view, the light they shine is only physical and temporary and illumines only the outer form of things: the material world. On the other hand, the great, emblematical Light of the Volume of the Sacred Law illumines deeper, inner truths. In the East there is a tradition that suggests that this world is an illusion, but this does not mean that it is false, only that it is temporary and therefore unreal. What is real is eternal and it is this that is illuminated by the spiritual light of God's word

December 3

To him that made great lights... The sun to rule by day... The moon and stars to rule by night:

Psalm 136

There is a lot of talk in Freemasonry about light and, of course, our ritual speaks of the greater and lesser lights which serve to guide our footsteps and our minds along the path to perfection.

Masonic artefacts and symbols are also sometimes referred to as 'light' and so it is important to distinguish between symbolical and actual light. Masonic symbols, however powerful, are only symbols and it is not until we imbue them with meaning that they actually have any. A Masonic ring is just a ring, but when it becomes a daily and constant reminder to us of our Masonic ideals, then it begins to have some power for us.

It is important to remember that it is not our artefacts and symbols that are sources of light, it is us; our actions, our words, our very lives.

December 4

Freemasonry is no longer an exclusive and withdrawn body, doing good by stealth or concerned only for its own. Its principles are blazoned for all men to behold; if now we fail to match fair professions with worthy deeds the fraternity will be brought into contempt and will deserve the condemnation of mankind.

Anon

It was not very many years ago that it was decided that Freemasonry should try to be more open about its principles and philosophy. Such a brave decision was absolutely necessary and yet it is fraught with danger. It was necessary, partly because of the negative attention that Freemasonry was once again attracting, but mostly because we had arrived at a crossroads. Either Freemasonry was to become a meaningful force for good in the world, a beacon of light in the gathering darkness of materialism, or it was to drift slowly but irrevocably into a fusty irrelevance, to become a quaint but essentially useless relic of a bygone age. Happily, we chose the former, but the great danger is that the reputation of the Order now lies squarely and wholly on the shoulders of each individual Freemason. The Order can no longer rely on its glorious past to sustain it, it must rely on us. Let us try to do honour to that trust.

December 5

By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down, yea, we wept, when we remembered Zion.

How shall we sing the LORD'S song in a strange land?

Psalm 137

As Freemasons, we are reminded in our ritual that we should all think of ourselves as kin to Hiram, who was a widow's son. As such, we are encouraged to look with kindness on those who suffer in this world and, vicariously at least, we share in and thus empathise with their suffering.

But we would also do well to think of ourselves as exiles. A human life is a great blessing but it involves, by definition, a separation from our source and from the centre of our being. Sometimes we feel the pain of this in the futility of earthly desires and the amassing of material wealth; in the following of dreams that, deep down, we know will end in dust.

In our moments of silence, in the depths of our meditations, we know what it is to be far from home; strangers in a strange land.

And knowing it, we are able to be more understanding and more compassionate to those others who are exiles from their homes too, whether those homes are of this world or the next.

December 6

*Deep into that darkness peering, long I stood there wondering,
fearing...*

Edgar Allan Poe

Doubt and questioning are part of what makes us human. To ask questions is, ultimately, what leads us to find answers. To put our philosophy and our beliefs to the test, constantly and rigorously, is important if we are to learn to trust their strength and usefulness. We often wonder what our next step in life will bring us to; we fear the unknown and waver on that cliff-top of uncertainty. This is natural and understandable, but if we do not take the next step – that leap of faith – we will not grow. The caterpillar that does not spin the dark cocoon around itself will never become a butterfly. The seed that does not crack and split will never be a tree. It is not in our nature to stand still and atrophy. We are living, growing creatures reaching up towards the emblematical light that is God. Pause if you must; recognise your doubt and fear, embrace them, own them. And then, if you want to be all that you could be, leap.

December 7

Though the LORD be high, yet hath he respect unto the lowly: but the proud he knoweth afar off.

Psalm 138

Although we meet on the level, it is important that we are mindful of those who may be struggling to maintain their obligations to the Craft. Being a Freemason costs money and, while for many those costs may be minimal, others may have to make sacrifices to prioritise this important aspect of their lives. We pay dues and dining fees, we purchase regalia and we are called upon to give to charity. We must be careful not to assume that all Freemasons do these things with equal ease.

On the other hand, we make no judgments about a brother's financial position and certainly do not treat any brother differently however apparently high or low their worldly situation.

The story of the affiliation of the Duke of York (later to become King George VI) into Glamis Lodge 99 S.C. at the hands of the local postman is a famous one and is a salutary reminder that Freemasonry judges by standards that are different from the standards of the outer world. We value a good heart and the actions that spring therefrom. These are the excellences of character of which we should be proud and which we should determine to maintain.

December 8

We hope to arrive at the summit by the assistance of a ladder, called in Scripture, Jacob's Ladder.

First Degree Ceremony

In the lecture on the Tracing Board in this Degree, we are taught that the summit of Freemasonry is reached by the Mason who possesses the virtue of charity 'in its most exalted sense.' Charity has several meanings relating to the giving of alms but can also be defined as love of humankind. This, it would seem, is its most exalted sense and so we can begin to understand, even as we first set our feet upon the Masonic path, that our greatest aspiration must be to develop love for our fellow creatures. This love, known to Christians as agape, is founded on the understanding that we are all children of one God. The giving of alms, for which Freemasonry is rightly well known, is, at its best, a physical manifestation of this love.

The Tracing Board teaches us clearly that the path to realisation of brotherly love is through the study of Spiritual teachings and the development and strengthening of all of those three great virtues: Faith, Hope and Love.

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December 9

Search me, O God, and know my heart: try me, and know my thoughts:
Psalm 139

As Freemasons, we declare ourselves to be willing to undergo ‘strict trials’ and to be constantly tested against ‘...the square of God’s word and the compasses of our own self-convincing conscience...’ The declaration is made within the context of our rituals, but, as ever, there is great significance and import for our lives outside of the Lodge.

The simple truth is that, if we are truly willing to be tested in terms of our fidelity to Masonic teachings, we must always be prepared. We can never know when our principles will be put to the test; it can be in the most mundane of circumstances. To stay patient when anger and frustration may feel more natural and certainly easier; to be generous and open-hearted when we could turn away in coldness; to speak our truth humbly, but with courage and conviction when to remain silent is to allow evil to triumph.

It may be more convenient to believe that our trials will come, loudly heralded by angels and be conducted by the Almighty Himself, enthroned in glory, but the truth is that our hearts are weighed daily, quietly, in all our deeds and all interactions with our fellow creatures.

December 10

This is none other but the house of God, and this is the gate of Heaven.

Genesis 28:16

In a Royal Arch Chapter as much as in a Freemason's Lodge, the symbolism of the ladder that Jacob dreamed of is a key to our understanding of how we, as Masons, wish to live. Remember, the ladder rests on the truth of God's word; its rungs represent all the moral virtues, but most especially Faith, Hope and Love or Charity, and the Mason who fully manifests these virtues in life is deemed to have achieved the summit of Freemasonry which is, 'figuratively speaking, an ethereal mansion, not made with hands, eternal in the heavens.'

Just as Jacob awoke from his dream and realised that he had had a true vision, so must we remember the truth of our understanding that, even for us, the lessons of Jacob's ladder offer us a vision of the house of God and a key to the gate of Heaven.

December 11

Deliver me, O LORD, from the evil man: preserve me from the violent man;

Which imagine mischiefs in their heart; continually are they gathered together for war.

Psalm 140

There will always be those who will resist our best efforts at making peace and promoting brotherly love. However attractive we think those things are, there are people who are simply not ready and not able to let go of the fear that causes them to see themselves as islands, under threat from everything beyond their own shores.

It would be easy to lose patience with people who cannot see what is best for themselves and for the world at large, but we must learn to have compassion for them, to see and acknowledge their wounds and to trust that, when they are ready, they will be able to open their hearts and minds to the idea that we are all related on a deep and fundamental level and that one person's pain hurts us all.

And, as always, we must be confident enough and secure enough in our own faith to trust that all is well and all will be well.

December 12

If one advances confidently in the direction of his dreams, and endeavours to live the life which he has imagined, he will meet with a success unexpected in common hours...If you have built castles in the air, your work need not be lost; that is where they should be. Now put the foundations under them.

Henry David Thoreau

So much of what we aspire to in Freemasonry seems like an impossible dream. For ourselves we aim to live faultless lives of piety and beneficence although we so easily and often fail to attain it. For humanity we dream of a world of freedom and fairness where brotherly love prevails, yet all around us are poverty, strife and war. We must believe that our dreams are not a waste of time. They are, rather, the ideal that inspires us to keep moving onwards to strive for more, for ourselves and for the world at large. They are the light shining out in the darkness to guide us home.

But the dreams alone are not enough. First come the vision and the inspiration but until we act to bring those dreams to fruition, they will remain out of reach, just 'castles in the air.' Freemasons are builders, although not in stone, but we are dreamers too and we build upwards, to the summit of our dreams, to the very throne of God.

December 13

Set a watch, O LORD, before my mouth; keep the door of my lips.

Psalm 141

The Tyler occupies a key position in Masonic ritual and symbolism. On the practical level, it is the Tyler who guards the door of the Lodge, who oversees the preparation of candidates and the admission of visitors or late-comers.

On a deeper level, we can understand that the Tyler represents that part of us which watches over our actions and our thoughts. The Tyler is our innermost self. Beyond the body and beyond the chattering mind, our true selves watch and wait, silent and unmoved except by love.

But the Tyler also represents our interactions with the world. We are enjoined to guard our tongues from speaking evil, to guard our actions from doing wrong and to guard our thoughts lest they lead us astray. All of these are the work of our inner Tyler and we would do well to contemplate and meditate upon that true self which lies beyond all human and material cares.

December 14

Fiat lux. (Let there be light.)

Genesis 1:3

The idea of light as a symbol of all that is good is one that can be found in every part of the globe. It is a concept that has been with us since the earliest periods of time, from the very dawn of human consciousness. It is something that is hard-wired into us on a primal level. For Freemasons, too, the symbolism of light is key. In our Lodges, heaven itself is represented by stars, God's works by the sun and moon; we talk of great and lesser lights and, in the third degree, we welcome the return of the 'bright morning star.' In the Chapter we acknowledge the source of that light, both emblematical and physical, and begin to look beyond its physical manifestations and into the light of spirit that illumines our inner world. The catenarian arch, that symbol of strength and perfection, has inscribed on it the words, 'Fiat lux' and it is only by trusting that light that we are able to break into the darkness to find the wellspring of truth.

December 15

I looked on my right hand, and beheld, but there was no man that would know me: refuge failed me; no man cared for my soul.

Psalm 142

We are, by nature, social creatures, designed to live peacefully in family groups and communities of mutual support. Although we all need time alone, our connections with friends and loved ones are what bring us joy and give our lives meaning. As kin to the widow's son, however, Freemasons also understand loss and isolation and know that these can lead to a sense of abandonment and to depression.

How lucky we are to have found Freemasonry; to have the opportunity to surround ourselves with a network of mutual support and to know that, if we ask, we will always find a hand outstretched to help us.

But asking for help in our societies is not always encouraged. Many of us have grown up in cultures where the need for assistance is seen as, somehow, a sign of weakness. A society that puts economic growth before personal and communal well-being is one that encourages individuality and separation rather than co-operation, connection and mutual support. Freemasonry has the power to be the yeast in the dough of such societies, quietly promoting the idea that, together, we are all stronger and happier.

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December 16

The first condition of admission into, and membership of, the Order is a belief in the Supreme Being. This is essential and admits of no compromise.

Aims and Relationships of the Craft

As with all paths that lead to Spiritual insight, Freemasonry has had to adapt and change in certain ways to remain relevant and credible in society. The abandoning of the traditional penalties once associated with the Masonic obligations is an example. But, as with all other paths, there are certain basic principles which cannot be altered without changing the very nature of the system. In Freemasonry we refer to these as 'Landmarks' and they constitute the very heart and soul of our Craft. The first such landmark, and undoubtedly pre-eminent, is belief in God, whatever we conceive God to be. This is the sure and solid foundation of Freemasonry, for, when all else is stripped away, this one thing can stand alone: that we believe. In many ways it could be argued that this is not the first but, perhaps, the only 'condition of admission' that really matters.

December 17

Hear my prayer, O LORD, give ear to my supplications: in thy faithfulness answer me, and in thy righteousness.

Psalm 143

None of us can really claim to be more worthy than another. Perhaps in this material world, with its inverted value systems, it is possible for one person to look down on or up to another, but in Freemasonry we see differently and we judge our own and another's worth by different criteria.

It may seem contradictory at first: we place such great store by our sense that we must act well in this world if we are to do justice to the institution of which we are members, but we also know that our intrinsic value and worth come from our being, not our doing. Here we do not mean our being as the world reckons it, but our being in a spiritual sense, as sparks of the Divine, as children of the Most High.

We strive to attain perfection in our earthly lives and to act as well as we can, not because we hope for a reward in the next life, but because we understand that perfection is our true nature and that the more we can bring our earthly selves into line with that spiritual ideal, the happier, more fulfilled and more peaceful we will be.

December 18

I AM THAT I AM

Exodus 3:14

It is a real irony that the one thing that all Freemasons must agree on is also one of the things that we do not discuss at our meetings. We acknowledge the Supreme Being, we even offer up prayers and hymns, but the one thing we do not do is discuss the nature of our understanding of what God is. Freemasonry's great strength is its breadth, the fact that people from all religions and cultures are welcomed under its banner. For this to happen, though, we must be very careful to avoid anything that could cause division amongst us and one of those things could easily be disagreements about the nature of God. Therefore, Freemasonry leaves us the freedom to conceive of God according to our own nature, religion, culture or inclination, secure in the firm faith that God does exist and that, whatever we imagine that Divine nature to be, it is eternal and unchanging.

December 19

LORD, what is man, that thou takest knowledge of him! or the son of man, that thou makest account of him!

Man is like to vanity: his days are as a shadow that passeth away.

Psalm 144

Our lives are very short and yet we spend most of them acting as if the one certain ending will not happen to us! Freemasons are led, through ritual, to contemplate their own mortality and this is the most important lesson we can assimilate: that one day - and it could be any day - we will die. And knowing that, being acquainted with our own death, we can begin to truly live.

In death's shadow, life is beautiful and rich. Our family and friends are so precious; every day is a gift more valuable than silver and gold; every breath is an affirmation of a life lived to the full, in gratitude and thanksgiving.

So what do we do with this short life? What will we leave behind when we go? Who will speak for us when we are no longer here? There are so many questions but there is essentially, only one simple answer. Love. To give and receive love while we are here; to leave a legacy of love, to be spoken of and remembered with love - these are the signs of a life well and truly lived.

December 20

...to look beyond the narrow limits of particular institutions, whether civil or religious, and to view in every son of Adam a brother of the dust.

Third Degree Ceremony

Whatever our own private beliefs, religious or political, as Freemasons we are more concerned with actions than with protestations of faith. All Freemasons believe in God; that is the primary condition of membership, but we do not concern ourselves with the details of that belief because we choose to adopt the very widest, most inclusive definition of human kinship as our yardstick. We do recognise that there are differences between people and we understand that different religions and political philosophies seem, at times, hard to reconcile. We could dwell on these differences but that would bring us down to the level of partisanship and one of the greatest messages that Freemasonry teaches is that it is possible to rise above the things that appear to divide us and operate from a higher perspective. Thus we see every man and woman as Brother and Sister and, irrespective of differences between us, we act from the firm conviction that this is so.

December 21

I will extol thee, my God, O king; and I will bless thy name for ever and ever.

My mouth shall speak the praise of the LORD: and let all flesh bless his holy name for ever and ever.

Psalm 145

If they are religious at all, Freemasons tend to be the kinds of people who would rather live their religion than talk about it. And so, if we are to ‘...speak the praise of the Lord...’ in all the moments of our lives, how are we to do it?

Not all communication involves speech, of course, and we can express our faith, our joy, our compassion and our gratitude through the actions we perform and the lives we touch as we go about our daily business. Like teaching, healing and love are imparted through how we are with others, the quality of attention we give them and the way we make them feel through that genuine attention.

It is possible to make our whole life an act of praise and devotion if we simply live out our basic tenet, that we are all brothers and sisters in God.

December 22

Be strong and of good courage; be not afraid, neither be thou dismayed: for the Lord thy God is with thee...

Joshua 1:9

We do not come to Freemasonry to find faith. To enter Freemasonry we must already have faith and be willing to acknowledge openly our belief in a Supreme Being. Freemasonry may help to deepen our faith and to render it more secure although, strictly speaking, these things come more within the scope of our chosen religious paths. Freemasonry is more about the practical application of our faith, about how we use it to make the world a better place for ourselves, our connections and beyond. Being secure in this faith, and motivated by the highest of ideals, we are able to tread the paths of life with strength and courage, undismayed by setbacks and failures because, deep down, we know that God is with and within all of us.

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December 23

Put not your trust in princes, nor in the son of man, in whom there is no help.

His breath goeth forth, he returneth to his earth; in that very day his thoughts perish.

Psalm 146

Eastern religions such as Hinduism and Buddhism share the concept that this world is considered to be unreal. This is not because it does not actually exist - it clearly does - but because it is recognised that everything in it is temporary and will undoubtedly change and then pass away in time. Only the eternal is considered to be real, because what is real is always real: it does not change and disappear.

Freemasons live in what we, ironically, call the real world: we work hard, we marry, we raise children, we pay the bills and the mortgage and we do our best to share our understanding of love and brotherhood while we do it. And at the same time, we know that this 'real' world is ultimately unreal and that, at the end of our earthly existence, we believe there is more, something closer to reality, free of the ever-changing cycle of birth and death.

Therefore, to put our trust in worldly security is fine, as far as it goes, but we know and we understand that there is a higher authority and an existence that is of the spirit, bright and true and eternal.

December 24

Freemasonry not only inculcates the principles of love and benevolence, it seeks to give them an actual and living presence in all the occupations and intercourse of life. It not only feels, it acts! It not only pities human suffering, it relieves it!

Anon

Every lesson that Freemasonry teaches is of practical use in our everyday lives. Although the method of teaching may seem strange to some and, at best, out-dated to others, the fact remains that within our rituals and ceremonies there is to be found the key to living a good and useful life. We do not expect fame and fortune as the world sees it, nor is that something we would particularly value. Our aspiration is to live quietly, humbly, happily, in accord with family, friends and connections; to pursue our careers and jobs with satisfaction, giving our best, and all the time mindful of what is real and what is only temporary. In the second degree ceremony we are encouraged to ‘...keep eternity in view’ and we are encouraged to contemplate our own mortality. Thus our values are, we hope, attuned to the eternal and we act here on Earth in such a way that our beliefs in ‘...the principles of love and benevolence’ are demonstrated in all aspects of our daily lives.

December 25

Praise ye the LORD: for it is good to sing praises unto our God; for it is pleasant; and praise is comely.

Sing unto the LORD with thanksgiving; sing praise upon the harp unto our God:

Psalm 147

Music is not something that is necessarily associated with Freemasonry and yet, of course, there have been many musicians who have been members of the Craft. From Mozart to Fats Waller, the list is long and sometimes surprising.

What is not surprising is the importance that Freemasonry places on Music. One of the offices of a Lodge is Organist and the playing of music through the ceremonies as well the hearty singing of opening and closing odes is both encouraged and enjoyed. At the festive board, too, there may be singing: the Entered Apprentice's or the Master's Song, for example.

Those who formulated our rites knew very well that music and communal singing in particular is a quick and immediate way of, literally, harmonising a group of people. So if your Lodge begins proceedings with a song, meditate on how it brings you and your brethren into tune with each other, the better to accomplish your Masonic labour.

December 26

Thou shalt love thy neighbour as thyself.

Matthew 22:39

Freemasonry encourages us to see all of humanity as one family under God. It shows us our interconnectedness, our inter-reliance, the bonds of love, care and respect that unite us. We cannot fail to notice the repeated references in our rituals to the fact that the 'rays of heaven' shine on all. Therefore, we must, of necessity, begin to develop the sense of humility that is a sign of our understanding that we are part of everything that is base about human nature as well as part of its highest aspirations. We cannot separate ourselves from any part of human life and when we see images of disease and war and hunger, we must know that it is ourselves and our family who fight and starve and die. Freemasons openly declare their connection to humanity and, therefore, they consciously take on a responsibility to help all those who suffer. Let us determine to do all we can to love our neighbours from every corner of the globe.

December 27

Fire, and hail; snow, and vapour; stormy wind fulfilling his word: Mountains, and all hills; fruitful trees, and all cedars: Beasts, and all cattle; creeping things, and flying fowl: Kings of the earth, and all people; princes, and all judges of the earth: Both young men, and maidens; old men, and children: Let them praise the name of the LORD:

Psalm 148

If we are to believe in an omnipotent and omnipresent God, we should develop the practice of seeing His presence everywhere and in everything. Omnipresent means everywhere, as we know, but if we stop to consider deeply the meaning of the word and the implications of the idea, we begin to see the truth that what we call God is immanent - literally dwelling within - in every atom of creation.

That means that God is in every creature, from the smallest to the largest; in every plant and flower and tree; in every drop of water, every grain of sand; in the wind and the rain; in sunshine, in the clouds...everywhere.

And it also means that God is in every one of us. It means that when we look at ourselves or at each other, we need to see a manifestation of the divine, as close to us and as much part of us as our own heartbeat.

Nothing less will do because nothing else reflects the truth.

December 28

...and may He continue to preserve our order by beautifying and adorning us with every moral and social virtue.

Closing Ceremony

The reputation of Freemasonry, the power it has to be a force for good in the world, even its very existence is in the hands of every Freemason. If we are to be open about our membership of the Order, we must also accept the responsibility to be its ambassadors. It is far easier, of course, to keep silent and only own to being a Mason among other Masons. But what message does that give to the world, to our families and even to our inner selves? That we are ashamed of what we profess to admire? That Masonry has no value beyond being a self-serving clique?

If we truly believe that Freemasonry has any worth in the world, we must also believe that we are of worth to Freemasonry. The ritual makes it clear here that the survival of the Order is inextricably linked with the behaviour of every Mason. It is by our demonstration of 'every moral and social virtue' that the Craft will be preserved. Let us continue to pray daily that we may be so 'beautified and adorned.'

December 29

To execute upon them the judgment written: this honour have all his saints. Praise ye the LORD.

Psalm 149

Sometimes we have to be willing to submit and, although Freemasons are often doers as well as thinkers, there are times when we simply have to admit that we are not in control of what is happening to us or around us and we have to accept that a higher power has us in hand.

Being believers, Freemasons can find comfort in this kind of surrender and, indeed, it may be argued that the greater our level of surrender, the greater our inner peace. However, we must also remember that, while we may not be able to control events and circumstances, we are always, if we so choose, able to control our reaction to what happens to us. This gives us a great deal of power over our own feelings and behaviour and allows us to be in control of ourselves at least, and maintain that faultless centre sought and understood by all Master Masons.

Thus we learn to be at peace with all that the world throws our way, maintaining a due balance between emotional extremes, always understanding that between those extremes there are still waters and green pastures of inner peace, the logical outcome of our unshaken belief in the wise dispensation of divine providence.

December 30

Sing unto God, sing praises to his name: extol him that rideth upon the heavens by his name JAH, and rejoice before him.'

Psalm 68:4

Ultimately, all the paths of this life lead us to one place, a place where every Freemason has – emblematically, at least – already been: the grave. Our time on Earth is so short, this life is so sweet for those of us lucky enough to have known love and to have had the time to appreciate the natural beauty that surrounds us. What else can we do but let our hearts sing the praises of our Creator? How else can we prevent them bursting with the joy that fills us when we contemplate all that makes us human?

For all its troubles and disappointments, all its suffering and injustices, this life still holds the possibility of happiness and peace. Sometimes we would do well to remember this and simply go out into the world to share our joy and our appreciation for what we have and what we know to be true.

December 31

Let every thing that hath breath praise the LORD. Praise ye the LORD.

Psalm 150

Ultimately, there isn't anything else. It all comes down to that one last moment where we stand alone before our Creator and face the single moment of certainty that has been with us all of our lives: death.

This is what we are preparing for in every moment that we live. It's what we are doing in every small act of selflessness, in every act of kindness, in every moment of giving and in every step we take to try to be the very best we can. It's what we are preparing for in every moment of laughter and joy that we share with friends and family; it is what we are preparing for every time we are overcome with gratitude for all of our blessings and for the beauty of the world.

This final moment: to stand before our maker, with a conscience, devoid of shame, secure in the knowledge that, "... to the just and virtuous man, death has no terrors equal to the stain of falsehood and dishonour..." This is the purpose and aim of life: to live well and to die content, knowing we have done our best.

It sounds easy, but the truth is that it takes a lifetime of preparation to do it right and, given that we don't know how long we have, it's always better to start now. In every moment. With every breath.

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Happy New Year!

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